Anonymized interview transcripts analyzed in *Unpacking the experiences of felt understanding and its relation to social identities: A qualitative study among international students*

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I: Interviewer
P: Participant

Interview 01
I: Yeah I will start with kind of basic questions. So could you tell me a bit about your motivation for coming to the UK for study? Like why you would want to be in the UK?
P: Yeah and it's mainly because I want to study [a course]. At home I don't have that chance to study it, because the competition is too high. I want to improve my English speaking skills as well, so I come to England. Also my mum wanted me to like become more independence, like back home I live with my family, so I don't really have much chance to take care of myself. But in England, I have to take care of myself.
I: Okay got that. And before you came here, do you have any expectations of what your study and life will be in the UK?
P: Yeah I do some preparation so it is much like the same. And the life in England is kind of the same as what I expected, but there are more people from home than I expected, but yeah others the same.
I: Okay, so you said you did some preparation for the course, so the course is [].
I: Okay so were there anything you find difficult to cope with or do you face any challenges?
P: I think language is the biggest challenge, because I say that -- like I just use English to communicate sometimes which is in the lessons and that is necessary. But [back home] I just use [home language] to speak with others. But um yeah in here, I need to get used to speaking English so is the most difficult part.
I: yeah so that's the language barrier right?
P: Yeah.
I: Yeah and do you find like anything you think is easy to cope with or any positive side of your life and study here?
P: I like the fact that there are so many societies, so I can choose whatever I want to join. And the people are friendly here, so they, I mean, most of them don't really care if my English is not very good and yeah. And I don't really face any discrimination here, which is good.
I: Okay, then, did you register with any of the society?
P: And yeah, I joined [Society A], [Society B] and [Society C].
I: Okay yeah then do you have like social activities or any other events very often?
P: Yeah I was a committee member, so I host weekly sessions in our society.
I: So you know some new people from the society right?

P: Yeah.
I: Yeah and then, and when you are here, do you know also, like, your previous friends also came here to study or you just don't know any people here?
P: Um at first like I have many friends who come UK to study, but they're in different cities, so yeah we can just talk via phone instead of face to face, that is good, actually. But like I said, I have someone to talk with and yeah. And last year, which is my first year. And so my flatmates are people [from home country], and yeah we communicate very well and get along well, so yeah it definitely help me to adapt to life here.
I: Yeah and I wonder like during your study and the life here, do you have any specific experience of feeling you are understood or misunderstood by others? Like a certain situation?
P: Um sometimes, because now I move to a private student accommodation, and my flatmates are all locals, and sometimes they're like misunderstood what I said because of my accent. But yeah I'll try some explanations, we can communicate between us, too, so yeah. But this happens.
I: yeah okay yeah so you're talking about some local friend who sometimes misunderstood you because of accent.
P: yeah and I sometimes misunderstood them as well so.
I: Okay, and then because of what?
P: Sometimes it's because of accent, sometimes I have limited vocabulary, and sometimes yeah they speak too fast. I think, mainly because I don't have much vocabulary, so I can't understand what they say.
I: Okay, and can you think of one like particular thing happened when you feel misunderstood by your local friends?
P: Sometimes when I talk with one of them, and the talk goes well. But when there are more than one, they chat in a group and they always speak quite fast, and there are some vocabularies that I don't really understand, but yeah I can't stop them and ask what is that mean because, like this will interrupt their chatting so yeah.
I: yeah it's kind of a bit like awkward to stop the conversation. And like, can you think of any time like they misunderstood you?
P: Before I said, there are some worms on the leaves in my room, and I was like very scared of it. And then after I clean them and tell these funny things to my flatmates and I pronounce 'room in worm' instead, because I don't know -- don't really understand the difference and they misunderstood.
I: Okay, so that's basically the difference between room and the worm right?
P: Yeah.
I: okay yeah and like, how do you feel like when you found 'they get me wrong' or 'they just don't understand what I'm talking about?
P: Um actually I don't understand why they don't understand, because I thought I pronounce it correctly. After that day, I finally understand what is the difference.
I: Okay, so there was a bit of delay.
P: yeah yeah.
I: And like so, at that time, you just let the conversation just go, and after that you kind of know why.

P: Right yeah. yeah exactly.
I: yeah and how do you feel like when you suddenly got what was happening there?
P: yeah it's like 'oh that's what I always like mispronounce', but I'm glad that they pointed out, because I won't pronounce it wrong again.
I: Yeah and does these like event influence, have any influence on your relationships with your local friends or your flatmates?
P: Um not really, no. Because I think they have some expectation of me, like not very good at English, so they just like friendly point it out when I speak something wrong.
I: Would you attribute it as a randomly just happened event or you will think this is kind of a barrier between local and international people?
P: I think it's just randomly happened because of me who pronounce it wrong so.
I: Okay yeah so okay. And I wonder you've said before, you didn't really experience any discrimination here right?
P: Yeah.
I: So have you ever feel like you are unequally treated because of your language or accent?
P: I don't think so.
I: Okay. So could you tell me a particular event that happened?
P: Um I was recruited as a temporary teaching assistant in the uni with two other students who is one local student and one international student so. So I think yeah we are equally treated.
I: Okay, so you think you are equally treated. Okay, do you think, like the language or accent play a really important role when someone is included in a certain group of people or excluded by a certain group of people?
P: Um I think languages is very important when like in terms of communication with others.
I: Yeah and how do you think about the accent , the different accent among like people from different countries.
P: Different accent is not really matters, as long as we pronounce something correctly, like yeah.
I: Okay, did you think that accent is not really important before you come to the UK?
P: Yeah.
I: Okay yeah so, then I wonder, did you have like any friends or people who are close to you, they feel like they are excluded or included because of language or accent?
P: Um yeah but they are not studying in this uni.
I: No worry, as long as it's in the UK, that's fine.
P: Yeah yeah and he also came from [participant's home country] and he just feel isolated and don't have many friends.
I: Because of the communication problem?
P: Yeah kind of and also maybe his personality is not that outgoing, so he don't have many friends and he also doesn't join any societies.
I: Okay yeah. And then, how do you think, do you feel comfortable when you communicate with others in English?
P: Not really.

I: Okay, so why?
P: Because I have limited vocabulary, so I can’t really like choose the correct words to like express what I want to say. And also, maybe my grammar is not very good. So it's a bit hard to communicate in English, but it's not too hard that I am afraid of it.
I: Okay, then, did you have any group project during the time you study here?
P: Yeah yeah.
I: Yeah then like. How do you feel when you communicate with other group members, with either local or other country students?
P: And I actually think it’s a good experience because they have different personalities with us. Like [back home] we don't really express ourselves in front of the teachers, and don't really like to raise our hands answer questions. But people who from Western education they're more willing to express their own feeling. So yeah and actually it changed me a bit as well, so I think it’s actually a good experience.
I: Okay, so do you think it changed you in the way that you are being more active?
P: Yeah I think so.
I: Okay, and then do you have any difficulties when you doing the group assignments together?
P: Um actually surprisingly not really. I don't face much difficulties like communicate with my group mates regarding the group projects. Instead, I faced some difficulties when communicate with -- like daily conversation.
I: Okay, could you give me an example?
P: For example, I don't really know the vocabulary of clothing, like yeah, the difference between different clothes so yeah.
I: Okay yeah so some words we don't really learn the textbook, but it appears in daily life right?
P: Yeah, in textbook we just learn some very difficult words that don’t really use in daily conversation.
I: Yeah that's true and does this bothers you when you communicate with the staff in the store?
P: No, just with my friends.
I: And then, how do you like figure out which word you should use for like certain type of clothes?
P: Several times say like when they said skirts, I don't really know what’s that, and I thought it’s shirts, because they are kind of similar in pronunciation. And then, after they point out which part of clothes is skirts and I remember. And also thinking of like searching dictionary of some -- how to pronounce some clothes so yeah.
I: Okay, so basically they will help you by like pointing out and also you can just like search by yourself. So yeah that's a really like important part in daily life. And so we talked about lots of things that happened in the uni and I would also like to know about like your daily life, out of uni, in the shops, or whatever place, do you think like language or accent is a big thing?
P: I don't think so. Yeah because in the shops, we don't really -- like we just say a little bit things, like ‘I want this and this to be paid and paid by what’ so yeah we don’t really communicate much actually.

I: Okay yeah. So yeah we've talked about like your experience of feeling understood and misunderstood, also a bit about the language barrier, and how do you think these experiences reflect your overall experiences here in the UK?
P: I think pretty much like -- I actually enjoy studying here, because the societies and people are friendly. And the language barrier is just a little bit thing that I need to work with, like I need to work on so yeah.
I: How do you think it plays a role in shaping your life here?
P: Um pretty much because, because I think communication with others, is a big thing here, so maybe language barrier and understood or misunderstood by others is really important.
I: Yeah okay. I wonder, will the conversation be different between you're talking to your friend from home and your local friend here?
P: Um yeah actually. Because I talk more about my personal things with my friends from [home], because they are like, my closest friends here. I don't know if it is because the language or they share the same life experience that I live [back home], so they have more common things with me, so they can be my closest friends. With local friends, we can also talk the personal things but it's different because we don't have that much common things here. So yeah actually it’s quite different.
I: Okay, so that's a bit about the common background and the common culture.
P: Yeah.

Interview 02
I: Okay, so the first question, I'm really interested in what's your motivation to come to here in the UK for study.
P: Practical reasons, I was doing research back home but the status was not being appropriately paid back home, so I moved to the UK because of financial reasons, and because research is recognized professions. And, of course, there is the reputation part, good uni, Russell group, and so on and so forth.
I: Okay yeah then do you get funded here for your research?
P: Yes, I receive stipend. It's a not great, but it's better than what I was getting back home.
I: And do you have any expectations of your life here before you came?
P: Before that I was in London for study, which was a radically different. In London, you can afford having a small group of people that are like minded, you speak the same language, you have the same set of values. In [a city in the south of England] it's demographically very different, and it's yet predominantly white British. So I have felt a bit of yeah exclusion and not finding like-minded people. The expectation was to find something similar to London. And yeah this has probably been the case if that make sense.
I: Yeah yeah. London is more diverse. Then, how do you think your life here in the UK, compared to your life in your home country?
P: In Greece, I had the sense of belonging to a community, but I could not get properly reimbursed for my services research I was -- so there is a certain sense of having a social life back home and having a professional life in the UK. And there is a

very clear distinction in my mind that in the UK, I can sort of follow my passion, follow my dreams, and while I'm appropriately compensated, at the same time, research and professional culture is better in the UK, however, socially it's not good, as compared back home.
I: So you have mentioned that you feel like social life here is a bit like different in your home country or it's a bit difficult for you?
P: Yeah definitely difficult and it's made a big impact on my studies and my mood and so on. I don't know if it's relevant but the remote working part is also a big thing, I don't know if that's what you're looking into. But like UK wise is more difficult. Yeah let me know what you'd like to share more what.
I: More is better, yeah just please tell me more about your feeling.
P: Yeah yes sure so. What exactly would you be interested in?
I: Was there like a particular part of the social life, you think is difficult or different?
P: Sure. So there is a certain degree of having rituals in the workplace right, so you have the lunch break, you have the Friday night out. These things in London, which was also -- I was not at home in London, but because of the multicultural aspect, these things went down much easier. In [a city in the south of England] I don't really have much to talk about, the popular kind of references that people make, I don't get them, I cannot be, you know cannot make humour. I cannot crack jokes. This has led to me turning down social events, because I'm like, even if I show up, what's the point you know, just the exchange niceties after a certain point of the social event, I won't be able to participate in the -- what they call banter because I don't really know the language. I mean I do know the language, but I know in academic form of language, it's a form of language that's good enough to produce research, but not good enough to like be properly considered part of the society. I might be exaggerating things, but that has been my impression in [a city in the south of England]. In London it's very different.
I: Okay, like why in London is different?
P: In London it's different because the native people are also equally alienated. There's a lot of groups of say Asian people, European people, African people, America people, English people and there's a lot of clusters that mingle and there's a prior acceptance let's say or there's a prior willingness to engage in cultural exchange and so forth. Of course it's also quite British heavy in London, but in [a city in the south of England] is a whole other thing.
I: Yeah okay so like London is like more diverse, people are willing to engage to know, like a different culture or different language and they kind of allow the space for people from like different place to -- in terms of language yeah. But here is like more like single dominant group.
P: Yeah exactly.
I: Okay yeah and then do you still have any connections or friends with the people who used to work with you in London or your friends in London?
P: Yeah yeah I do. I travel once a month, once every two months or so, to visit.
I: Yeah so are they also British or they are the people from your home country?
P: They are the people from the home and other countries. Not British.

I: Okay yeah. Then, do you have like any people here in the UK that you know them back home or from the old time?
P: No, no, none.
I: Okay, and after you come to [a city in the south of England] , do you have any new connections.
P: By connections you mean like proper social connections, not professional right?
I: Social connections yeah.
P: I have one good friend that – she's British, so -- but the other I would, it's a bit strict, but I would call the other people that interact acquaintances.
I: Yeah okay that makes sense, so I think it would be the difference in 'can I talked to this person with personal problems or it's just like superficial conversation', is that right?
P: Exactly exactly yeah, that's exactly right. After a certain point of talking about the weather or talking about the day to day things, I feel like there's a barrier. There's like a very certain set of things that I can comfortably talk with most people, but particularly in [a city in the south of England], I can only, you know qualified talk to one person.
I: Okay yeah. Do you feel like this barrier is because of language or it's because of the like the common culture or common background behind you or anything else?
P: That's a good question. A lot of it is personal reasons, but then again personal reasons are also social and political and so on. Like I wasn't in a good place when I moved, I was a bit burnt out, I was low in mood, so I wasn't getting out, I wasn't trying out new things or like getting out of my comfort zone to go to social as well. So there was a lot of self-inflicted let's say social exclusion, but again when I start feeling a bit better and going out, this sort of structural barrier, language is different, cultural references are different, they started to come into play. And then, even if I -- even when I was sort of able to try out social things, I wasn't really able to click with people, feel at ease and at home because of language. And then because of a certain kind of language that's not spoken from 9 to 5 if that makes sense, so when Friday nights out or like a weekend city breaks with colleges and so on, so it's another thing -- in my mind it's another English language. It's like different phrases, different references, different way of approaching, and talking about things, so this definitely -- this was not the sole reason but it definitely played the part.
I: Yeah Okay, so you talked about like first it's about whether you want to step out of the comfort zone, and then after you stepping out there will be other like difficulties coming out. Do you mentioned about like social exclusion, could you tell me a bit more or was there a particular event like you feel you are excluded by the group?
P: In [a city in the south of England] at large, not in uni, there has been incidents like, I go -- I take the bus, I sit someplace, and because I like look different and I speak differently. You know there's like four bus seats in a particular seat, and I sit at one of them and then people literally walk away. Because I kind of look different and I kind of behave different. And there was another incident someone was trying to -- someone was kind of drunk and was trying to talk to me at night. And I responded in my Greek accent, in a very non English way, and then they started kind of a racist banter and I

just walked away. So yeah there was another thing -- but these are like few and far between but they give the atmosphere for like sort of -- I hadn't experienced anything similar in London or Greece So they were quite striking.
I: Yeah yeah I can get it. Then do you think like the experiences you just described are discrimination?
P: They are a form of -- You have to know the word discrimination I mean definitely. I'm allowed to go places, I'm allowed to participate in society at large, like legally, of course, but there is a certain in places atmosphere, let's say that, not necessarily, I mean yeah this particular -- yeah that have been -- no I can't sugarcoat, yeah there have been discrimination yeah. They're not the rule but it's more common to say like subtle signs that people avoid looking at me when I speak loudly in the Greek accent, like people cross the street, then it starts -- these are more, there's not exactly discrimination per se, but they are like signs of a sort of subtler thing that spikes up to be proper discrimination [hasn't even been described].
I: Yeah Okay, and then, how do you feel every time you experience the exclusion?
P: I think I'm a bit more used to them by now, but I really don't feel like spending any more time than my funding requires in [a city in the south of England]. I get it that it's a -- for historical reasons I suppose it's very long, English predominant, but I don't want it anymore. So I'll try to either go back home afterwards with better salary than I had back in the day, or try a larger city where it would be more multicultural.
I: Okay yeah. How did you react at the time, like when you facing the exclusion, you just let it pass or do you give any reactions to the person who kind of annoyed you?
P: In the incident that with the drunk person I was responding back. I didn't have any point -- I didn't have any reason not to, because he was coming in my space, there was no violence with none of that, but I can stand up for myself I don't mind. And honestly at this stage if this happened once again I've been thinking about it, and if it happens again I wouldn't mind escalating things, if that make sense. It's getting to a point where it's causing me -- it's not happening a lot, if ever, but if it happens again, I would respond back properly. In other words, when it's more like people just as in the train incident or another incident, while I would just shrug it off like I'm used to this, but if someone like literally tries to come to me with this kind of discourse yeah I'm not taking anything.
I: Okay. And like do you think these incidents have any like impact on you, obviously you said you probably want to go to a bigger city or either go back home, and apart from that, do you think there are any other things, for example, your relationship with like local or other people here?
P: Yeah. Definitely definitely. It's a -- I don't feel a part of the community. The only time I felt part of the community was when I got the -- because I rent a place naturally when I got the letter to vote for the council elections, this is the only time I felt like 'okay, there is, I have a saying, I have a saying in the larger community'. Other than that, partly because of these reasons, partly because of work also being predominantly British people, I don't feel a part of the -- part of [a city in the south of England]. So yeah I guess the short answer would be they definitely have contributed to me feeling a bit outside the zone of belonging if that make sense.

I: Yeah so you have like a bit low sense of belonging to the community here.
P: Yeah definitely.
I: Okay we've talked about exclusion and from now, I would be interested in is there any particular event happened in your life where you feel you are misunderstood by others.
P: In work or outside work?
I: Both daily life or work would be fine.
P: Honestly work it's the norm, like, I tried to convey my research findings in English, which is not my first language. I do -- in my mind I do a good job, however it's never good enough and it's always caused a bit more nuanced, as they say, or have to hone my methods which is, these things again yeah maybe it's about language. So it's very different –it's not intuitive to me that there is a certain set of linguistic habits that people here use a lot and I don't resort to them first thing. But then I started catching up. So in the beginning, especially in the first six months was very difficult for me to convey research findings properly, and I can't do it to appropriate stage even now. So as a sort of compensation, I resort to images or like figures or like tables which do not require much of me getting a proper English words and phrases in place. So misunderstanding that led to horrific events yeah definitely, there was a lot of -- not that they understood something different, but that I was not quite clear, so yeah. Misunderstanding in personal relationships, again I have been very wary with people that I consider friends and being associated in relationships and so on, it hasn't been much. But that's related to like me also growing up in developing character wise personality, was being a different person than I was, say in London or back home. So yeah misunderstanding has been predominantly focused on workplace, while -- oh yeah then again the workplace and lunch breaks, it's the most common way of things proceedings that they tried to convey something, it's rather than being misunderstood, but it's not quite clear when I tried to spell it out. I don't quite succeed and then just drop it all together. Does that make sense.
I: Yeah then, could you describe what happened at that time in detail, the lunch break?
P: There was a lot of political talk, and I wanted to join because I'm interested in politics. And I asked the -- it made – it was striking to me how people are out -- people were fine with political sort of -- the political party members of the [inaudible] is to be the only people that would vote for the upcoming election. And they made the comment about. And then people ask me about how exactly the situation was in Greece. And if we vote in Greece, which was honestly more than an insult like proper offensive. And then I just said something about the English [inaudible], people could get heated very fast and then it goes up. I'm sorry, can you hear me. Where did you lose me?
I: I just lost a bit.
P: Yeah yeah. At the lunch break the colleagues were not really aware of the political situation in Greece and made the assumption that in my mind were offensive. So there was a certain aspect of me trying to get the inside this group and talk about politics with colleagues at lunch break, however, if their remarks, they made it clear in my mind that -- it's not they misunderstood me, they didn't really value my opinion, and

they consider me sort of you know, coming from a country we don't vote. So I just dropped it all together.
I: Did you explain to them?
P: No, not really no. Of course, I told them, of course we vote in Greece. But honestly, there might have been a fair bit assumptions from my part, because even if I spelled it out, they wouldn't really ever understand I think. Because yeah there's yeah I don't know how much I can convey by language, so even if I did try to get into bits and pieces, I don't think it would be that interesting to begin with, because the context was talking about English politics and [inaudible]. So [inaudible] a bit of confidence [inaudible] the discussion and just talk about something completely different.
I: yeah so they are your colleagues right?
P: Yes.
I: yeah do you work with them?
P: Not directly no, just work in the same office.
P: Okay yeah. Then, like will this kind of experience influence how you would interact with them?
P: Oh yeah absolutely absolutely. I feel more comfortable reducing every interaction to professional interaction, like if we talk about statistical software packages that's fine, I can do that. But when it starts getting into more of a grey zone territory, I just retreat.
I: Okay, do you feel like these misunderstanding happened randomly because of a particular person or it's just because of the local groups like UK people?
P: Yeah. I want to be fair, but my direct response would be that’s systematic. So there's a lot of widespread implicit rejections of people that are not English in [a city in the south of England]. So it's not a random thing, it's not some person was ignorant, it's not that some other person was not very appreciative of people that are not English, I feel that it's system. Because [a city in the south of England] is predominantly white British, and this allows that atmosphere to prevail. So yeah definitely I don't think it's random no.
I: But do you think this will happen in London?
P: Definitely not definitely not. It might happen but it would be very looked down upon by other people, it would be very fast rejected by other people. So this would reduce the probability of it happening again in the future.
I: Okay yeah, got that. So we've talked about this understanding and I’m wondering, do you have any experiences of feeling understood by others.
P: I have felt a bit in [a city in the south of England] and in London. In [a city in the south of England] it was this woman that I did last year, and now we're friends, she's British, no issues having a proper communication, I feel like I’m understood, but she's also not representatively British that she feels more at home in France, so we set a certain sense of ennui if that makes sense. So we sort of bonded partly over this. In London I have a good amount of interactions and feeling understood, but yeah not by British people. French people, Greek people in London or Lebanese people, Saudi people, Indian people. In London it's a whole other story there.
I: Okay, then every time when you feel like you are understood by others, do you feel

like they understand your idea right or they can just summarise what you just talk about?
P: huh yeah that's a good question, most of the time, yes and no. But to be fair, I also do not do a perfect job all the time of speaking good English and getting to the point. So I have a degree of responsibility in that regard. Are you interested in particular events of being understood and people summarizing my thinking? Was it be good to you if I remember a certain event?
I: Yeah.
P: There was a particular event, where I was delaying a particular application because I wasn't comfortable with the output and there wasn't confident in claiming the results in public. This was not -- this was there [inaudible] for my supervisors, because I was taking a good two three months to report this particular already completed work, so it has to come to a point of me deciding to have a proper sit down with them and not talk about professional things and talk a bit about how this translates to public and how I am not confident in getting results out that are not fully [inaudible] and, of course, they are not either. And this point was more of – it feels kind of personal because I also talked about wider things like the trajectory of my work here and develop. And this was one of the rare points of me, like explicitly carving out space from a very technical meeting to talk about, not very personal, but kind of personal stuff to my supervisors. And they didn't really understand, but they understood parts of it, so they understood being confident to talk about research findings in public and how they have to be accurate. And yeah I was not like capital 'U' 'Understood', but I was kind of understood.
I: Yeah of course.
P: Yeah in the personal space it's a bit different, I don't know if you're interested in events.
I: Yeah. Of course.
P: So yeah good example would be talking about the life cost and how research is not really paying that well with friends from London that are Indian. And I remember vividly they were trying to motivate me against pursuing a research career, because it doesn't make sense financially. I cannot really talk about these things -- I feel like I cannot talk about these things with people from work or [a city in the south of England] in large, but in London I feel that it was more allowed, and I feel like I was understood to be complaining about feelings like that.
I: Okay, yes, so thank you for sharing that detail with me about the misunderstanding and understanding.

Interview 03
I: Okay, so first I would like to ask every basic question, so what's your motivation for coming to UK for study?
P: The motivation was that I wanted to experience of global culture And then, by coming here, your know, that I could meet up people from a lot of different countries, lots of different backgrounds, and then travel, and explore new countries, regions. So that was one of my main motivation to come here, apart from studying, of course.

I: Okay before you came to the UK, do you have any like expectations of your study or your life here?
P: Yes, so one thing I was a bit of fear or fearful was that maybe I don't understand the language you know. Like it's not -- like I've studied English my whole life. And then, I feel maybe I'm not able to speak as clearly, or maybe if people don't understand me, what if I don't understand what people are saying. So that was a bit of the thing. But other than that, like I knew a few British people before when I was in school during a volunteering program, so I knew like they were very friendly, nice, kind people, so that gave me a bit of a [inaudible] or a motivation 'okay okay, people are nice'. It was not like that I'm coming to a new country and I don't know anyone, I had a few friends, but that was it.
I: Okay yeah. That would be the expectation of the language part, and after you came here do you feel like language is still a barrier or there is problem?
P: I think for general communication like just to speak with someone on a daily basis, it's Okay. But then the problem comes when you are like on social conversations. My social conversations, I mean let's say if you're at a party or at a loud place you know, if people speaking very colloquial, colloquial I mean very local British slangs, then I wouldn't know what that means you know. I'll just have to open my phone, do a Google search 'Okay, at this time, that means…'. So yes, it's not perfect always, but it's okay, you know, like yeah.
I: Okay yeah then, how do you find your study here? Do you have difficulty or it's fine?
P: Study was very easy, I wouldn't say very easy, but I mean the language part of it was easy, and I did manage to get good scores, and everything. So study was nothing, no harm, like, I was very used to citations, references. So study was OK. Was very fortunate with those studies, fine.
I: Yeah that's true. Apart from study, is there anything you find it easy to cope with or any positive side of your life?
P: So apart from the study, obviously one big part of my life is my social life and work as well, so part time work. And I think UK as a culture to work part time is really friendly. Like back home, I would not imagine me working part time you know, just 10 hours 20 hours a week. But this is something of culture, here in the UK, it's very popular and I was lucky enough to find a part time job very soon. So it helped me to sustain my living expenses, as well as, I did not have to ask money from home or parents from back home, and I was able to live on my own independently in the UK. So I think that was a big part. And then working also enabled me to earn enough money to go travel around you know, visit a lot new places in the UK, socialize with friends, because obviously in UK, it can be a bit expensive if you order, like food can be like 15, 20 pounds. So yeah that was pretty helpful and yeah I think that culture, social culture and work culture has also been very impressive in the UK.
I: OK, so the work part is the positive part. So, you mentioned that it's a bit hard for part time job back home, so, is it because of any policies or?
P: Um it's because of the culture. Like people only do full time job, there's no part time job. Either you work for them, or you don't work.

I: Okay so that's the culture thing yeah. Then I wonder like after you came here, do you know any friend from home, from the old time? Or you don't know anyone here when you just arrived.
P: Um no not really. I did not know anyone when I arrived.
I: Okay, then do you have any new friends here?
P: Oh yeah a lot of them. Like before coming here, so I used to post on Facebook asking if there's any other students who are studying the same course, probably staying in the same house or accommodation in the university. So my -- from that way, I made a few good friends. And, of course, when I came to [a city in the south of England] I met more people, not just from my course, but from other courses by participating in different events, different university events, society events and that's how I made my connections.
I: Okay. Can I ask, like the friends are local or from your home country or from different countries?
P: So I would say it's very diverse. Obviously, one part was I could not make many local British friends. One part of the reason for that was there were not many British students in my course. But if I generally say my friends, so my very close friends are from South America. And then I have some of my Asian friends. And then a few British friends as well. But yeah overall it's very diverse, my friend circle you know.
I: Yeah and do you feel these friends are the people you can talk about your personal or private things with?
P: Absolutely. Like this would be my top, go to friends to speak about anything as such, whether be job, life, personal, private, you know everything.
I: Okay, and how do you feel your like your sense of belonging to the uni or to [a city in the south of England] here?
P: So the university as a whole, very good experience. One reason was that the university have offered me a full scholarship to come study here for my degree, so that was, I did not have any financial pressure, and so that was very, you know smooth ride for me. And there's a person, she works a lot with international students from the university, so she helped organise a lot of events, like intercultural meetings. That were really helpful for me to meet other international people, other international students. And then there's another [social event], which is also very helpful to meet new people. And I think this was how I got very attached to university, to the societies, so overall my experience in [a city in the south of England] has been very positive.
I: Okay yeah. Back to what you mentioned before, like when you go to some party or some very careful situation, and the language could be a bit like a difficult when you communicate with others. So I wonder is there any particular like event, you feel like you, are excluded or included because of your language or accent?
P: I wouldn’t say typically excluded, but you know let's say when you go to a pub and there's a local singer singing some songs, and everyone else around you is singing, and you're just there like, I don’t know that song. Sometimes it can be like everyone around you singing, you can do like, I just don't know that song, you know. So, then you just stand there, you just drink, you finishing your drink. Yeah those are the

situations where I felt excluded. Then the included part. It's nice because, like some -- obviously when you look different, you know people approached you sometimes asking ‘oh hi how are you’ like ‘where are you from’, ‘how do you feel in the UK’. So they've been very welcoming in that sense I would say.
I: Okay yeah that's good, and I wonder, have you ever experienced like rejection or ignorance from people, like when you have a conversation because of your language or accent?
P: Actually, no I haven't. I know -- I wouldn't say exactly incident, but my friend said they have. But I think yeah we were just fortunate, because you know, there was no racism, there was no any derogatory comments, there was no yeah. Because, the only public when we go in the trains, public areas, people are quite friendly here in [a city in the south of England] especially. So whatever the meet was you know, people might be a bit you know, there might be a bit of racism and stuff like that, which I would say I’m very fortunate that I haven't faced any personal insult so far.
I: Okay yeah then do you have like friends that they faced this kind of difficulties?
P: Yeah there was one of my friends from [an Asian country], where she was in a shop, just some random English woman was badmouthing her, just asking her like ‘go back to your country’ and stuff like that. That was a very bad experience for her, and then I don't know if it helps you in your research, she had posted about this experience in the Facebook group. So you might still be able to find the post, you know, where she has in detail explained what she went through.
I: Okay yeah yeah that's so bad for her yeah. And do you think language would play a big part in your interaction with others?
P: Very well I think so. Because some of my very close friends here from [an Asian country], and then the thing is sometimes, like, I know that, like we have a very good bond with each other, but then, sometimes we are just not able to communicate with each other. And the only way we talk to each other is to like, some translation app or something you know, but then obviously that like you can do it sometimes, but not every single sentence, you know. And then I obviously don't know sign language, neither does she know sign language, so sometimes it becomes really difficult. But otherwise you know, like I could feel she would become a very close friend of mine, but just because she was born and brought up in [a city in Asia], and her English was not as good, so we could not really like talk to each other, so I think that was a bit of a hassle, but otherwise like very good.
I: Okay, so I don't know whether I understand that right or wrong, so it will be easier for you to like texting in the app?
P: Yeah I think she -- yeah she use translation app as well. I kind of learning Mandarin, but it was really hard so.
I: yeah OK, so texting is easier than speaking or chatting.
P: Yeah.
I: Okay so we've talked about some language things and next, I would be interested in do you have any experiences that you say something or explain something, but the person just don't get your idea or they get your idea very quickly?
P: Ah yes. It's like basically accent comes into the place, where I say something, you

know, my accent, and then they don't understand it, because they just saying differently. Sometimes you don't get what I'm saying, and I have to repeat myself a couple of times before they understand 'Okay, this is what you mean'.
I: Okay, then, could you give me a specific example about that?
P: Let's say, okay, so in UK, in British, they say -- so we say dinner right, when you have your meal in evening or you say supper. In England, they say tea, to have tea. For me tea is like normal tea that I can have all day, it's not dinner for me, you know. But you're in the UK, for some people, not everyone, of course, for some people tea means like dinner. So one of my friend invited me for tea and then, by then, it was quite evening, so I already had my dinner, because I'm just going for tea, I'll feel hungry. I'll just have my dinner and go. But when I went obviously they gave me a lot of food, I was like not hungry, you know. So that was a bit of miscommunication, so which are certain examples like this, I think yeah a lot of local British colloquial I would say.
I: Okay, so the friend invited you are British?
P: Yep.
I: Okay, so they use tea rather than dinner. Okay yeah and so how do you feel at the moment when you see lots of food?
P: I mean I I'm a very hungry guy, so I ate the food, but in the mind I was like, but I did ask you know, why do you say tea when you invited me for dinner. Then he told me we just call it tea, like evening tea. What do you think if they invite you for tea, do you think the drinking tea, or like proper food?
I: I think is drinking tea, rather than food.
P: Exactly.
I: Okay, so after they know that you just have different understanding about tea, how does your friend react?
P: Well, he was surprised, but, for me, next time, anyone asked me for tea, I'm going to ask is it snacks? Where is it? You know, next time would be cautious.
I: OK so. The reason of these kind of things happen, do think it's just because of culture?
P: I think so.
I: Okay, then would this influence on your relationship with the friend who invited you?
P: No not really, doesn't really change my relationship. Just a simple word in different cultures.
I: Okay, then. So when you do some like group assignment within your program, does similar things happen?
P: Yes, so with others, like generally it's fine, but only with one or two most, one of few students who probably, whose English is not as good, then sometimes we struggle with communicating each other. Because every time texting is not helpful, when you're speaking like face to face or less in a zoom call like right now. We cannot really communicate by chat. It will take us like hours to communicate.
I: Okay, so the people who are doing the assignment with you are also from other countries rather than local?

P: Yes.
I: Then, how do you figure out a way to work for you?
P: Sign language, how we just communicate… texting yeah. It's like we open a laptop and then you you like speak like voice translation, basically, so I say something and then she listens and then she says, then I listen.
I: Okay, even though you are both like speaking English.
P: Yes. I speak to the laptop, it translates, and she speaks, it translates back to English.
I: Yeah and is there a particular like things happening, when you do not really expect your partner like understand you but they really got you?
P: Yeah of course. Language or words is only like 40% of how we communicate, so most of it is usually body language and stuff like that.
I: Okay, could you give me an example of the people really get you?
P: Okay, I would say my South American friends. As I said because I know they have the same understanding and same background as me in terms of work, in terms of my childhood upbringing, we just share similar values. Now the similar values could be like let's say, if I say, 'okay let's go for dinner tonight', now there'll be a common understanding that we are not going to a Michelin star restaurant, we go somewhere probably like you know. The basic things, but then of course they said 'Okay, we are going with you'. Your, like, common understanding is quicker to each, there's no differences in opinions and values much. I think that was a very bad example for certain situations like that, where we feel like we have bonded, we really know each other well.
I: Okay, then like, why do you think like your South American friends have like common background or understanding with you, even though you from different like continents and different country?
O: I think the culture of these different places are similar. You know there's more similarities across cultures from both of us rather than me and the British someone, or me and or let's say someone from Hong Kong, would might be a little bit of difference.
I: Okay, so basically it's the South American culture is similar to the culture of your home country.
P: I wouldn't say the entire South American culture, maybe the lifestyle of these three or four people is closer to what lifestyle I have, and I would say the lifestyle choices much, and that's why we could relate to each other.
I: Okay, so it could be that particular person, they have similar lifestyle yeah. So how do you think the experiences we talked about reflect your life here in the UK?
P: Um one particular thing is that, obviously, due to my friendships, I'm able to ask for help when I need, which is most important, being able to ask for help, or look for help, whenever you need it. Like it could be let's say when you're sick, you know, and obviously when you're alone here, I'm just giving an example where I could have just texted my friends, saying 'hey I'm sick, can you bring me some medicines', or 'can you bring me some food'. So I think that is, it has affected my life in the UK.
I: Okay, and how do you think the difficulties you talked about like, the dinner or the pub, they have influence on your life here?

P: Not really, because obviously that's the culture, you have to go to pub to meet new people, to meet your friends. back at home I'll just meet at my home or their friend's home, you know, usually at home visit, or maybe just going to a shopping mall, just eat at a cafe or just watch a movie. But here I think I'm only going to watch a movie once or twice the whole year. Just could be the culture, just could be the choices of people around you that you decide to do certain things and not other things.
I: Okay yeah then, how would you like interact with the local people, the British people?
P: In public train, so let's have you go watch a local football match in the stadium, and when you're going and when you're coming back, you talk to strangers in the trains, I mean not every time, but you know, sometimes, some people are very friendly, so they talk to you. Or during part time work when I'm serving my customers, which are interaction with them talking to them, so then also interact a lot with the local people.
I: Yeah, then you also have local friends right?
P: I do, I do have local friends.
I: Yeah so what would you really like do with your local friend?
P: So with some of them, I just work with them, part-time work. And some of them, they studied on my course, that's how I know them. And others I know them through different events that happen around the university.
I: Okay, so the local friends, do you also like contacted them in your private time?
P: Yes I do I do.

Interview 04
I: OK, so my first question would be very basic one, so what was your motivation for coming to the UK for study?
P: Um, possibly, I would say is a better education system, as well as a better lifestyle. I feel like the way that I was educated in Hong Kong is very stressful as well as it's very spoon feeding. It didn't require a lot of independence studying and was not very and -- I was not enjoying studying, let's say, let's put it in that way, I was not enjoying education at all. But my friends who were studying in the UK for A level back then, they were very -- they were very happy with it, they were enjoying it a lot. And yeah I would say, like in terms of the lifestyle, it's -- it's lot slower here.
I: Okay yeah and then do you have any expectations of your study here before you came to the UK?
P: And I well I didn't really have like expectation, but I didn't have like specific expectations, but I guess what at the back of my mind I knew that how different it would be in a sense. That would be a lot of independence studying, and the environment would be very different, and you know, just in terms of you know how things would work out is going to be very different from home. But yeah I didn't really have like set expectations.
I: Okay, then after you came here, do you find here, like, the education is, like, what you've thought before, like freedom or anything else?
P: You know, I think. Yeah I had a lot of independence and freedom and autonomy in terms of how I plan and schedule my work, and in terms of how things are taught in

the UK, you know. Like, they do like give us a lot of freedom and space to explore into how we want to learn things, what kind of things were interested in and we don't get as much help, like, relative to you know, education, back home, like back in secondary school. So yeah I would say, like I enjoy it a lot, and also, I found it very insightful in a way it actually motivated to me to enjoy education and enjoy studying. And I think like in a sense, the system in the UK, they encourage you to explore into your area of interest, rather than forcing you to do subjects and courses which you do not enjoy. And that is the case back home, which was why I didn't enjoy education, but I think this is the main thing you know, the main takeaway from myself.
I: Okay yeah. During your life here, is there any particular thing you think is difficult to cope with or any challenges you have faced?
P: Um. I-I don't really -- I don't necessarily think, you know, I experienced culture shock, because my upbringing is rather international, and in a sense, I studied at an English school as well, when I was back home. So I didn't face any language barriers, but I would say the slight difference in terms of, you know, the culture to be a little bit different in the sense, you know, like I grew up in a mixture of like Western and Eastern upbringing, whereas like people here they're very Westernised. I suppose it's because the information that they get in the UK is very different from the information that we get. So there's a bit of the gap, if you have to you know talk to them about cultures or even just like, just normal pop culture, let's say, for example, like, it would be very different. At times I didn't understand like what they were saying and, you know, like English speakers they love using slang and it's only like after several times when they use it and I realized like what the slang means. So yeah, it does take time let's say.
I: Okay. Then, when you study here, do you know also some like old friend who also came here to study?
P: Here I've got two or several friends from school who graduated from this university as well.
I: Okay, so did you have a good connection with them during the time?
P: Um yes or no. Yes, in a sense, so when like during the first year when we first arrived, we connected with each other and. Even though you know, like a lot of my friends, we weren't very close to start with, like when we're at school, because we're in different classes. But when we first arrived, we connected and we hung out a lot. But yeah like the second year, because the covid hit, we can't see each other. And third year, you know, we're all like on different routes and different pathways and you know graduating so. I would say the connections, not as deep as the first year, but we do connect with each other, we yeah we do still talk.
I: Okay, then, and then how about the new friends you meet here, do you also have connections with, like societies or other friends?
P: Yeah so um I guess like -- I'll put it this way, half of my friends are Asian, half of my friends are English. And I met them through like my course, my degree, some societies and volunteering, and yeah I still connect with them, like, we still talk a lot. We, well, because everyone graduated, everyone in my year graduated, so most of them have moved home, and some of them like very, very minority of them are still in

[a city in the south of England]. So at times we go out, but mainly at the moment, it's just you know, by online communications.
I: Okay yeah. So how do you feel your, like, sense of belonging to the UK and to [a city in the south of England]?
P: And so I'll start with [a city in the south of England]. I think, after being here, for you know physically being here for a year and a half, I can definitely call it like a home, in a sense, I can always like feel safe and I'll be happy to be back. In terms of like the sense of belonging in the UK, in general, I do have a very great sense of belonging and I do find a very strong link with the UK, because, like as I've mentioned like my home was once a British colony. So yeah. There's a lot of things that I can - I can easily relate to in the UK and that's also a lot of history which I'm not going to cover but yeah, I guess, I would say, I would call like the UK a home as well.
I: Okay. How do you feel the difference when you communicate with others in English back to home and in the UK here? Do you feel there is any difference?
P: Okay, I would say, like in the UK it's rather natural like in order to hold a conversation very easy. And I think, like in the UK everybody has like an accent. But like back home, I still speaking British accent when I - when I go home, but at times it's very hard to like hold a conversation in English or like just simply in this English accent, because people back home, do not understand the accent very well in a sense. They were not brought up here, or you know they've never experience the UK and speaking English in the UK. So I would say it's probably harder to hold a conversation in English and back home. And like even though, like most people like people at our age they're very educated and mostly fluent in English. People who are - who are like several generations back behind, they probably do not speak as much English, so at times I would have to rely on speaking Cantonese.
I: Okay yeah I got that. So back to what you've mentioned a bit earlier, so you said that the pop culture back home and in the UK is like different. Could you give me a specific example about that?
P: And what I mean you know, in terms of difference of pop culture. For example, the pop stars that we know in Hong Kong is probably very different from the pop stars that they know in the UK, what they know is English pop stars and what I know is Cantonese or Mandarin Chinese, Taiwanese pop stars. So you know, when you have to communicate and try to deliver your understanding of pop cultures in the UK, sometimes people do not understand you, because they were not brought up in the same upbringing. So I don't really think I have like a specific example I can bring up, but, yeah generally it's because of you know, the divide between East and the West.
I: Okay, then, do you think is there any event of you feeling misunderstood by others during your time being here?
P: I guess I don't think so, and not necessarily yeah I don't think so. My friends are very nice and even if they - even if they think like there are areas of uncertainties, they would always ask, so that they don't misunderstand me. So yeah I don't think like that was the case yeah.
I: Okay, then I wonder like when you trying to deliver something about the pop

culture you know, but the partner you interacted with not quite get that, what would you do?
P: So I would, I would like slowly explain to them, you know what that culture is all about. And you know, like probably not getting into great details because they probably wouldn't understand, so it's just you know, on the very general level explain to them, you know, what it's all about and how it all started in a while I'm interested in it. But yeah like mostly I would explain like how I am interested in it, because I think, like, it would be quite interested in -- I think English people they are generally very interested in other cultures, so especially like Asian culture, so they would always ask, and I can always explain to them.
I: Okay, so, then I wonder, is there any particular event, do you think you are understood by others very quickly? You feel it 'Okay, they got me'.
P: It's not necessarily an event, but I would say it's like an occasion. So normally like when I do go out with my friends, when we do go out like for food or drinks, for example, if we do go out for Asian food, they do understand it quite a lot, like they will tell us -- they'll tell me that they like this sort of dish, they like this sort of taste. And then when I do bring up or, for example, my friend who brought up with me, you know, like where he travelled and what kind of food he had, I can always relate to it. And when I explained my understanding of that place or the kind of dishes that he had, he would relate to it. So I feel like on that level we connected quite well.
I: Okay. And what do you think would be the reason of these, like, well understanding of each other?
P: Um so I would say, like in general, now that people and, like students in our age, they are very they're very globally aware and they're very culturally aware. And I think, there's a general interest in global culture, so they --I guess like out of interest, they've also done some research or they've looked into it, so they kind of understand you know the position that I'm in, and what I'm talking about which you know -- which explains why we connected.
I: Okay, so the next question would be, will are the things you're doing with your like local British friends and friends from any other countries be different?
P: Um not necessarily. I think especially -- yeah I don't think - I don't think that would necessarily be the case, unless you know there's some certain festive celebrations, which is, you know, wholly developed by a certain nationality or certain ethnicity, and things would probably be a little bit different. But, in general I think like with my friends are all students and graduates, and yeah what we're doing is quite similar, yeah what we enjoy is also quite similar.
I: Okay, could you give me an example about the festivals?
P: So this is not a festival that I went to, but it's - it's a very popular festival in the UK, it's a music festival, and it's a very recent festival and it's something that the locals in here as well. So like, other students like, apart from English they do enjoy it. And I've got friends from home, who went to that festival as well, so yeah music is probably a thing that everybody would enjoy.
I: Okay, then. Does this festival that… You mean you will do something with particular friend, but not others in certain festival, is this the festival you refer to?

P: Oh no no no. I mean, like, for example, like Diwali. Diwali is an Indian festival right? I would say, like I would probably go to Diwali with my Asian friends who are probably like Pakistani or Indian or you know, like southeast Asians. And I think like some English friends, they do enjoy it because, you get a lot of fun there, but yeah like not everyone else would understand what Diwali is, and you know and enjoy that festival just because they do not know what it is. So I think like on that point, that would be the festival, which you know I would go with some of my friends, but not some others, if that makes sense.
I: Okay, then. I can understand that yeah English is not quite a difficulty for you, and I wonder how do you think the language or accent, the role they played in your daily life.
P: For me, so when I first arrived in the UK, when I was in my first year, I already got used to all the accents in the UK and I think - I think sometimes like for for students from home, if they're not fluent in English, and they do have their own accent developed from, you know, the upbringing, or just like speaking Cantonese all the time, so their accent would be a mixture Cantonese and English, and it's always visible and it's very distinct and easily identifiable. I would say, people may feel a bit insecure. I mean like generally speaking people could be insecure because they probably feel like they're not as fluent and they're not familiar enough to communicate and deliver the message. And I think at times, so when I first arrived I spoken an American accent, my friends asked me ‘Did you study in an international school’ or you know, like ‘were you brought up in the States’. And that all kind of into, you know how people think of my upbringing and it does not necessarily influenced my lifestyle, or you know, make any negative impacts, but yeah it, I think, like it does make people think about how you were educated, how you were brought up. And people are quite interested in that too, so people do ask. But generally for me it's not a big issue and. My understanding of, you know, the English language or like slash communication is that as long as you're willing to speak and even if you're speaking a different accent like, people don't really care like, people are still very willing to talk to you. So yeah I think that is how it is.
I: OK and you mentioned like people from your home country may feel insecure if their English is not fluent or have accent. So can you give some examples of what they had faced?
P: So I would say, for example, for some new immigrants from home that I met from church, and so they were telling me that they are not fluent in a sense, they either can't understand what the Brits are speaking about, and like when they have to you know go and pay for something at the till, they could easily miss understand like what, the cashiers talking about, and they can't you know, facilitate that communication. And also, like, I think I mentioned this at the very start of our conversation, which is, slangs. So they don't easily understand slacks. They would either you know, have to ask them to repeat that or ask them for further explanations. Or, they would just be left in the dark. It's not necessarily, you know, they're trying to be rude or you know, but I guess as I said, because they would be insecure so that they're quite afraid to ask because it does seem inferior like when you, when you do ask. So yeah does that

make sense to you.
I: yeah yeah of course yeah. So, apart from what we just talked about, is there anything you want to add about your international students life in the UK?
P: Personally, I would say, like since Covid started, there was quite a lot of like Asian hate around the UK, like not necessarily in [a city in the south of England], but as an international student, like as an Asian student, I do feel like at times there are Asian hate crimes. I personally have not, have I? well I don't think I've experienced any specific things in [a city in the south of England], but I've seen some I've heard some. yeah Like at times like when you're at the grocery stores, people would probably like give you give you a look in a way that you would feel uncomfortable. And I think at this point like at this point of the year, when Covid already started for like two years, that kind of case has already died down a little bit, it was it was like a lot more serious previously but. As an international student I do feel like when people do not understand you or you know, like if you're very new to that place and people have not seen other nationalities or other ethnicities, they would probably be quite curious and. I don't want to put it this way, but you know, sometimes people could be quite rude on purposely. Just because you're different from them and they just want to show you that you know they - they are the locals here, and they are stronger than you, and you know you are immigrants and you don't deserve to be here. Yeah.
I: Okay, so. If you have, could you give example of like people being on purposely like, expressing something rude or behaving rudely?
P: And so, this is what I experienced like walking a high street myself in the daylight, as well as like after the evening, and this is not necessarily rude but deep down, I do feel like it's, it's, it's an issue with race. So you know, like how Chinese or Chinese looking people they always get greeted with 'Ni Hao'. yeah even though, like I speak I speak Mandarin and, and you know I can always say like 'Ni Hao' or 'Ni Hao Ma' back to them. The people who say 'Ni Hao' to me, they are white, they are brown, any sort of people would say like 'Ni Hao' to me. I don't think it's necessarily rude because they're trying to be nice, but, at times, I think people do take it like a joke to [?] all the Chinese looking people as Chinese. And I personally think it's not right because it's not everyone who, who is Chinese and not everyone wants to be associated with being Chinese if that makes sense. Like Koreans don't like to be associated with being Chinese. So it's not necessarily rude, but people are not socially aware.
I: Okay, and considering the Asian hate you mentioned. Can you think of any occasion you could think of it as discrimination?
P: Um so, this did not happen to me, but it happened to a friend of mine from Asian. This happened when Covid first started and he was out clubbing with his friends. So by the time when he left the club he was hit by several men. And they are, I think there are English. And they did, you know, they did expose some racial slurs as well as. From what I know, yeah they hit him and said like 'oh you brought Covid' and this and that. And he was not severely injured, but he was - he was in pain at the time, so that is an example for you.
I: Okay, then like after this, did your friend report to the police or the uni or take any

actions after that?
P: yeah so he reported to the police and I'm not sure if the uni is aware of this but, I think that's how far he could bring it. Like you know there's nothing else he could do as a student. so yeah he did report it to the police.

Interview 05
I: Okay, so the first question would be a very basic one, like what's your motivation for studying in the UK?
P: What's my motivation, um, I have scholarship from our government. And the second is the possible network that I can create here in the UK. And maybe the last is the location. I want to be close to other main, like highly respected universities in Europe for any conference or etc, travel easily. So these are my, to be honest, my main motivations to come to UK for studying.
I: Okay, thank you for that. And before you came to the UK for study, do you have any expectations of what life would be like here or what the study would be like here?
P: To be honest, like of course I had very high expectations. Like, I would say, especially like when I had my friends studied in the UK before. I think Instagram either was like, it was about to getting like popular so that's the reason like we were seeing stuff about UK more and more. And I had also might have the expectation because I participated a couple of education fairs to study in UK, and like the advertisement was very colourful, very shiny, so I think like the PR was very like successfully arranged, so that's the reason. It can make you blind with the -- with the, how can I say, with all of these they provided, so that's just made my have quite high expectations before come to the UK.
I: Yeah and how would you like -- have you ever imagine how your life would be here in the UK before you came?
P: To be honest, before moved to UK, I live several years in Europe, so that's the reason, it wasn't my first experience to live abroad. I was a bit familiar with European culture. So I had like very detailed research before coming to the UK, like from social cultural life to accommodation, to financial issues, everything else. So to be honest, like when I moved here, I wasn't that surprised about, how can I say, the other things which are out of my control, so I just thought that 'okay, this is what happens'. Of course, I would have some like, I had some cultural shock in some issues or I had some problems in my like first time, like first month when I came to UK, but I wouldn't say that I have -- I had very different issues like before coming to UK and after moving there.
I: Okay, so you mentioned that at the beginning of your being here, there was a bit culture shock.
P: Quite a lot yeah. But I can't say it's a kind of like post of culture shock. For example, of course UK is a like developed country, so that's the reason, of course, I would have -- I would say that people are doing some other stuff that we don't have in my home country. Especially recycling was a great culture shock for me, because in my home country, we don't do much recycling. So when I came to UK, I was -- I got fine for particularly for recycling issue, so it was a kind of culture stuff, but of course

there are many positive things I had in the UK when I came here.
I: Okay, and you also mentioned that you have very high expectations of the study here. After you've been here for so long, how do you think -- does it meet your expectations?
P: Difficult question. For language course I would say I had very high expectations, because I just thought that I would prepare myself for IELTS exam. But I found out that like language courses are quite a Trade Centre here, so that's the reason I had some difficulties to motivate myself to go the language courses. Because I just thought that it would be a great experience for me to learn English in the capital of the English Language Centre, so what I found out that like every week we had new students, every week other students are leaving from the classroom. So to be honest, for me, language course experience was not as good as I expected. So that's the reason I used meetup application a lot to improve my English, and sort of the poster language course, so this is my first experience, I would say. For my Master programme, it was beyond my expectations, to be honest, I would say, I had a great time at [a university in London] and I always tell that like it was the best year of me in the UK, because I had chance to go to other universities for conferences, or seminars, workshops etc. And London, there are so many opportunities to improve yourself and expand your social network. For my life in [a city in the south of England], I would say it's very complicated. Because, like first of all, after moving to -- after moving from London to [a city in the south of England], it was a kind of difficult experience at first, because as I told, staying two years in London, I had many opportunities and then moving to [a city in the south of England] is a kind of -- it makes me feel that a bit at first it's a failure to be honest. But then I just realised it [a city in the south of England] relate with a good university actually, so that's there's ‘now I would, I would like motivate myself’. However, because of my social interests, because of the lack of available conferences in the university, and maybe lack of resources, or lack of the hardcopy resources in the university library as well, and we can say Covid definitely. So for these reasons, I like being at [a university in the south of England], but I couldn't say that I had my best [several] years of my life to stay here. So in terms of academic expectations, I will give maybe 5.5 or 6 out of 10 maximum. Not anymore, not anymore.
I: Okay, thank you for sharing all these details, it is quite useful. And I wonder for the whole time you've been here in the UK, is there anything you find difficult to cope with, any challenges you have faced.
P: um I would say, maybe, the most challenges, maybe socialisation, like social circle. In London, I didn't find too many difficulties for social circle, it was quite easy because everyone was like, not everyone, but most of -- a great amount of people are like foreigners, so I suppose it was easy to improve your -- expand your social circle. But in [a city in the south of England], I find quite difficult to socialise with people, that's the reason I used sports club during my university here to socialise with people. Other then, I remember that I was studying all day, going back to home without even saying hi to anyone else all day. So it was very like depressing for some time, until I met my wife, so that's the reason. I would say that in the first semester at [a university

in the south of England], I started to look some flats in London, to be honest, so I just thought that I would go back to London and come to [a city in the south of England], maybe once a month to meet my supervisor. So yeah that's like social -- establish a social circle was a quite a challenge for me, other than I don't recall any kind of challenge for myself.
I: Thank you for that. So after we talking about some challenges, do you find anything that it's easy to cope with or any positive side?
P: Any positive side? I'll say that, because [a city in the south of England] is smaller, so when you, again maybe I speak too much about social circle but because I am an extroverted person, so I don't want -- I don't like spend time by myself. So because the city is small and if you make any friends, it is easy to keep this contact and it's easier to meet often. And for academic environment, I would say I was lucky to meet my supervisor whenever I wanted, so it was a great opportunity for me. So in [a city in the south of England], I think I was lucky enough. How can I say, again, I told you like sports club are very useful to distract myself or for a short amount of time and make some friends from university. I had a couple of friends also like from [inaudible] school so that means we were also meeting time to time, so it was also a nice opportunity or a positive outcome, I would say. Because in London it wasn't quite easy to have regular meetings with people, I would say.
I: Okay, no problem, and then, how do you feel like you belong to [a city in the south of England] compared to you belong to London, like the sense of belonging?
P: Again I think in London, it was much, much, much more easier like. Because in London, I have good contact with [home country] community. I had my friend from South Africa, from Asia, from Europe, US, like South Africa, anywhere else. But when I came [a city in the south of England] again I don't feel that I'm belonging too much to the city. I just found that [a university in the south of England] is not international enough, not as they advertise that 'we are internationals, we are typical internationally', so I think they don't pay too much attention to international students, so that's the reason I don't feel myself very belonging to here, in terms of these internationals issue. Again like maybe I would say [a university in London] is also very, very international. Maybe this is my kind of feedback, if you are advertising that 'we welcome international students', I want to see that you are also protecting the international students' rights. But I had a couple of experiences that my rights are not very actually protected. I just found out that I don't get enough help, as much as some British students helped me, or I get some help from external locals you know.
I: Okay, and could you please give an example of like in what situation you feel like your rights are not protected?
P: For example, in my [exam], I failed, I couldn't pass it. So I was a bit, of course I was very demotivated and that was very like discouraged. When I tried to speak with, for example, like people from the Wellbeing Centre, I would not feel bad to use this word, but they are pretty useless, I would say. I hate when they say that 'did you check this website' or 'did you read this one'. I think I need to speak with someone else, and what I have found that if you approach all students as that they are coming from your background, so English background or European background, you cannot

understand this person very well. So I want to be understood by the wellbeing person, but I didn't -- I wasn't understood, so I stopped seeing them. The same thing also happened for pastoral tutors, I would say. When I called that, I was really depressed, really crying, and I was just got, even 10 minutes, 5 minutes to speak, not anymore. So I just found out that 'Okay, if I was a British student, maybe I will fight more, maybe I will challenge them more'. Because of the fact that I'm international student and I'm a sponsor student, I was quite careful about my actions and my treatment towards these people. I just thought that I would be super careful and super respectful, not to lose my scholarship or not to put myself in a risky situation. So I had very quite difficult time. I found that some people or some departments don't know how to deal with international students I would say.

I: Okay. I'm sorry to hear that. You said you need to be more careful than British locals.

P: Yeah, for these reasons I had to arrange wellbeing sessions from my own country. I'm not understood here, so why should I spend time and make myself angrier or upset. But at the same time, of course, like there are many great people in the university who are trying to help you, ease your stress, or make you feel that they are feeling your problems, etc. Of course, I cannot disregard their encouragement, but you know, maybe because of the human psychology like sometimes you focus too much on negative stuff and you just remember this negativity. So these people make my life a bit more difficult than I wanted to have it.

I: Okay, and when you came to the wellbeing service in the university, was there a particular interaction that makes you feel you are misunderstood?

P: For example, just arranged meetings and I saw the person in wellbeing centre and like when I was speaking, I was asked questions out of context, or I just tried to find the exit and I found myself that diving more and more to the hole you know. So I mean, of course, I cannot remember now specifically what I was asked and what I answered, but I remember that when I wanted to have the wellbeing service again, I was offered the person, and I just found that this was the same person that I spoke before. And I kindly declined to speak with the person again, because there was no point to speak one more time. Maybe I am biased after speaking one person. But I found that also I have friends who are using wellbeing services, they are not very happy about it, I would say.

I: Okay, what do you think is the reason for these thing happens to you when you go to the wellbeing service for help, these kind of repeated, and the communication barriers or problems?

P: I think like I wouldn't say that there was a language barrier, but I would say that maybe, how can I explain, maybe emotional barrier. For example, I'm telling something else in very -- like I am [inaudible]. And reflecting my emotions to the other side. I may not be as powerful as my native language to reflect my emotions to other person. So that's the reason [I felt not understood by the wellbeing centre], maybe they would be more helpful when they speak with a British person, student or from someone else coming English speaking country. I found that my emotions are not understood by the other side, so that's the reason I just thought that 'Okay, there is

no point to like go more and more, like there is no point to spend time'. I just say, maybe emotional barrier, I would say, and yeah that's my that's my case.
I: Okay, so, then you found someone from your home country to help you?
P: Okay, yes.
I: And, did you report these problems to the wellbeing service in the uni or you just cancel the next meeting?
P: To be honest you just made a great point. I found out that maybe again like maybe I'm wrong, but I found that like complaining remains is complaining in the university, so there wasn't any action or there wasn't in the in the response. When I want to complain something else, either it was declined or it wasn't paid attention enough. So I found that very like useless, I will say this thing. For example, this won't be a complain, but university as a whole, I don't find it's quite organised. I needed a desktop during Covid time and my friend from another department got the library desktops that you will use maybe sent to their home. When I wanted the same desktop I was told that you'd go to office and you will study there, and we will not send the desktop to your home. Our department were different, so the outcomes are also very, very like different. It happened the same thing when I applied for tuition fee scholarship because the Covid. I found that like some British students or some international students got, for example, like 6 months, 10 months tuition scholarship. My fieldwork was interrupted. I had to stop -- I had to escape from [fieldwork place] during Covid time in a very very difficult environment. And I just wrote everything else in the application form, they just gave me two months tuition for scholarship. It was so - so - discouraging and so disastrous and these kind of results make me feel really disappointed, you know, because, when I was given 18,000, 19,000 pounds per year, there was no problem, but when I wanted to get some service from that money, I was given so many barriers, I was given so many broker issues, do you understand. Even for example, I got an email about my scholarship problem. I just spoke with the person in charge, I think from finance service or etc. I said that, 'why do you contact me, I am a sponsor student', I said 'I am very stressful right now, why am I doing [inaudible]'. The person said we need to contact your sponsor. 'Okay, have you tried?' 'yes, we send email.' 'why don't you phone them', and they say 'no, we cannot phone them, we just can send email to them'. So I have to phone, I have to call my sponsorship, I have to arrange their communication again between each other. So that's like I found some departments are very useless and I think they don't train good enough. And we are unfortunately, we are suffering because of their lack of experience or lack of help. I'm not sure whether the British students experienced the similar stuff, but as an international student, I didn't like how I was approached, to be honest.
I: Okay yeah it's really sad this thing happened, and like, how do you feel like when you experiencing all these like difficulties or these problems?
P: Again, I'm just saying it because I'm like quite upset about that, at same time I want to like speak in this interview that if I had any chance, I will sue the university. If I had any chance, I will sue the university. But I know that the university's rights are very, very well protected, and I will lose the, like, trial so that's the reason I'm not

doing it. For example, [an academic year during Covid], I wasn't in the country, I wasn't in the country, and I was charged fully, like my tuition fee was paid fully. However, when I want some service from them, I'm not given. I might still want access hardship fund for like proofreading etc, but they but they asked me my last three months banking like bank statement. I'm not going to apply for visa, I'm just like I just want extra funding that I spent maybe over 60,000 pounds for the past years. I mean like, of course, maybe my experiences might sound quite, how can I say, like less than maybe some other people's experiences, but this is what I experienced and I feel very frustrated to the university.

I: Okay, then will these experiences influence how you like, for example, interacting with British locals or with other students when you're here?

P: No, I mean I wouldn't have any problem with the locals, like the locals are quite helpful, locals are quite I think understanding. But at the same time, like maybe because of my, how can I say, I don't want to again like say something, how can I say, wrongly, but because of my skin colour maybe because of my appearance, I wasn't approached very differently. Whenever I just step inside the pub or somewhere else, or some local restaurants, I was approached as British customer you know, I don't have any have any problem with locals I would say.

I: Okay, and when you arrived in the UK, do you also have some old friends from your home country, also they live in the UK or study here?

P: Um, no, no. I had people who study in the UK, but I would just say that maybe like my friend, my friend met me in the airport when I came here first , but it was the end of his study so he just left UK two days later. So I didn't know anyone else when I came here.

I: Okay, so your social network here, it was like mostly built after you arrived, and you also said that you have friends from like almost all over the word and from different countries. How do you feel when you communicate with people also from other countries and British people?

P: Again I don't want to sound very like biased, I don't want to use some stereotypes, but normally I don't consume alcohol due to religious reason. So I was going to pubs and other like places to socialise with people. So I found that socialise in the pubs are quite easy with the international students than with British locals I would say. But outside, I find it quite like challenging as well you know, like so that's the reason, maybe when I like --maybe during daytime, I was socialising with my like [religious] fellows and British local people, but maybe after evening after dinner, I will socialise with international students. I found out that again international students are more tolerant that to speak or understanding your like problems, and I have found Brits like which far more -- maybe like locals, maybe less understanding. For example, maybe when I speak economic crisis with like Greek person, we can understand each other easily. When I tell same thing to the British person, it doesn't make sense too much you know, you understand? Or the same thing also is happening for other human rights issues, terror, politics, sports anything else. So I just think that here's a different developed world, and I think, as long as you are not born here or you're not -- you don't move here early, it is very difficult to be accepted or it is very difficult to be

feeling that you are belonging here.
I: Okay, do you think this is because, like you, sharing more like a common background or you think this is because of like the acceptance from the British locals are not that high?
P: I think there are two things. The first thing I would say again, maybe sharing similar cultural -- not cultural like similar background or being neighbours. After speak a couple of minutes, you can understand whether you are understood or not. If the other person starts to criticise or starts to give some suggestions, it means that he or she cannot understand you're suffering. So that's the reason I just found out when I speak with locals, it's not their impatience or it's not their lack of understanding, but I just find that it is very hard to imagine for themselves to have this kind of problems. Because, like as we always told each other with our friends like most of British people are not very like familiar with the second language or they don't -- so that's the reason they are living in their world, and it is very hard for themselves to understand what other nations suffer problems.
I: Okay yeah and thank you for that. So after we're talking about these, is there any moment you feel ‘Okay, they got me’ or ‘they understand me’ when you living in the UK?
P: I mean, I wouldn't say that, no. Like whenever I say something else, I was like I came across a counterargument or I came up with different suggestions or I will I came up with different offers that don't work. So I think -- I don't say I was quite understood. I don't feel that like. I’m just thinking while I’m speaking with you, I don't think I can recall any moment that I was understood here now.
I: Yeah. So the next question would be do you feel comfortable communicating with others here in English?
P: Yeah. I mean I don't have any problems like, as far as, of course, like I’m not speaking very -- I’m not using a broad range of vocabulary, but I don't have any problems communication with other people. But when I came here first time, I found some difficulties to understand their accent, but after some time I spent more time with British people, so I get used to their accent.
I: Okay, and have you ever experienced excluded or felt other people treat you unequally, because of your speaking or your language or your accent?
P: I don't think so. Again, when I speak with locals or like maybe I would have more communication challenges, because of to understand each other, and I want to keep my pace to reach their level of English, but of course it was quite hard. So I felt like stress and maybe I became more introverted while I speak with them. So I was more in the part of listening side, rather than speaking part side, you know? But I was speaking with international students, I didn't feel anytime that I was excluded because, like there wasn't any kind of exclusion. Yeah we were all belonging to the same circle, I would say.
I: Okay, it's okay to talk to international students in English, and when you talk to, for example, like British, they will also listen to you, try to get your idea?
P: Yeah, they're listening, I wouldn’t have a problem. But I just found out that maybe like especially, I found that they are using too many slangs while they speak, or

language I’m not familiar with quite a lot with this language. Because again because of language course, because of Master, PhD, I’m familiar with the very formal language you know. Although I watch series movies, I still don't understand sometimes what they try to explain. If I felt that, I feel a bit introverted, maybe even leaving the place earlier than I wanted.
I: Okay, we just we have the very last question. How do you think the experiences we just talk about reflecting your overall experiences as an international student?
P: For city, I would say that, like I don't have any problem to live in here, it's a great experience. I love the city, I can even live here until I die. So there is no problem. For the university, I just think that like the most of – the international students mechanisms have to change. Otherwise today I experience this thing, tomorrow other students experience other thing. And maybe I am -- I was too calm but maybe the other students won’t be calm enough. So that’s the reason I don't give a very like positive feedback about the university, I would say, like in terms of the belonging. For being international students. I think -- I wasn't quite unhappy, so I had happy moments as well. But in general, I just felt I’m not quite belonging here in the university, unfortunately. I felt -- I didn't want to feel that but I felt like that. So that’s the reason sometimes I had to consult my British friends, what can I, how can I overcome this problem. I speak the same level of English, but I’m not understood so yeah.

Interview 06
I: Okay, so, first I would like to start with a very basic question. So what was your motivation for studying in the UK?
P: Um there, there were a couple reasons. One was just I’ve studied previously, and I really like the UK. Second it's a good school. Third tuition is so much cheaper than my home country, so I think yeah basically those reasons.
I: Okay. What expectations do you have for either your study here or your life here in the UK before you came here?
P: Um I was pretty open minded. I expected to get good degrees and I expected there to be some personal and potentially academic difficulties. Obviously the pandemic overlapped with my studies here so that definitely was something I didn't expect, but I think I think I was pretty open minded, just really expected to get into school, get it done, and move on.
I: Okay yeah. So you said you expected some like possible difficulties in study. So after you came here, did you really encounter with that?
P: Yeah I’ve encountered for more difficulties. Yes, really more in like life in general than I expected, because, like obviously the pandemic no one expected that. That was very difficult. And then my first year in this PhD, I’ve just had tons of outside difficulties that were unexpected. But academically, it's been. maybe slightly harder than I expected, but not crazy.
I: Yeah and so, do you have any challenges when you either communicate with your colleagues, or in general, like British locals?
P: So that's kind of the interesting thing. it's hard to entirely separate, but I felt a

degree of difficulty interacting with British culture, my first year, far less this year. My peers actually have tended to be international, so I've had a very interesting experience of I have just tons of international friends, and actually I find I find the internationals easier to like communicate and understand me than I find British people, most of the time. Even though I'm American, oddly enough.
I: Okay, then what would you think the reason could be for these like international peers are more understand you?
P: Um I think I think it really comes down to that where the foreigners, and we have that commonality, so there's a lot of shared understandings of like having immigrated on some level, learning a new system. I didn't have to learn a new language, obviously, but quite a few of my peers need, so there's a lot of those sorts of struggles. I think that, and most of my friends would agree that the the British system really is quite -- it's not built to bring other people in in a very welcoming way, for instance, to rent in the private sector, it's quite difficult as an international and as an international student. There's just many hurdles. And then like my tuition is quadrupled than British student or an EU student, or it's doubled, it's one of the two. But there's lots of different barriers built in that make it more difficult to be here as an international than as a British student, so I think I think I think that's a big factor.
I: Okay, then, would you say that the barriers are brought by the system or by like certain group of people?
P: Um well, I would say, I would argue, just in my perspective that like right, it is systemic like it is, it is built by a system, it's built by government, it's also built by university policies. But, I would say, like there is a group of people who are causing that to happen, for instance, like the Brexit voters have affected, roles that affect international students, so I think I think it's connected.
I: Okay, and earlier mentioned that you probably struggle a bit with the British culture at the beginning, and more or less this year. So could you clarify more about that?
P: I think part of it is obviously like moving to a different country, so I expected some cultural things but I had the same -- I speak the same language, I'm a native English speaker, so I just kind of underplayed the differences that lingual can use. Like, it seriously upset me for a while, when people would walk up and say 'alright?', because I couldn't understand what they were meaning, I had to have a friend explained to me that they were asking me if they were -- if I was all right, they were saying like 'hey what's up'. So it was just like tons of little things like I felt like my world was a little slanted. You know you, you speak the same language, you go to a country that has a connection to yours, but then everyone is calling things different things, as simple as like your jumper is what I would call a sweater. So it wasn't like a massive deal but, there. And then it's also like, from my state we're very outgoing, and like friendly, and talkative, and small chatty, and that's not the same here. So so it's just like little things that I found like a bit difficult at times, but it wasn't it wasn't like horrible, it just was an adjustment.
I: Okay, then I wonder when you came here, do you have some like old friends also studying here in the UK?
P: So that is part of what made the first time difficulties, I didn't know anybody. So, I

came just with my husband and I had to totally create a friend group, and then coming back to the UK again, I did change universities and cities. So that was a little tough, but I did have those existing friends from my previous uni.
I: Okay so. Then, like basically your social network are like were built up after you came here right?
P: Yes, it was it was much better, it's just was spread out.
I: Okay, when you are making friends here, are they like from also other countries, and do you also have like British local friend?
P: So my closest friends are internationals also in the PhD, and then I have some like friends, but I put the more likely my acquaintance bubble, and that's where like hilariously enough yeah it's like all British people.
I: Okay, and how do you feel like when you communicate with international friend and a British local friend, would you feel like there is a bit of difference or it's basically the same thing?
P: I think there is a difference because I feel like my international friends come with the awareness that we have quite a big cultural and communicative differences, and so, something I appreciate about them is that they're always seeking to understand. And they're quite aware of this difference, and so it makes it very interesting and easy to make sure that there isn't a miscommunication. And then often with British people, with my British friends I've found that, it seems as if I'm the one doing the majority of the trying to make sure that there isn't a miscommunication due to like cultural differences. Whilst, if there is some awareness, it's our feel like, it's typically been a little more condescending, because of like stupid American stereotypes you know. So that's what I've encountered.
I: Okay, and. Okay, so when you encountered with the stereotype things, how would you react to it?
P: Um it depends on the situation, for instance, if a friend like, has vocal this -- vocalized a stereotype and I feel comfortable I might be, I might be more willing to say, well, that that seems stereotypical, not like really fair, do you know that to be true mean [?]. But generally it just ruffles my feathers a bit, but I try to just keep my mouth shut and move on, and just kind of tell myself that it says more about the person speaking a stereotype than it does really about me.
I: Okay yeah so you attributed to that particular person saying that thing.
P: Yeah the person and the culture.
I: And the culture, the culture, you mean the British culture?
P: The British culture typically. Because that's where I find that stereotype from the most.
I: Okay yeah. And I wonder how would you feel you belong to the UK or [a city in the south of England]?
P: Um yeah it is kind of a complicated, I feel I belong to the international community here quite a while. I feel like this is a place that I have found belonging, but I am very aware that I am not one of this culture, nor do I have belonging to this country, you know I'm on a visa so I'm very aware of the fact that, although this feels home to me and I found belonging, it is with conditions.

I: Okay yeah got that. And so my next question is about whether you have felt misunderstood by others while you being here as an international student?
P: Oh yeah definitely. So touched on that a bit, I know I'm sorry I'm trying to think of like some instances. I know I definitely like -- as easy as like I've definitely said some phrases that just aren't common here. People don't know what to do.
I: Okay, then would clarify more or they just asked you what you mean at that time?
P: Yeah if I if I see like a confused face I'll just like double check and be like 'oh is that not like the phrase here' and I will clarify if I am aware that there's a misunderstanding.
I: Okay, so it's basically about the language, the phrase right?
P: Yeah yeah typically, but I know I know that there are -- I just can't think of examples, right now, but I know there have been like the ways I do things rather than the ways they do things. I just can't really think of one.
I: Okay, so, apart from the language, there are something about the like the the culture or the way of people working?
P: Yeah sorry I just can't…oh yeah, for instance, like I'm far more straightforward, though I am still very polite, so I've just noticed like one of my British friends, she'll really hum and haw about -- she'll dance around an issue rather just than saying hey I'd like to open the window. She'll mention that 'oh it's kind of warm'.
I: Okay.
P: Well you know that that whole situation that's how she'll handle thing, so I've learned to like, listen very carefully once someone seems to make an off-handed comment if they're British, because maybe they're trying to tell me, and so I've just learned to be to continue being a little more assertive, and be like 'oh hey do you want the window open?'.
I: Yeah the direct and indirect way of saying things.
P: Right.
I: Yeah and when you figure out your friend actually want you to like to open the window, then, how do you feel at that time, like you finally figure out?
P: I just feel bad for her have the time. I just wish that she felt like she could just tell me exactly what she wanted when she wanted it. I'm not sure if I if anything it's almost just kind of pity, and so I'm trying to be very aware, so that I can ease her feelings, you know, if she doesn't feel, I can just tell it so ingrained in their culture, not to just say what you want. A lot of the time, so I'm trying to honestly just be kind and put them out of their misery, a bit with that, and not be to direct that they feel uncomfortable, but be direct enough that they don't have to tell me five different ways of what they want. You know what I mean.
I: Yeah okay. So this like definitely have some like impact on how you would interact with this person afterwards right?
P: Yeah I feel like I have to be almost hyper aware of cues that I'm not used to. And it definitely does take like a bit of like emotional effort, but it doesn't bother me. What would bother me is if I miss it, you know, I felt very horrible if I'm not picking up on a cue like that.
I: Yeah definitely yes, and so my next question would be well was there any moment,

like you feel others like ‘they really got me’, ‘they got what I’m thinking’ or ‘they understand what I’m talking about’?
P: Yeah especially like, especially in terms of like British students, like the more that they're around me and the more that we share like life experiences, we can find the similarities, and I can explain to them like why I think the way that I do. And people that I like keep around me, you know they do take an interest, and give enough care to want to understand. So there have been a lot of those moments, and I find them very rewarding and I feel like it gives me mutual moments that I finally understand why they're doing, what they're doing and it's very cool.
I: Okay yeah. My next question would be about the language. So the first one would be, like, will other people treat you differently when they recognize your accent is not like British?
P: Yes, I for quite a long time, and there are there are places in particular too that I’ve just chosen not to speak, if I can avoid it, so I can try to keep my head down a little better, which is kind of a sad thing to admit. But absolutely like the moment that I speak, I do have a pretty bland accent is what I’m often told, and so I’m hoping that I come off as Canadian, so that people won't just initially hate me for being American. So there's a lot of stress about that, but I try to work really hard to, like I can't help where I’m from, so I try to just remind myself like, I try really hard to be a good person, and if someone's going to make a snap judgment because of the way that I sound like, again you don't want to hang out with them, they're not a very nice person. And yeah I’ve definitely gotten looks from people that don't seem kind.
I: Okay, then, do you think this bit plays an important role in your life?
P: Absolutely, because if I didn't sound different, I wouldn't feel different so often, and I feel a little more at home.
I: Yeah. Okay, so when like people kind of treat you differently, because of your accent, would you just trying to think ‘okay it's my problem or it’s their problem’?
P: Oh yeah hundred percent think it's their problem. Kind of what I was saying back there like, if someone judges another person based on the way that they sound, that's their problem, they're not very -- yeah that's their issue, that's not fair.
I: Okay, apart from all of what we talked about, do you think there is any other of your experiences, you want to add to this talk, to this interview which also about your international students life here?
P: Um sorry I’m just trying to think there's something. I think just I, I think my big disappointment, with England, the government, the society is the fact that they voted Brexit, and because it does seem like it has some um racistly charge factors. I think it's also, just very problematic that there's so many different fees, that there's so many different treatments according from your country of origin, because just because you're from whatever country doesn't mean you have the same privilege and access, or that you have the same issues. So I just think for all the talk of inclusivity, and, non-nationalist racist issues, there seems to be quite a lot actually just guised in different ways. So that's not in anyone, any university particularly, but the more I’ve lived here, I’ve just found it kind of ironic that they're quite high and mighty about not being racist or having some problematic elements, and quite often talking about

America’s issues which are full well that they are abundant, but at least we're honest about it, whilst I feel they really like to play the deflection game, and kind of talk the talk and do the bare minimum, to quote make things right, but in reality, I think, just the just the renting laws, you know, really protect some discrimination against internationals speaks another story.
I: Okay. And thank you for adding that. Earlier in this interview, you mentioned British locals and EU nationals, so do you think, like before Brexit and after Brexit, they like performed differently or think they are just kind of similar people from similar countries?
P: Um so about the people, I think that people are the same as they have been I think they've just expose some of their ideologies, through their voting. That that's more what I see.
I: Okay, then, how do you think the difference between British local and EU nationals?
P: Well, I mean just the forefront, especially in the context of Brexit, you know, the British want to think of themselves as a very separate entity, while the people from the EU have a much more community minded perspective, like about countries as well, while Britain really seems like they're trying to preserve the sanctity or whatever their nation.
I: Okay, then when you interact with like some students or friends from EU, do feel -- is there any difference?
P: Oh yeah they're definitely different from British people. They often are not native English speakers and so that brings a really cool and interesting perspective change, because the language of origin that you speak does shape some of your perspectives, which is really cool thing about language. And they just they have different cultures, so I find them just innately different for sure.
I: Okay, so we can conclude this with a final question like. So, for your experience generally, how do you feel America living in the UK?
P: I think that I think I have it a lot easier than a lot of internationals, and I think that that's part of the reason that I’m vocal about some of the issues I see, because I know I have it easier. Most of the time I feel like I’ll get a little job or pushback about being American, but once people get to know me, they're pretty fair about things. But I do find it obnoxious to be American in this culture often especially like during elections, people will literally, if they hear me speak, they'll stop me in the street, to tell me what they think about my country, which I super don’t appreciate. So it's mostly good but they're just moments that I I’d rather not.

Interview 07
I: Okay, so, first I would like to start with a very basic question, so what was your motivation for you to study in the UK.
P: I wouldn't say motivation, but my country's education system is not as good as the education system in other countries, like the UK and the US. So I applied to universities in the United Kingdom and in the United States. I got several offers from several universities, but I choose this university because I have a twin brother and my

twin brother studies here.
I: Okay yeah. So, during your time living here the did you find anything that is particularly difficult to cope with or other challenges you have faced?
P: I would say understanding cultural differences. Because in my country when we greet each other, we usually kiss each other on the right and on the left. So doing this with students from home here seemed quite awkward to everybody from the UK, because it's not something that they're used to, to shake hands every time we meet and then to kiss right and left because -- I would say, people might think we're homosexuals if we did this here in the UK, but it's just a way of greeting each other. I do this to my father, I do this to my uncle, I do this to any member of my family because it's just the greeting way, so I have been misunderstood in the first few periods I'd say. When I arrived to the UK, because it's my first time arriving here in the UK, I haven't experienced this before, and I didn't know that this is how they see it. So yeah that's one thing. Two, I would say, I am a curious person, so I usually ask a few questions. And here in the UK, the more I asked, the more some people think I'm being offensive. Because they have some boundaries and I'm crossing these boundaries. But again in my culture, it is a good thing to ask a lot about other people in their lives, because it's like 'oh we're one community, we help each other, we do whatever for every other person'. But I'm not saying it's not the same here in the UK, because people help each other as well, but they're not as close as people are in my country, so they don't usually ask each other a lot of questions to know more about other people. They find it offensive to some extent, because you can't ask me this, that's something that concerns me only. That's what many people saw when I started asking a few questions.
I: Okay, then I wonder like when you start asking questions, will the people or the person interacting with you perform like awkward, or they will point out this is not quite appropriate here.
P: They don't usually point it out, but it is quite understandable from their reaction, and sometimes if I do something and I see a very odd reaction from the person I'm dealing with, I usually ask somebody else about the situation that happened. And I say that, for example, on this particular date, I said let's go out or something with an intention of having fun, it's just an outing. But the person acted quite awkward because it seemed like an invitation to, I would say, go out on a date for something. But in my country, when I tell someone to go out, it's immediately understood as a friendly outing. That's how I'd say. Yeah that's how it phrases, it's not allowed. So when I say going out it's definitely going out with friends, it's not a date or something else, so they're usually acting odd. And then I asked like yeah, they might have understood that it's a date, so they were acting awkward because you don't even know them, but you just said 'yeah we're going to go out', because I just meant that it's a friendly outing. Nothing else but different cultures, I guess.
I: Okay, so you think it's because of the cultural background is different.
P: Yeah.
I: Okay. Then, how would you react if you find the people -- if the person is awkward? Will you explain what you really mean?

P: Sometimes I do try to explain, but sometimes trying to explain it would make it even more awkward. So I'll try to avoid any explanations and I go with the flow. I act like it's normal.
I: Okay, then what if this have happened between you and your close friend here?
P: I was speaking about my country, because as an international student, people usually ask where I'm from, where my country is located and everything. And I was speaking about some traditions in my country, and again they felt that these traditions are quite awkward as well. So when I reacted towards them, when they thought it's awkward, I just tried to explain how the differences are from a country to another, and how cultures, traditions influence the society in general. So they usually find it very awkward and I don't react awkwardly, but I just try to explain myself as clearly as possible.
I: Yeah then, how do you feel when you're trying to explain yourself?
P: Sometimes I feel upset, because it depends on the subject to be honest. If the subject is quite sensitive, I do feel upset. But if subject is generic and it's just about food, for example, if it's about something very common, then I feel all right, I just try to ensure that the misunderstanding does not develop. I try to make sure that the misunderstanding stays cool. It's just the difference, that's it, but if it's sensitive sometimes I do feel upset and offended.
I: Okay, and the experiences you just described, did this happen between you and a British local, or you and other people from other countries?
P: It happened between me and a British local.
I: And will this awkward experience influence how you would interact with this person afterwards?
P: As the situations get repeated several times, then I will probably be influenced by anything this person says, because I'm gonna realize that everything I say, sound sensitive to them, everything I say does not please them in a way or another, everything I say they find it weird or they find it awkward because of my culture, but it's something I'm proud of, so this might influence how I deal with them. But if someone understands that it's culturally different, and it's just how it is in a country and how it is in another country, then I don't think so, because that's normal, because I've seen things here in the UK that aren't common in my country is odd, and it's just a learning experience that's how I see it, and it's just how their society act towards something, how their culture is being affected by the previous generations, and how they're, I would say, carrying it on to the next generations on and on and on. So it's something that, they have in their culture, and in my country it's something that we have in our culture, and I understand them and they understand me and everything's fine. So I don't act differently towards them later, it's just like a normal topic, as if we're talking about university, and topics in university, but if they act weird and yeah I would probably be careful when I speak with them next time.
I: Okay yeah, and you said your brother is here right? And do you know any like old friend also from your home country they study in the UK?
P: I know many people actually but they're not here. They are in [other UK cities], which are quite far, so we don't usually meet it's probably once in the whole year

because of the living costs thing going back and forth, because it's quite far. Again maybe it is because my country is very small, my country is actually smaller than London. So transferring from an area to another doesn't take more than 30 minutes, but here it's quite far so I don't usually see them.
I: Okay, then, how do you feel like you having your brother also here? Do you feel like this kind of help your get used to here?
P: Initially, yes, because when I came to the UK I didn't know anyone, so it would be very difficult to socialize with others, as the person who just came, because I know, nobody, zero people. So talking with my brother for a few times about the people I've met, about how I'm trying to socialize with others, it did help because I had someone to talk to in the first few days. And then I slowly started making friends, so it did not become a problem because I have my friends the whole time and my friends take the same courses as I do. So we usually meet a lot in every module, in every subject, in lectures, seminars, groups, and so, sometimes I even see them more than my brother. So in the first few days, yes, it did help, but later on, no, because I started having more and more friends, so it didn't become a problem.
I: Okay, so you said you have some new friends after you arrived here. Does your friend also include like both British locals and people from other countries?
P: (Mainly) local friends, because the accommodation I stayed in had a lot of British students and did not have international students probably just one or two. Maybe, because the university has a priority for international students to live in the university halls, but the private accommodations that are not in the university usually have British people, because in the university it's a priority for internationals and outside it's for British locals because British locals are not a priority when it comes to accommodation in the university for international students. But I lived outside university, because I was 17 years old when I came and that was another problem. Yeah so mainly British people, but I do have some international friends as well, from China, from many countries.
I: Okay, then, could you explain more about the problem you just said, when you are here you're 17?
P: In my country, the education system is quite different, so I graduated from school when I was 17. I came to university when I was 17 as well. However, I did not meet any British local person who is 17 years old. Sometimes when British locals know the time 17 they're like 'Oh, are you an international student', because they realize that international students are usually younger because of the education system in their country. But being a 17 year old, I did not have a chance to go to clubs, for the whole year because it's not allowed. I can't buy alcohol because, again I have to be 18 to buy alcohol. I can't participate in some university events, because I have to be 18 plus to attend. Some of them are arranged by big societies like business and finance society, but because the events or in a club, it's not allowed for under 18 to usually go there. And when it comes to accommodation, I did not find proper accommodation because of my age. All of them, I wouldn't say all of them, but most of the accommodations here in [a city in the south of England] said 'you're still young, you're 17, so we can't have you with us'. Even though I'll be the one who's paying, they said 'you're still

under 18 so you're a child, you can't live here in this student accommodation'. And so I faced a lot of problems until I turned 18, but I only turned 18 a few months ago, so it was at the end of my first year. So I just enjoyed being 18 for one month in university, unlike everyone. So sometimes when they go clubbing they're like 'Oh, we feel sorry for you, but it's okay, you can come later when you turn 18', but that's been for like eight months. I've been bullied sometimes when I'm 17, because the locals here, sometimes give me their bag they are like, 'can you hold it for a second' and I'm like 'Yeah of course, I can hold your bag', and then they tell me 'Oh sorry child abuse' and they take it, 'because you're still under 18 so we can't let you do this for us'. So yeah, I was the youngest and that's a problem when it comes to the time to socialize with elder people as well, because some of them were quite sensitive because of the law here in the UK, elder people usually have to be careful when they deal with minors that are under 18. You can't say everything, you can't do everything. I can't just give candy to a guy that is young in the road, because it might be understood in the wrong way. And that's something that also happened to me. I was in Sainsbury, and I had an extra candy with me and I just gave it to the younger kid, because he's like my little brother, I have another little brother. And when I did his mom was like 'what do you want from him'. I'm like nothing, I just gave him candy because I have an extra candy, like it's just being friendly. And then she said, next time, please don't deal with him. And it's because they think I'm an adult, so adults can't just go around giving candy to kids. Here the UK it is quite weird but it's not in my country. So when I did, I told her I'm still a kid too, I'm not even 18, and then she said, 'oh that's all right', and she was fine. So she probably thought that I am older maybe because of the beard. Because she thought it's awkward, but I didn't I thought it's something that's friendly, so that's again being misunderstood, but I don't know. What was I saying before I spoke about the candy incident I forgot.

I: Before the candy, I think you're talking about children abuse or you're not allowed to go to the clubs.

P: Yeah I was talking about clubs and not allowed to go there, what else, yeah being really -- because of the bag and when they said 'you're still a child', child abuse and yeah. I remember that they're sensitive towards 17-year-olds because they're usually careful when they deal with me, especially elder people. I do have 18-year-olds and 19-year-olds with me in the university, but I also have people who are 24 years old, taking same degree with me. So they're like always 'you're 17, we have a five years gap between us, so you're still a child to us'. So I realized they treat me differently when it comes to treating other people. They usually smoke and they have fun with smoke cigarettes when they deal with other 19 or 20 year olds. But when it comes to speaking with me, um they don't usually be as comfortable, as open with me compared to other students. I'm speaking mainly about British locals because internationals are usually young.

I: Yeah okay, it seems like age is a quite a big thing here in the UK and I didn't know about that before.

P: It is, it is. After 18 everything is perfect, but before 18, oh, my f- goodness, sorry for the language.

I: No worries. Okay, so we talked about lots of misunderstanding here. So, will this kind of influence on how you would interact with British local and other international students?
P: I don't think so because at this point, I wouldn't say I fully understood the British culture and what they find offensive, but because of the experiences I've been in, I do understand what should be said and what shouldn't. So when I speak with other British people, or even international students, I'm going to know what to say, so it's not really going to influence how I treat with them. I'm going to act with them normally. But when it comes to the things that they find offensive, yeah I am going to be careful, because I can't just say anything to anyone, especially culturally. Yeah that's it.
I: Yeah okay.
P: I was just saying it depends on the person, because some people, even if they're British people, it doesn't mean that they're very sensitive and they're not open to anything. Sometimes they are as open as I am when it comes to asking questions, knowing more about different cultures, speaking about anything and everything. So yeah it depends on the person, some people are open, some people are not. So if the person is comfortable, yeah I do speak with them, if the person is not I don't. So it's just how the person is, their character really plays a huge role here determining whether I should be speaking the way I am with them. That's it.
I: Okay, so you think like it's more about the person, rather than the group they belong to.
P: True.
I: Okay, then would you treat British local friends and international friends a bit differently?
P: That's a hard question.
[silence]
P: I don't think I would. When it comes to cultures, some cultures find it – very - offensive to do something, and while some cultures don't. It's all about being offensive and harming other. Maybe because I'm trying my best not to make someone feel that I am being harsh towards them or I'm being mean towards them. So I'm careful when it comes to language and speaking to them. But I wouldn't really treat them differently, because I'd be careful when it comes to my language with both. So again, it depends on the person really that I'm dealing with, because, again as you mentioned earlier, you mentioned a statement that I strongly agree with, that it's about the person and not the group they belong to, because every group has an outlier and a lot of British people are outliers when it comes to sensitivity, when it comes to understanding, when it comes to being open to others, basically. And a lot of international students are outliers as well because international students, as far as I've dealt with, usually try to socialize with other international students, because they're from the same group, similar culture, similar areas probably, they might even know each other back from their country if they're from the same area. But the UK students, as British locals are not as familiar with people from the same country, so people from the same country and that's my country as well, usually tend to be closer to each other.

So I treat them differently in terms of being close with them if they're from my country. But if they're internationals and British students, then I just treat them the way they treat me, I would say, because it's depending on the person. That's it.
I: Okay yeah. So talk about misunderstanding, I wonder, is there any moment, like you feel the person you're interacting with, they really got your idea and they really understand what you are talking about.
P: Sometimes they understand it fully and they interact with me on the basis that they understood everything, but sometimes they don't, and they find what I said or what I did means to create problems. For example, the timings I eat and the timings I sleep as well. Because in my country we usually stay late, we have shops open to 1am, 2am, 3am. But in the UK everything closes at 6pm. So when I say I usually stay very late because I'm used to it, they are like 'that's weird, that's creepy staying up till 1am, 2am or 3am'. But I don't find it creepy. I find it usual because it's what I do in my country with my friends. Because we have a lot of shops that are open, but here, for example, Sainsbury's and the rest, Iceland, Poundland, 7pm, 6pm, 8pm maximum everything's closed. So when I say that I stay up late, [a house mate] are like 'that's creepy'. When I eat after their usual times, sometimes I eat dinner at 11 or I eat dinner at 10, '10, 11 that's sleeping time'. So eating dinner at 11 would be very awkward, so they find this very unusual as well. So it's just every scenario is awkward, so there has been some tension built up. When it comes to my eating time, 'oh you're eating now', I'm like 'yeah', that's awkward. When it comes to sleeping time, 'oh you're still awake up till 11pm', that's awkward. So awkward awkward awkward awkward in every scenario. So there has been some tension and now we treat each other differently. But when it comes to [a friend], he is quite understanding. He explained to me 'British people act like this because blah blah blah', and then I tell him 'Oh, [home country] people act like this because blah blah blah', so we explained the cultural differences and it's completely fine, so nothing changed. But with [a house mate] and with other British people like [a house mate], that find things usually awkward and misunderstand me several times, yeah things usually change and the way we treat each other does change.
I: Yeah so would you treat, for example, [a house mate] more carefully?
P: Yeah I would be very formal with [a house mate].
I: Okay yeah. Thank you for all the experiences you shared about misunderstanding and the next question would be, so, what is your first language?
P: I would say two languages are my first language. Because at school, we used to study separate subjects with two languages, and I graduated from school using [mother tongue]. And English as a first language and I've been also classified as a native speaker. So in both languages, I am having them as the first language, even at home, I speak with my parents in [mother tongue] sometimes, in English sometimes. Because my country was colonized by Britain at some point, so we started learning English in schools the whole time, private schools, not government schools. So because I studied in a private school, I studied both languages alongside each other, [mother tongue] and English, in several subjects. So I grew understanding both languages equally and having a similar level in both languages, so they're both my

first language yeah.
I: Okay, so you are comfortable communicating with others in English right?
P: Yeah.
I: Okay, and I wonder like, so when some people recognize maybe your accent or the word choices which is different from maybe how the British would say. So do you have any experience like this?
P: In the first few periods, as in the first few weeks, I used to talk in an American accent, as in when I say some words like ‘words’ I pronounce the letter ‘R’. But when I speak with British locals, I usually speak ‘words’ but without the ‘R’, I say ‘words’, ‘if I speak with you I use different words’. So I tried to change my accent when I speak with British people as a means of respect really, because that's how they speak here. But not everybody agrees with me when it comes to seeing this as a means of respected. I’ll be like something norm, I do speaking in American accent, usually, while with British people speak in a British accent and I don't find a problem with that, because it's not as hard, it's normal to me. So I still prefer speaking in an American accent because back in my country, we used to speaking in American accent the whole time. But I’m still trying my best to speak in a British accent because I want to learn about at the same time. So some of them, some of the British locals did spot some of the words that are usually said in an American accent, and they told me, some of them said, ‘Are you American?’, and I’m like ‘No I’m not. Do I look American? No, I’m not American at all’. But I speaking in American accent because of my country, and how I’ve been taught, because the education system differs from a school to another, and my school was teaching us, I would say in an American system yeah. And we had some American teachers as well, so it did influence my accent, but then I started talking in a British accent the whole time, especially because I’ve been here for a whole year now. So it's not an issue, but only in the first few days, weeks, I spoken in American accent, and it was a problem. That's it.
I: Okay, then, have you ever been treated differently or unequally because of the accent or language here?
P: I don't think so, no. Maybe because I’m an international student. British locals usually prefer having their own friend groups, usually hanging out with each other, going to each other's homes, back in their cities like London, going to each other's homes, but that's understandable because all of them are British locals and they are used to each other. And as an international student I don't interact with them, as much as they do with each other, because they used to live with each other as well. I used to live in a studio alone, so this acted as another barrier, because socializing with British people here with me in the accommodation wasn't as common with them socializing with each other, because they're in the same flats, they are in the same block, they're sharing rooms, they're sharing facilities, so they interact more, and they're also from the same country, same culture and everything, so this just makes them interact more and more. When I’m in a different block in a studio alone, so I didn't have a chance to interact much, but I always go to their kitchens and stay with them. And because I was 17 they used to say, ‘oh if you ever been lonely or everything always come to us, and

we welcome you anytime, if we have prez we will tell you'. And we had a group chat on snapchat so they usually write a message, 'oh we have pre party drinks in this flat, you're welcome to come', so they were friendly with me, so I used to go there, whenever there is an event or something. But when it comes to socializing, it was a difficulty a bit because of being an international student. But it would go the same way, just like British people are close with each other, they interact more with each other, international students are as such. Because, as an international student, I interact more and more with international students, probably because of some cultural similarities, where we understand each other more, we know which situations we're being kept in, because we've been through the same experience. So yeah. it's the same way with the internationals so it's good.
I: Okay, and yeah so that's pretty much of my questions, and, at the end, I wonder, is there any experiences you feel like is relating to your life here, and you want to add.
P: I wouldn't say experience it. I look a bit like Pakistani people. And because my facial features look like them, some group of younger kids called me 'Paki', which is a slur, or a bad word that is being said to people who are from Pakistan. It's offensive to them, offensive to their culture, offensive to their traditions. I wasn't Pakistani so it wasn't a problem to me, but if I was Pakistani, I would have been offended a lot, because saying this to me is not okay. And it's obviously not allowed as well, even in the UK, if you complain about someone saying this to you, then they will be punished, I assume, I'm not sure, but I assume they will be punished because it's still an offensive word to say, so it's offending somebody else. Yeah so it wasn't really touching on my culture or my country, but if I was from another country then yeah, it would have been offensive.
P: Another thing -- because of my home country have a reputation of being rich, to some extent. A lot of people here in UK were treating me differently, like 'oh he's rich and spoiled, he doesn't understand us as normal people because he is rich, again, he thinks he's better than everyone because he's from this country' or so. So I try being humbled with people as much as I can. And I try to avoid saying that I'm from this country sometimes, because of what people are gonna think when I say that I am from this country. Because, as soon as they know that 'oh this person is from [home country]', they are like 'oh so you're rich'. No - not necessarily, every country has several classes, high class, middle class low class, so just because I'm from a rich country doesn't mean I'm rich. So yeah, it was quite annoying actually, from British locals to say 'oh so you're rich', because not really. So they directly classify me into a group, and I don't like this because I treat people as you said, based on who they are as a person, and not because they belong to this group. But that's not what some people do to me, they immediately classify me into a group and I don't like this, but yeah that was an annoying experience to me. Otherwise everything is all right.
I: Yeah that sounds like a stereotype they have.
P: Exactly.
I: Yeah and how you would feel like -- how much do you feel you belong to [a city in the south of England] or to the UK after this one year living here?
P: I would say, on a scale of 1 to 10, 20% or 10%, because number one I'm not a

British citizen. Number two, I have never been to the UK before, so it's my first experience and my first experience coming here to a place like [a city in the south of England]. Like if it was London, there would have been a lot of interactions with a lot of internationals, a lot of countries, a lot of people. But because [a city in the south of England] is known to have more locals compared to other areas as well, and that's what most of the British students said. And I would say I don't really feel like I belong here, maybe in London, I would say 5 out of 10 or 6 out of 10, and in the UK overall, it would be the average of both which is 3.5. But in [a city in the south of England], I feel like I don't really belong to [a city in the south of England] or to the UK, so it's 2 out of 10, the sense of belonging, but again in London, I'd say 5 out of 10.

Interview 08

I: Okay, so I will start with a very basic question, so what motivates you to come to the UK for study?

P: Um I'd say is the lack of employment, there is, in my home country. After uni, I just thought the opportunities in England were much better.

I: And do have any like expectations of your life and study in the UK before you came here?

P: um I went to British school when I was back in Spain, so I felt like the transition wasn't that harsh. But of course there is a culture shock. Expectations, I mean I just expected it to be, I mean, I think I had all the information I needed when I made the decision, and I was just like 'okay there's probably going to be more British people that international people', but I also checked that [a city in the south of England] had a lot of international students, I was happy with that. Yeah I just, to be fair, I feel like such big institutions, like you are going to find your people in such big institutions because there's a bit of everything.

I: Okay, and yeah so you mentioned that there was a bit of a culture shock, could you give example of it?

P: Um yeah, for example, the drinking culture in England is very different than in Spain, they drink to get drunk whilst we enjoy like a glass of wine with a meal or something. Um also maybe the way of communicating. I feel like they sometimes can beat around the bush and be and try and be very polite with things which I do appreciate, sometimes, but I feel like in my culture is more like direct and straight straightaway, and that's something I've had to get used to. But apart from that, I mean we're still European so. And I do feel like young people are quite open to international students.

I: Okay, then we were talking about, like you, are like European, do you feel like there is still like a commonality between UK and your home?

P: I think more and more there's less of a commonality, but like I said before, I think, in in hotspots as in like, for example, London, obviously, is going to be a lot of European presence. But -- and universities, where people are educated, I think they know all about Europe, they know. They have a slight idea of like what your culture is about, so I think they are informed in that case.

I: Okay, and apart from the culture shock bit, was there like anything else you found is

difficult to cope with, or at the challenges you have faced during your time here?
P: I'd say, the only real challenge is just missing home sometimes, the friends and family. But I think, apart from that, not really because. I knew how to speak English properly so that was, that was okay. yeah and genuinely like generally the people have been very nice and I have made an effort to not only meet English and UK students but also international students.
I: Okay, so like when you are here, do you know, like any of your old friend also maybe from home, they also study in the UK?
P: I know people now but not when I moved in, like not when I moved to England.
I: Okay, so when you move to the England, you know nobody here?
P: Nobody.
I: Okay so basically the social network was built after you arrived.
P: Yeah yeah. I threw myself into the pool.
I: Yeah so, as you said you meet with both like British locals and other international students right?
P: Yeah bit of both.
I: Then, would you feel there is difference between you interact with British locals and other internationals?
P: Yeah. 100% I think international students understand certain problems you have, like being homesick or… yeah being homesick and, just like the extra effort you have to make to study there. And obviously just cultural differences, but I will say, I think, for example, British students and Spanish students are more similar than that I know Spanish people and Canadian people you know. Okay, so I think it's a spectrum.
I: Yeah yeah that's true. Okay, then apart from the difficulties, do you find anything that was easy to cope with or any positive side of your life here?
P: Yeah 100%. I think I think it's good that I, I made the effort to also socialized with English people, because it made my, how do I say like, I adapted into the culture more quickly. Because I know there's a lot of Spanish like international students, I know a lot of them tend to stick to their like their nationality and people from that same country. I think, in a way that's not good to integrate with the people in that country. So I think being with them, part of the time, helped me integrate into the whole environment up the UK yeah.
I: Okay, then, how would you think your sense of belonging to [a city in the south of England] or to the UK?
P: hmm I do think I belong, I mean I'm like I think you make yourself belong somewhere like. You're never obviously the first day you're there, you don't belong there, I don't think you're like -- you're not you're not going to feel like you belong there, you have to make an effort to do that. Because I remember my first year of uni, I did come to London often because I had some friends in London that I had made, and I got along better with them. But as soon as I realized that I wasn't putting the effort to make friends at [a city in the south of England], and I started making the effort to meet people and make good friends there in [a city in the south of England]. I started to feel like I belong there, so I think it's all about how you approach it at the end of the day. 100%.

I: Okay yeah and thank you for sharing that. So my next question would be, have you ever feeling you are misunderstood by others when you are here?
P: Um I mean not – no generally no. I feel like maybe if the language barrier was bigger, I could understand that, but not in my case, I want to say. I can't think of any situation where a formal misunderstood now.
I: Okay, and can I ask that you mentioned language barrier is bigger?
P: No I said like -- I feel like if it were to be bigger, as if someone from Spain that didn't speak as like good English, I would understand that it would be harder for them. Or like it would they would feel misunderstood more often.
I: Okay. And is there any moment you feel like the person you're interacting with, they really get your idea or they really understand you?
P: Yeah I feel like as I've said generally, I mean day to day, I can socialize with whoever, it doesn't really matter that the nationality. But if there's certain things, for example, about missing home or just like, the drinking culture or like maybe some humor, I would relate to more with an international person. But then, if you think about it, I have like -- it's all about the person at the end of the day, I feel like and you can't really say 'oh, I get along better with international people' because I have some English friends who I get along better with than some of internationals, so I think it maybe generally you can relate to in some aspects with international people, but as a whole, I think it comes down to the person.
I: Okay, so it's more about the person rather than a group they belong to.
P: Yeah yeah yeah. And how open minded they are, if they want to learn about your country your culture yeah.
I: Okay, so yeah. So you are comfortable communicating with others in English right?
P: Yeah.
I: And is there any like scenario, you find the person who recognize, like you are not a native English speaker yeah.
P: Yeah I think I think they definitely do know I'm not native. I think they don't know where I'm from, but I do think sometimes when they realize you're not native they make an extra effort to hear you out, which I think is good.
I: Okay. yeah so. Have you ever been treated unequally, or excluded because like you sounds not like a native?
P: Not really, I think the only thing is we've laughed about it, if I've made a mistake, we just laugh it off. It's never been in a mean way, at least in my experience.
I: So yeah so it won't have a big influence on how you interact with -
P: No, not really, no. I mean, I can, I can tell you like, my best friends at uni are not Spanish, so that just goes to show.
I: Okay yeah and okay so, apart from what we've talked about, do you feel like there is anything else you want to tell me about your experience and feelings?
P: I'd say, the fact that there is an international community is good for both parties, like not only international students but also British students. Because I can tell, I don't wanna toot my own horn, but I do, I can tell people also learn from having international people, like sorry I can -- I can see how British people have learned from having international people around. I think it's quite eye opening. And that happens

with everything, like I've learned too from being with them as much as they have with me. And yeah I just think I just think it's about diversity at the end of the day that makes people richer so yeah. I also think, having the international community present, even if it's not like the most, the biggest one, like obviously London is full of international people. But in a personal sense, I haven't I haven't felt, like I belong less or more either in [a city in the south of England] or in London, and it's all about like the people you choose to be around really, I think.
I: Okay yeah and, is there any moment you feel like 'okay British people are learning from internationals'?
P: Yeah like just generally they asked about my culture, about my traditions, what like -- what life is like in my country, how we do things in my country, and then we can compare, and I do think they do learn. It's like -- if, I don't know, if I were to meet, like one of my best friends is South African, so I have learned so much about Africa just through her. And yeah and, as I said, I think, an important thing is that it's important for international people to branch out also to Brits, because it makes you feel more integrated into the society, in my opinion, 100%.
I: Okay, so do you think like, international students, if they integrated more into the society they will feel better?
P: Yes, 100%. I've seen I've seen how I, as I've said, there's some international groups that stick to each other, and I don't think that's healthy. Because you just you just it's like you're in your country, but just in like another territory, really like you're not experiencing anything different. But I think if you are, if you hang around, if you hang out with people with Brits and English people, I think -- it's just like when I started to do that, I felt like I belonged more. So I do think it's beneficial.
I: Okay. Yeah, and so my next question is, how do you think the time like you've been in the British school helps you like help you living here in the UK?
P: I think only the language, because my school, it was full of Spanish people, it's just that they taught us, they taught everything in English. So I think it's just the language thing and it made it easier, it made the transition easier. Like, I didn't have the barrier, the language barrier as a problem. So I think that's it.
I: Okay yeah I remember earlier, you mentioned that if a Spanish whose English is not that good, they will face problems here right?
P: But I think I think you can overcome them easily, I think, be in be in that country, and if you expose yourself to the language, I think it's something you can overcome, yeah.
I: Okay yeah then. Do you know any of your friends who like feel a bit difficult in living here due to their language?
P: I mean, I don't think I don't think language has been a problem for most of the people I've met. But maybe that's because I've met people that can speak good English. But I think I think the biggest problem, there has been with international students around me that I've seen, is just missing home and missing -- and it's just all about being outside your comfort zone. I think it would happen with any anything else, but it was just this in this case, it was just like moving out and being in another country. But I think it's just like missing home and adapting to the culture. But I think

it's definitely just like a phase, it's a transition, it's fine after a bit.
I: Okay. What actions did you take to release the stress?
P: I just, um I think it just very, very it was like a very progressive thing. It's just exposing yourself to it, and finding a routine and doing, doing what like the new thing. Because, obviously, every time you have like a life change, it's going to be difficult, so just like finding a routine and getting used to it. I think that's, the only thing really yeah.
I: Okay. Then how would you think the social inclusion or exclusion here in the UK?
P: Um I'd say in my in my experience it's been pretty good. Like I said, like I said I've never felt excluded because of my -- because of being international at all. In fact, I think sometimes people, I think that's cool, which I don't even get but, yeah I've never felt excluded, like even in like societies, like the French society, you can go even if you don't speak French, like it's so, so social or, I don't know, I've never felt excluded for being what I am.
I: Okay, so then. The difficulty for you would be at the very beginning, the time that you need to adapt to.
P: Yeah, 100%.
I: Okay.
P: I think that's with everyone, I think I feel like that's everyone yeah, yeah.
I: How long do you think it takes you?
P: Because of lockdown, I went back home for half of Term 1 and the whole of Term 2, so it was kind of like, when I moved in my first year, I had like the excitement of, like, a new thing and moving out, and that lasted till lockdown, so I really didn't feel homesick in first year of uni. It was more second year of the uni when I when I stay there for like, the whole time, that I felt homesick during Term 1. But I would say it depends on when you want to start, like acting on it. If you obviously -- if you just surround yourself with people with like Spanish people, and or if you go back home often, to like neglect the feeling, then it's going to take a longer time, but if you if you start thinking 'Oh, this is my new life now, I have to get used to this, I have to integrate with the people here like, the English people', then I think it takes less time. For me it was three months.
I: Okay yeah. So for the homesick like was there particular part you really missed your family members of your or your friends there?
P: Yeah both family and friends yeah. I felt like the ones I was meeting there didn't compare. But that was because I hadn't met them well enough.
I: Okay, you mentioned that the one you made. I'm sorry I mean I just miss a bit.
P: I think I was feeling homesick because I hadn't, I was comparing my friends at uni with my friends at school. But you can't do that because you you've, at least for me, I had I had been with my friends at school for like 10 years, and you've only made these people unit for like a couple of months, so you can't really compare.
I: Okay yeah that's fine. Okay, so it seems like you don't really feel there is any difference when you interacting with British students and other internationals right?
P: mm hmm I don't, I mean. Not really. I would say, maybe at the beginning at the beginning, I would say yes, I would say I would open up more fast, like quickly to

international people. But I'd say like after a long time I've I've been like more friends with British people, than some international people. Like it comes to the person, it comes down to the person.
I: Okay yeah. Okay, so a final question would be, do you think the experiences we've just talked about reflecting your time being here in the UK?
P: Oh yeah yeah. I mean I feel like my time in England has been like, first year of the uni, which was kind of like a bit, it was a bit wobbly cuz I wasn't in England for most of it, so you can't really count it. I just had the excitement of the beginning and the excitement of the end in Term 3. But it was like literally less than two months, those two periods, so you can't really -- it was -- I felt like I was on summer camp. And then, and then second year was like the real deal and I had to get used to it. And I feel like the first term of second year was the struggle of missing home, and missing my friends and family, comparing the people I knew at home with the ones that had, like the new friends I made there, and then getting used to the culture everything. But then, as soon as you accept it, and you make effort to integrate, and you realize that it's just different, it's not better or worse, it's just different. Then, when your mindset changes, that's when you start enjoying it, let's say. And now like I'm happy, I wouldn't go back. I think it's fine. But I do -- I have realized living in London, because there are more international people here, I do feel more -- I do feel like I'm part of the majority, and I didn't feel like I was part of the majority in [a city in the south of England]. But I still felt like okay, because I don't really -- I'm one of those people that I don't really care what others think, so like that didn't bother me, as long as I was, I was being treated fairly, that didn't bother me.

Interview 09
I: So my first question would be very general and basic. So what was your motivation for studying in the UK?
P: So well, this is not my first time studying in the UK, I studied my undergrad, and also master's degree in the UK. So I have been here for about eight years by now. So the motivation was, well, it is a sort of a long story, but I would say that it was just I was I wanted to go away from my home country. And it was just to sort of explore how does it feel to be just by myself and to perhaps find myself better? That's probably the shortest way how to put it sort of just explore myself in my own way. Together, there was a reason why I came here.
I: Okay. Yeah, no problem. And do you have any expectations of the life being here before we came to the UK?
P: Um, I don't think so. I don't think that I had really expectations. I have been to the UK before, because my country, my school, high school, organised a trip. And obviously, there was not really the experience of being a student. But I didn't necessarily come with any expectations. I just wanted to go away from [home country]. So it was like, whatever the experience is going to be. I just wanna try it. So yeah, I did not have expectations. Yeah.
I: Okay. Then, after you've been here, do you find anything that is particularly difficult to cope with? Or any challenges you faced?

P: Um, I don't think so. I'm actually, to be honest with you, I find living in the UK a little bit easier than [home]. I feel like, for some reason, I feel much more accepted. But yeah, I don't think that there were any specific, like, difficulties really? Yeah, but maybe if you want to meet any particular, like, specific questions, I will be able to elaborate but yeah, in general, I didn't have I cannot think of anything.
I: Okay. And when you came here, do you have any old friend you know, like, from your home country, who are also studying here in the UK?
P: Yeah. So we came here from high school, five of us. So basically, the first year when I came here, I was sort of in a group of people from high school, who I knew and we sort of did many things together. And they actually helped me with -- one particular student from there, but particular friend has been in the UK before. So they helped me with, for instance, establishing a bank account or finding shops and this kind of like basic things, which you have to start thinking about when you come to study at the university. But after the first year, I -- over the course of the year, I slowly sort of detached from them. I didn't generally like doing like to necessarily meet with people from my home country. I think it's just because I don't necessarily like that culture. So therefore, I sort of started to detach and perhaps meet more with people on the course or something like that. So short answer is that yes, there was a group of people.
I: Excellent. Yeah. And so yeah, so apart from the old friends you also trying to build a new social network here in the UK, right?
P: Yes, sort of mostly with the students on the course, but I did not necessarily seek like social connection outside of that, because I, well, I am more of the person of solitude. But I also -- when I first came here I came to study in and I come from a small town, so it was a little bit of a change. And I felt like a little bit intimidated by all the people and everything. Also, is a little bit more dangerous if you want. So I did not necessarily see the social connection outside of the university or work. But yes, I did socialise with the colleagues and students little bit when I was at the university during lectures, or during working hours, but I did not go out unnecessarily.
I: Okay. And so, when you socialise with your, for example, course mates, did you meet with both like international students and also British local students?
P: Oh, yes. I think that we had quite a diverse like the background. Basically just, you know, well, the university which I was studying at is quite international in general. So I would -- my course which was a was quite diverse in terms of background and also in terms of races. Well, they were like, well like, quite many, like black people as well. Which was very, very nice. I mean, it was very, very diverse. And I would socialise with many of them and also, I think it was quite nice for our university that we had these like school trips. That was quite, quite good for like sort of ice breaking and sort of like developing like your relationships if you want like friendships and stuff like that.
I: Okay, after you being in the UK for such a long time, do you feel like you belong here to the UK or either belong to or [a city in the south of England]?
P: That's actually a good question. Um I think I feel better here in [a city in the south of England]. Maybe because as I said, I came from a small town and I love to be close

to nature and [a city in the south of England] is much more close to nature. Also, I feel a little bit more confident here, like I am much better in forming relationships here than for instance in. So maybe that might be also another reason. I would say that I feel much more at home here than [home country]. But maybe just because I have been here for so long. Maybe, I don't know.
I: And I wonder why you said that. It's easier for you to forming relationship here rather than
P: Um, I don't know whether it was just this kind of shift and maybe after COVID and being in [home country], I felt like, okay, let's start a new chapter. I take this as a new beginning, I changed my image a little bit. I feel like I started to be a little bit more confident about myself. And I felt like okay, well, we're also studying something that I like. So I started to be more open to friendships and these kinds of relationships, I guess. Yes, I sort of started to observe it. Also, people start to see me differently. I guess. I don't know whether you want me to elaborate on anything, but.
I: Okay, so basically, you're saying, you just change your way of treating social and make, like making connections with others?
P: Yes. I mean, I was, I used to be pretty shy, I think. And I guess I'm also introverted person, like, I've been reserved. And I think once I came to the to, to the UK, like, I started to be more like, Okay, well, let's just open up a little bit, and let's be just a little bit more open to friendships and these kinds of things. It was an interesting shift., I started to be really be more open up.
I: Okay. And after you've been here for like, a few years, do you make social connections with others? Or do you have like any international friends or British local friends?
P: I used to live in the university accommodation. And then I moved in with one friend of mine, who is British. And I think that we are pretty good friends. And we are still living together. And then I have another friend, but I'm not meeting him very often because we used to live at the same university accommodation, but right now he is doing the master's degree. So right now he's sort of working So, he's sort of a busy with other things, travelling stuff. So sorry, what was the question?
I: Okay. Yeah, yeah, I got the idea. And yeah, it's perfect answer for my question. And then I would wonder, like, have you ever encountered any communication problems, either in your day to day life or in your working time?
P: Um, yes, I think so. But it is interesting, because when I studied, basically my high school, it was bilingual school. So we had some subjects in English. So that, thanks to that, I was relatively confident when I was coming to the UK and study. But at the same time, I consider myself as not very verbal person, I can express myself in different things like art and music and stuff like that. So when I communicated, under certain circumstances, for instance, when I first started working, etc, I always had to sort of ask them to repeat whatever they said, because I did not understand them, especially. I think, I'm not sure what it was like it was specific work with a British person was speaking to me, but generally, like anyone, like when they were using the terms I did not understand and had to ask to clarify, and it still happens sometimes. And yeah, but I'm not sure if we're doing this necessarily, just because I'm

international students, but maybe just because I do not speak to people. Yes, but yeah, if you want me to elaborate on anything, just…
I: Okay, so you said that when someone using a term that you don't really know, you would ask them to repeat, right?
P: Yeah. And sometimes it was -- it felt a little awkward when I had to ask a couple of times, or when they had to then sort of show me what they mean. But most of the time, when people were very, very nice to sort of like, even if I asked like four times, and then they had to actually show it like what they really mean, they were always very kind. So I think that I was quite fortunate to have these kind of people around me.
I: Okay. Will these kind of experience influences how you would interact with certain people. So if you feel like awkward, when you asking that person to repeat it? Will these experiences influence how you would interact with this person in the future?
P: Yes, I would say so. I'm quite, I would say that I'm quite sensitive to how people are treating me. And I think that, whenever I just spotted just a minor, like, almost like negative emotion from the person, I would feel a bit more shut. Like, I would not ask that question. I would be scared to ask to repeat the question. So, sorry, to repeat what they said. So yes, it will very much influence on how I would react and sort of respond to them later on. But as I said, well, thankfully, most of the time, I had people who were very kind to sort of repeat anything, or help me so yeah, but it would influence quite strongly I would say.
I: Okay, okay. Then, do you find like there is any positive side of your international students here in the UK?
P: I would say that it makes you a little bit more unique. But at the same time, I think because in the UK, there is a such a diverse community, especially at universities, the diversity makes it more welcoming. So I think being international students, or being from [home country], which is a country, which most people don't even know where it is, it makes me a little bit more unique. And it is sort of it can be sort of, like a sort of trigger point for discussions like for just the initial discussion, like where are you from? [home country]. What? Then I have to explain, and then it sort of starts discussing these things, I guess. So I see this as a positive experience. Let me just think that if there's anything else. I guess sometimes it is also, I don't necessarily seek people who are from my country. Because I didn't like that. Because I mentioned I don't necessarily like perspectives, and etc. But sometimes when I happen to hear someone speaking my language, or if I happen to meet someone, in speaking, who is speaking my language, it is going to be more bonding. Because we are -- I'm meeting someone from my home country in foreign country. So it is kind of, I don't know how to describe it, it is easier to bond with that person, rather than if I was studying at home? If you understand what I mean.
I: Any positive that these living experiences here would bring to you during the time being here in the UK?
P: Well, I think that they're just basically using a different language is just - I sort of see this differences between my language and English, because English seems to be, from a cultural point of view, more individualistic, if you want, and [home country] is

more from the collectivistic culture pretty much. Right now it is different, but it is usually the collectivistic culture. And it is nice to sort of see the nuances in way how we express ourselves and how other people express themselves. In general, I think I find -- we have a saying in [home country] that how many languages you know that many times you are a human. So I feel like that, that being here as a foreign -- as an international student or just an international person in general, makes me feel more well, there's some sort of diversity within me, like developing this kind of diversity, like having different perspectives almost like on a life.
I: Okay, so you mentioned earlier that when you meet a person who speak the same language as you, you will feel like easier to bond with. What do you think would be the reason for this?
P: I think that it is not only language, but also sort of background. And the sort of we're [?] to degree also bringing the sense of, I don't know, history, historical background of the country. And I think that when two people from the same country meet somewhere else, they suddenly feel that they have something more in common than just being human beings, or sharing the same language, but also sharing the history, the culture, and everything. So basically, realising, oh, we have actually many things in common, even though we potentially didn't have the experience from the history, we still share something, which you cannot really put your finger on. But there is something more almost like the roots are the same. But if there is some sort of connection there which cannot be filled with person who is from also potentially also international students, but from different countries. So it's not from my own country.
I: Okay, so you're talking about the common background behind you and the person? So will these make makes you or the person like, understand each other more easily?
P: I think we are more likely to be more open to each other, or perhaps more open to -- it is almost like sometimes people can be almost like sceptical to other nationalities, sometimes. That's not necessarily negative way, but simply just being a little bit more worried, you know, of other nationalities for whatever reason, there might be. When you meet someone who is from the same country sort of know, what is the background, you have some sort of, let's say, stereotypes about that kind of, because you know, your country. So it is much easier to almost like trust person, or perhaps open up more easily and perhaps, in some cases for friendships. And I think, I mean, I didn't necessarily, as I said, I don't necessarily seek these kinds of friendships, but well, during my undergrad school studies, for instance, I met someone who, from [a country close to home country], who was studying the same course. And we actually became very good friends. So there is something about that, like open, like being able to open up a little bit more and trust person a little bit more.
I: Okay, yeah. And then I wonder, like, when you interact with British local students, do you still keep that openness? Or what will happen?
P: Um, it depends, I think that will. As I said, I'm a little bit reserved. So it takes me a little bit of time to sort of get to know a person, even if I know, for instance, someone from the same country, I would still be, it would still take me some time to sort of get to know the person and to open up a little bit. With the British nationals, it would take probably a little bit longer, but what I'm usually looking at is on how they are trying to

interact with me, they're more open to myself as well and potentially overlook some mistakes, which I make in the language. And just generally look at the person as they are, is their character, which potentially sounds strange. But yeah, I like to look at it that way, how they are trying to interact with me. And that would perhaps determine how open I would be. So for instance, that person who I'm living with right now, who is a British, I feel like we have really, like pretty good relationships, because he seems to be like a little bit more open, it'll be seemed to be like, almost on a similar wavelength. So yeah, I think that it is not that much the question of the nationality, more the question of the personality and these kinds of things, but well, who knows?
I: Yeah, okay, I got that. Yeah. So it's more about the person rather than the group they belong to.
P: Yes, I suppose so.
I: Yeah. Yeah. Okay. My next part would be, so do you have experiences of being misunderstood by others, either in your life or in your study here.
P: Um, I think it always happens once in a while. It was more often in the past. And basically because when I came here, despite my bilingual high school, I still was not quite used to speak English like whole day every day. But potentially right now I feel like that, well, it sometimes happens, but well, it is, again, well, I am feeling very fortunate. Most people either explain it again, or -- I feel like pretty fine to ask them to repeat the question or whatever they're saying. Or if I'm saying something that they do not understand. They usually feel comfortable to ask me to repeat that again. So I'm not sure whether that answered the question.
I: Yeah. Yeah, of course. So it's about the language part, as you talked about. And could you give an example of that?
P: From now or from the past?
I: Is there difference between now and the past?
P: Yeah, that's a good question. I didn't really know. So when I was misunderstood, yeah. Let me think. Yeah, probably recently. Well, not very recently, probably last year, I was basically having a meal with a friend of mine. And he was asking me something and he asked me once, I did not get the question. He asked me again, because I ask him to repeat that. Again, I didn't get it. And I think this went about like three or four times. So I felt a little bit awkward just because of that. But he seems to be okay with it. Like, oh, well, it might be just, you're tired or something. So genuinely, I didn't feel like -- I wouldn't have a problem to again, ask him. If I'm if I misunderstand something, I would say I would not have a problem to ask him to repeat that. Like, even right now. Because I feel pretty -- I feel the more he would be okay with that, if I asked him to clarify anything. In terms of if someone misunderstood myself, I think that happens relatively often when I have meetings. But it might be well, it might be partially because of my background, for instance, my supervisors very often say that I should use more tentative language, which is very much can be the difference between the languages because I think that [home country] is much more abrupt. We will say what we think do [?]. Although I don't consider myself as the kind of person. I still, maybe this background, sort of makes me expressing myself more abrupt in English. And that sort of makes it a little bit difficult

when expressing myself. So yes, but when it comes to misunderstanding me, I think it will then usually people just to sort of ask for clarification initially, then we somehow get to what I really mean. And then as I said, mostly I'm fortunate that people either get me then or just to ask for more clarification, and then we sort of work from that.
I: And we're talking about like, people in your country, they probably speak in a more direct manner. But here, people would say it indirectly?
P: Yeah, yeah. So I would say so. I find it actually quite interesting because, you know, I mean, I think that well in general British people are more associated with this gentleman kind of that -- I don't know, I saw one funny picture, which I don't remember clearly right now, but basically, it was well how, how the how the British person would ask for help. And the view was like, oh, sorry, sir. could you please help me? They would not shout like help me, you know, it will make all this kind of statement or to make it twice. So I feel like I think maybe it is English in the UK, this more polite-driven. I do believe that is just the kind of stereotype, but I find that many people who I know are relatively polite and trying to use it and speak in that kind of way. So I'm not sure maybe it is also like the world of academia. But also I would say that it is general kind of English in the UK to make sense.
I: Okay. And after your supervisor tells you that probably you should say more tentative, did you begin to pay more attention to that?
P: Yes, certainly certainly. And because I it is actually by my nature, I always felt that I was right, that I am a tentative person well, I expressed myself in more polite, in kind, or perhaps more loving way. So it was pretty, I wouldn't say shock, but surprise that when I realised that actually I'm not expressing myself as tentatively as I thought. So yes, I started to be more aware of it. And definitely when I'm writing, whatever part of the thesis I'm writing, I'm trying to really think about how I'm using language in writing.
I: Okay. And will you think this is because of the differences in cultures?
P: Yes, I think so. It comes back to that when I said that, I think that British culture is often associated with kind of a gentleman nature. Yeah, be very polite. So I think that, yeah, it can be culture. Yeah, so it's like, yeah, and [home country] is seemingly much more, much more straight. Yeah.
I: Yeah. And so, when you just arrived here and express it in a straightforward way. And there any, like, probably misunderstanding happens, or?
P: I think so. I cannot think of any specific example. But, but yes, it does happen that you are saying sort of in some certain way. And then I sort of realised that the person potentially could take it more personally, but usually, maybe they understand that I'm an international student. So they are perhaps more understanding, sort of taking, oh, well, maybe it is just a language thing, you know? And if it is really something not really good, they usually discuss it with me or at least asked me okay, what do you meant or what? But yeah, it is not happening too often, but it can happen. But usually, I do not have like any negative experience necessary. Usually people are very understanding.
I: Okay, we're talking about people are understanding you, is there any particular moment you feel like, okay, this person got me, they got my idea, and they understand

what I'm talking about?
P: Yes, I think the friend, he says to me, like, I wouldn't say that it is almost like telepathic, but sometimes I feel like that, that when I'm expressing myself, they get what I really mean. Also, another friend of mine, he seems to be able to understand me quite well. And I think that it might be mainly because of very similar past experiences, so we are more in tune, instead of understanding what we mean by certain words and expressions.
I: Yeah. So you mean you share some common background?
P: Um, I would say experiences rather than the background.
I: Yeah. Okay. So regarding the experiences, could you tell me a bit more about that?
P: So briefly, so basically, when I was doing my undergraduate, in the first year, once I've come to the UK, I basically experienced depression and loneliness. And the way how it really resonates with the friend is that similar experiences, we share some of these experiences with sort of, let's call them the 'dark stuff' if you want. And potentially that makes us, our relationships a little bit deeper and perhaps more comfortable to speak about certain things and being also a little bit more open and understanding.
I: Okay. Have you ever felt like you are treated equally, or, or being excluded, because other people recognise your accent or because of your language?
P: I think so that there were some instances, but let me think whether I can come up with any particular one. I mean, I think that well, in universities, predominantly, there is this sort of culture of being welcoming and inclusive. So I usually felt like very welcoming and fine. But there were occasions when I didn't know, for instance, when we had like a group discussion, especially during undergrad, when still my English was not the best. I mean, it's still not the best, but at the point is not. And I do remember that, there were occasions when people were less patient with me expressing myself. So that would be probably these kinds of instances that people would be less patient and it would be quite obvious to me, and definitely make me feel like that I was scared to express myself more, perhaps make a point during the discussion, which was quite a problem, because especially if you are getting marked for a discussion, you know, so yeah, but these were just sometimes it happened. It didn't happen too often.
I: Okay. Then. So, after, like, you feel some people could be potentially impatient, and then how will they react to their impatience?
P: Um, usually, these were like, if we are speaking, for instance, module's discussions, I would feel like, it was like, almost like shutting myself. Okay, well, I'm not going to say anything else, then. I would probably not even confront those people. I generally have like a problem to confront people, I guess. But you know, this, this is this felt very direct, if you want. So, I would usually just sort of be more silent. I guess that would be my coping mechanisms at that point, just basically just shut myself.
I: Okay. And does this have an influence on your, like, academic performance, or the grade?
P: Um, I don't think so. Because usually, I managed to, somehow I always managed

to, I don't know, maybe make a point before actually starts to feel sort of behave like that. So I wouldn't say they've made any, any, any difference or anything? Yeah, I don't think so. And we actually, interestingly, has a lecturer who was very tough, like, But he was very much like, okay, whatever, even if you're international, that doesn't matter. I also had to learn English, so you got to learn it as well. And if we were doing discussions, I expect you to speak like, like everyone else, and all the British people. And that was on the first day of the university and I was like, Oh my God. Oh my goodness. But yeah, I have managed somehow,
I: Yeah. Okay. And I wonder, do you remember the people who's being impatient during the discussion? Like, was he or she a British or people from other countries?
P: Um, I would say that generally like people from other countries were more patient. I think that because they shared the same experience, or at least to some extent. But there were also some British people who were pretty patient. I mean, yeah, I think there are also some British people.
I: Okay, but after being here for, like, a few years, do you think like, how important does language or English play the role in your life?
P: Well, I think that I'm thinking more often in English than in [first language], and when I tried when we have, for instance, calls with my family, I still sometimes have a problem to remember the [first language] term for that. I remember the English term, but I don't remember the [first language]. So probably, I wouldn't consider it a negative impact. But it seems like I'm forgetting my native language to some degree because I'm speaking in English. But I also find it much easier to express myself in English than in [first language]. I didn't know maybe it is. I don't know. Maybe because I'm studying using the language, I don't quite know. But I find it easier to express myself in English. Also, I'm reading more books, which are of my interest in English. So maybe that sort of helps me to expand that vocabulary, rather than the [first language]. And then I'd speak better in English, than [first language].
I: Okay. And do you think have a good English skill is important for international students?
P: I think so. Because obviously, the relationships are based on very often on communication, so we cannot properly express ourselves, then the connection with another human being can be much more problematic. So I think that being able to express oneself is quite important. Yeah, yeah. So yes, that's pretty much if you want me to elaborate, anyway, but this is my answer.

Interview 10
I: And we talked about your church friends, which is kind of closer to you compared to the people who you know from your lab or from your job. And when we are talking about the closer friends, do you mean you can talk like, anything, any private issues or your personal problem with them?
P: Oh, well, it depends. It depends. There are sometimes I would keep to myself and don't even tell anyone. Well, like you said, there are things I can still discuss with my church friends. I can discuss with people I met in the lab or school.
I: Okay. Yeah. That's pretty much a summary of what we've just talked about. And so

after you came here, did you find anything that is difficult to cope with? Or any challenges?
P: Yeah, well, the first thing is the food. I find it difficult to cope with English food back then, and I still find it very difficult to cope with it now. Back in my country, our mode of cooking is different. We, we cook our food a lot, like you know, a lot of time on the fire and stuff like that. But most British food are not properly cooked, let me not use the offensive words [inaudible], it's you know, sometimes most of their food, in two minutes, it's done and it's not the kind of food we back in… So the mode of preparing their food is somehow strange to me. [inaudible] in the hotel, I tried a lot of English food, and I only ended up wasting my money because I couldn't eat them. And I still attempt to try somehow [inaudible]. So it's down on me that I might not get used to their food. So that's one, then the other thing I find very difficult to cope with. Yeah, the weather wasn't really a problem for me. Maybe because I was well prepared in my mind, like, 'oh, it's gonna be cold'. It wasn't strange when it started. Because I came in April, it was about the time that the cold was about going off. So I enjoyed the summer well, and by the time it will be the next December, I was already used to it. So I wouldn't say much. Then the other thing I found very, very difficult to cope with at the beginning was not the language, but the accent. The accent was really challenging for me. When I first came, I mean, the first three months was really tough, getting to hear what people say. And I remember most of the things I do, the bank account I open, doing this and that, that my auntie always follows me there. And she's always wanted conversing with whoever I want to deal with. So it was with time I get to understand the accent. Of course, English is our first language in [home country], when it comes to English, like we do understand, I wasn't having problem with English, not the language. I don't understand a second language. But I understand English, but the British accent was a problem for me when I came. Well, it's a lot better now anyway.
I: Yeah. So the accent problem, like happens when you try to understand someone else. And have you ever been treated unequally or differently because of your accent here?
P: The truth is, yeah, let me just tell you the real truth. A truth of the matter is, in the UK, there are strong laws against racism. Yeah. But the fact is, there are still a lot of racist. That is the fact, let's face it that a lot of British people that are completely racist. But then they try to be stylish about the way they show you that they don't like you, because they know there is a law. I will pick it up against it, and it's going to be trouble. But it will be obvious with some [inaudible] with you, then you will know that 'Oh, no. These people are being racist'. Yeah. I think I've seen that more, on most occasions where I've experienced that it's not something direct. It's not something confrontational. So you can't hold anybody for what is not directly connect to you. But you can feel it. You know, we are all humans and from the way people react or behave, even they don't talk, you would know whether you're welcome or not.
I: Okay. So, like, does this happen when they just see you or when they talk to you and hear your accent?
P: Well, to be honest, it's not something I've always noticed. Because I don't care. I

didn't come here because of anyone, I came here because of myself. And I knew what I want. And the most important thing for me, if I if I tried to initiate a conversation with you, I don't see you're welcoming, I'll leave and go my way. I've have experienced that a couple of time, you know, most of them do not wait for you to talk. Most of them mainly see your colour, and they don't want to talk. I have -- I was in a in a gathering and I think it was with a lot of people and I was trying to -- we were going on the way, I was trying to initiate conversation and then they were evading it. Those guys get together, I just left them and then went my way. It's as simple as that. You don't need any special sign to know that, those people in particular. And then there you still meet people are extra friendly, very kind, yeah. It's funny, because the UK is a place where we have a lot of mixed races, for the fact that you are white does not mean you are British, we have a lot of European, a lot of Caucasian, these like complexion. So you can't really conclude that the cold treatment you're getting is from the locals, so to speak. Well, yeah. That happens once in a while. I really don't experience that much. Because I don't make myself vulnerable to it. I really don't have British friends, like I said, I really don't mingle well much with the white, so. Because literal I try to mingle, sometimes it [inaudible], sometimes you get discouraged. So I just did my lane. I stay in my lane most times and just, although when people don't understand me better, I think with that everyone is safe and happy.

I: Okay, so during your time here, do you have any experiences of like, you are misunderstood by others? So for example, if you say something, the person just doesn't get what you're saying, or don't get your idea.

P: That happens every time. And that's basically because of the accent. That happens every time. Then you say something and it takes time for them to understand what you're trying to say. I might have to say something 4, 5, 6 times. Sometimes you have to show pictures or spell something before people understand. There is a point, it's not a big deal. Because the same way they find it difficult to understand my accent is the same way I find it difficult to understand their accent. The only thing there is that I am here in their country. So I don't have a choice, but to get to understand. Many of them don't try to understand foreign language. But if they come to my country and they talk, they're the one that's going to adjust to… So that's normal, where you find yourself anyway, you're going to get into the system. That still happened to us tomorrow. So it's not a big deal about that. Well, I think if there is only enough understand is, if I'm telling you something you don't understand, I'll spell it, write it, describe it or whatever. And there is no crime in asking 'please, I don't understand what you said, can you come over again?'

I: So you feel this is kind of a normal thing, because you are here in their country?

P: No, it's not because I'm here in their country. It is because it's normal. It's not about any country. For example, my supervisor is a man [from another country]. Sometimes when he speaks, I still find it difficult to understand what he's saying, because that's his accent, and you can't take it away from him. So it's not about maybe British, I'm talking about generally, across the world, the way we speak, our accent is different. Even when we are speaking the same language, the way we speak, it is different. So it's normal when you are talking with someone that doesn't have your kind of accents,

that you have a bit of a struggle to get what he or she's saying. It's not just with British people, and I have some [friends from other countries] and you need to listen very well to get what they're saying. And the same thing happened to them with me. So if we leave the UK and go to America, the same thing can happen because different accent is different accent and there is nothing anyone can do about it.
I: Yeah, yeah. Okay. And is there any moment you feel the person who are like maybe talking to you or interacting with you, they really understand what you are saying? You don't need to like repeat lots of times. You don't need to like further explain what you are talking about.
P: No, that (coder: explanation) happens a lot. Yeah, it is not that maybe, everything you are saying some like [inaudible], no. Maybe you're talking about that -- you mentioned one thing that they don't understand then. You try to explain again, at least you're talking to them and you're getting to hear what I'm saying. But when I say one thing that you don't understand, you tend to ask 'what does that mean? can you come again, please?'
I: Okay. Yeah. And after you came here, do you find any like maybe positive side of your life or study here?
P: Yeah, I certain put this way in my studies. And for the lifestyle, it's, it's something that I'm still struggling to cope with. Let me just put it that way. Because the lifestyle is entirely different. The way we'll do things back [home] is different from the way it's been down here. I mean, even the way people relate with each other is quite different. And you just want to be careful so that you don't do things that will be led down, will land you in, you know, big shit and stuff like that. So yeah, like I said, I've mentioned when I'm doing that, and I'm talking about the food, it's one big deal. Here in the UK, social gathering as they have it been different from the way we have it [back home]. For example, this is a place where someone will invite you to a gathering, he asks you to bring money for refreshment. It happens, he will tell you 'there is some refreshment, come with three pound so you can get refreshment'. It doesn't happen like that [back home]. If they invite you to any gathering, they invite to any event and refreshment is 100% free. There is one thing I find difficult and strange here. I just give you examples. [Back home], if you enter a restaurant, most of the food you want to buy already cooked. You just tell them what you want and you get served, but here you get to the restaurant you tell them what you want, you have to wait for it to be cooked, you know this kind of things. I'm not saying it's a bad thing, I'm just saying as [inaudible] as simple as they are it's something that you find difficult and strange. Some are not of course all in negative way. Yeah, so basically the way of life and the culture is different and it takes time to blend in. Well, I will say I will say my life back in [home country] when it comes to social life was more interesting than it is here. Yeah.
I: You're saying your like life back home, the social life part is not like what you are doing here?
P: No it's not like that. For me, like yeah, it was more fun than here, well that's my opinion. I don't know about anyone else. You know [back home]-- here you have to, you try to get book appointments for everything to see if -- when you have to book

appointment to attend the party, you have to book appointment. Sometimes when I first came here, we were invited to a wedding, and we had to send a letter to say ‘oh yeah, we are coming’. You don't do that in [home country]. You just go there. Even go to some party. I mean, it might sound somehow some [inaudible]. And everything is too serious. Yeah.

I: Yeah, okay. I can get that difference. And do you think there is any other things you would like to tell me or you would add to your experiences here as an international student?

P: I think we've talked about that. Like I said, anywhere you find yourself, you just have to learn how to blend in. And blending in. And as difficult as some realities, you just have to face it as they were. I think I'm facing mine. And it's the most important thing. Yeah, that's done. And sometimes ago, I was talking to a lady, I think she's a nurse. And we got to the point where, you know, we're talking about how people relate to people, you know, you see someone had an accident on the road, and people won’t even go near the person, and how do we, [inaudible] ‘you alright, you alright?’, and that’s it, they wouldn't even help. And she told me that it's painful because the, the idea people spread that if you help the person, you will land in trouble. But in your instance, there is no law that says if you help someone in problem, you will be prosecuted for it. But it's just a basic idea that some people just started and spread like wildfire. And that just, you know, when I first came to the UK, I committed were on the bicycle till now I still committed on the bicycle. And a couple of times, I have accident on the bicycle. I even had one recently that I actually was bruised here by the fall. And on all those occasions, when you fall, all what people will just do to me was start from afar, and just be looking at you. Those doubts that would really care that what they will say ‘you alright?’. And that's it, and then they're gone. It's not like that in my country, if anybody had an accident, even before you're asking ‘what's happening’ or you ask the person’s name, you will have helped. I find that very strange. I find it very, very strange that I mean, who persecute you for helping someone in need, don't do. And I think in this environment, in this kind of nation, people should understand better. When this is a country where camera everywhere. Even if you help the person and anything happen, there are things to prove that you're not the one that killed the person. So why spread the idea. I remember sometimes last year, I was working in the lab, then I fell from the stairs and I broke my ankle, I had to go to fracture. And I had to go to the hospital. And then I was given crutches to walk with. Then I walk with crutches. And I stay in an apartment where you have five rooms, we all talk, we see each other most morning and then I go back home and everyone saw me walking with crutches. And none of them were to ask me what's wrong with you? I mean, to me, it's strange. It's just to show that they don't care about you at all. I mean, the idea of oh every man for himself about this country, about most people in this country to me, it doesn't go down well. I was not telling someone that if that kind of thing happens in [home country], people will show some concern. I couldn't leave my house for like two months. And none of them were to knock on my door wants to ask me ‘How am I here’? I mean, the idea of ‘oh, this is UK, why don’t we mind your business’ to me that that's nonsense. People should understand better.

So it's just it's just giving you an impression that if anything happens to you, and you can't take care of yourself, you will rather die in that situation because nobody will come to your place. I think that is one thing that is sad to know. And the country as a whole, I guess need to sensitise people on some of these things because it's becoming a norm, that you see someone in need you don't you don't go near them. It's becoming the norm. And it's not the best thing. And I understand how, how it can be sometimes because I've heard of stories of someone trying to help the other person and the person trying to help is then implicated that 'oh, maybe he wants to hit me, he wants to do this and that'. But nevertheless, there is there is need to, you know, put some regulations on this and let people understand that it is not a country [inaudible]. So when I look at all those things you know, if they don't mean anything to you if it's the same from where you're coming from, but if it's slightly different from where you're coming from then you feel somehow worried and a little bit concerned.

I: Yeah. And okay, after you experience all the things you just talk about and having been living here for like, one year and more, how do you feel you belonging to the university? Yeah, like from maybe from one to 10, how much do you feel you belong to the university?

P: Oh, I feel fully belong to the university. I'll give myself a nine. Yeah, yeah. As far as university goes and things are normal, no matter how much anybody -- as far as the university is concerned, as far as the system is concerned, the most important thing is are you dispersing your own duty? If yes, it's fine. You know, you just recently I applied for apply for [part-time job in the university] for the new year. The person I worked with last year got in touch with me and asked me if I was still interested in that role, so that they can put my name up for, they will ask first choice. I think if he had been racist, I wouldn't get the opportunity. As far as you dispense your duty as a student in the university I think you're fine. The university system itself takes a strive for to promote equality, diversity and inclusiveness. So I think as far as the system is concerned, I don't really have a problem with them, it's okay. I like I like the university I like being here. But as a whole generally you know the cultural aspect of it is my extensive that's when you begin to relate with people outside the university and then the fit with people outside the university.

I: Okay, and what about how much you feel you belong to [a city in the south of England] here?

P: To be honest, I would like to -- if after my programme obviously I'm back in the UK. I wouldn't like to stay in [a city in the south of England]. I really don't like being in [a city in the south of England]. Because I -- since I had opportunity to visit some other places in UK. And what I see and feel is at about all these places and what I'm experiencing in [a city in the south of England]. Things are actually expensive in [a city in the south of England], for no reason. Things are just too expensive. And yeah, things are just expensive. And I always tell people if things are expensive, expensive, and then you feel you are having the fun that you really want to have. You're really exploring the way you want to explore your own trade. There is nothing much fun to experience in [a city in the south of England], things are expensive. It's just crazy. Plus there are places in the UK that you have large black communities because I

would like to stay in a place where the community for blacks is big. You have very low black community in [a city in the south of England], you hardly see people of your race. I mean, like my race. Places like Birmingham, you have a lot of blacks, you can hardly walk down the street without seeing someone of your own colour. You know, it's wanted that make you feel among, it's wanted that make you feel safe. Like a natural human being. It's so you can imagine you go to a place now and you actually see people of your race you feel safer.

Interview 11

I: So what was your motivation for coming to UK to study?

P: So my motivation for coming here was because of the quality education system over here. So for some context, the education in [home country] is, it's not bad, there are some really good schools. I did my secondary and primary school in [home country]. But in terms of further education, like university wise, the UK was better, especially for the degree that I study. So I came here because I wanted to have access to better education and more opportunities.

I: Okay, then, after you came here, do you think the education here meet your expectations?

P: I will definitely say so. I think I've been quite impressed being here because there are lots of opportunities available. So in my first year of university, I was really involved in the [a university society], and I was able to connect with firms. Um, just different opportunities here. So yeah, I'll say my expectations have been met.

I: Is anything here particularly difficult to copy with after you arrived here? Any challenges and the difficulties?

P: I would say my main difficulty has been settling in, but I wouldn't say it's because of the environment at the university, because I believe there loads of opportunities that you can reach new people and all. But I personally found it, it's a bit hard to settle in just because of -- in terms of meeting people and all. So for some context, my second year wasn't the easiest for me. So in first year, I'm currently my final year. In first year, I was here until about December, and then I had to go back home because of lockdown and Covid and all of that. So in my second year, I was trying to basically let that be my first year. But I had like some personal issues which obviously affected that. So I'll say my main issue has been making more friends here, but I wouldn't say it's because of the university per se, because I personally believe that different opportunities to do so. But that is just based on my own personal experiences.

I: Yeah. And um, do you find any way to help you fit in or meet new people afterwards?

P: Yes, so I've been more intentional about going for events that societies have. I go to church, and I've been able to meet new people there as well. So it's been good, and on my course as well, I would say people are quite friendly, so I've noticed that there are quite a few international students as well. So it's quite easy in a way to relate to those people to and also connect with new people.

I: And when you just came here in the UK, do you have some like old friends whom you know from home, or also from home, or you just knew no one?

P: Yeah. So I have some old friends here. I have one of my really good friends that goes to this university as well, and I also have some of my other friends who study at other university. So I see them quite often.
I: Okay. You both have old friends, you are trying to meet new friends. I wonder, like among your new friend, do you have both like international students and British students?
P: Yes. So yeah, most of the people I've met so far are international, and also some British as well.
I: Okay. And do you think there is difference between you communicating to international students and British students?
P: I wouldn't say there's a huge difference. But what I would say is, I, most of the time I feel more at ease when I'm around people that like myself, it just feels more like home. But I wouldn't say there's a huge difference between in communication, you know.
I: Okay. So you mean, uh you feel at ease and like at home when you being with…
P: When I'm with international students, specifically like black people like myself. I feel more at home because there I can see people who look like me. But I wouldn't say I find it difficult to communicate to people who are not the same race as myself, you know.
I: Okay, Yeah. Now I get that. How would you rate your sense of belonging to the uni, and also the city?
P: I would say a six over ten. So ten being feeling very at home, and one being not. I say six, because, as I mentioned earlier, it hasn't been easy for me in particular settling in, and I think I'm just saying that because I'm really taking in the environment and the people. For a while I was quite distanced from the uni, so I was here, but also wasn't here at the same time. So yes, I'll say to six, but it's getting better, as I'm being more intentional about allowing myself to be immersed in the system.
I: Okay, apart from what we just talked about, do you think there is anything you find it's easy to cope with or any positive side of your international student life here?
P: Positive side, I would say the university has a lot of diverse opportunities, and so you know part of the reason why I came here was because I would have access to new opportunities, meet new people. And so it's been a positive in that way. I've been able to do that since I got here, I've been able to have access to opportunities and be able to touch basically people that I probably wouldn't see on a day to day I wasn't here, so I will say it has that positive side it. It also makes me more outgoing, because it's part of why I decided to come to the UK in the first place.
I: Okay. And then we will move on to the next question. So during your life being here, can you think of any situation you feel you are misunderstood by others?
P: Um, no.
I: Okay. So basically there is no situation like, uh when you say something, the partner didn't really understand you, and they ask you to repeat, or something like that.
P: So far no actually. I think everyone I've spoken to in classes, no one has [inaudible] that they didn't understand what I said, so I would say, in terms of current

communication like this, no barrier. The only thing I would say in terms of the crisis into being misunderstood is people often find it difficult to pronounce my name, but I wouldn't say that's their fault, because they probably never heard of anything like that before, because it's from a completely different culture and country. But that's the crisis into miscommunication, I would say.
I: Okay. And is there any other things you would think it's because of the culture? And maybe something happened, you think because you're from different cultures.
P: No, I wouldn't. That's the closest thing I can think of.
I: Yeah. Then do you have any experiences of you feel you are understood by others very quickly? They get your idea and they get your thoughts and your values very quickly.
P: Yeah, I would say at least the like, the current setting I can bring up our classes with other people. So when I expressed my views or asked question or anything, I feel very safe to be able to do that in the first place, and I also think the lecturers give you room to express yourself. So that's actually that diversity of opinions that allow to be, pass their course. So yes, in those settings.
I: Okay. Now you think actually in the uni there is space for you to express your thoughts and your values right?
P: Yes, I think it's encouraged. In a [module related to equality and diversity], and I've noticed that the lecturer is quite encouraging in us, sharing our opinions and all. And that's space, too. There's also room for disagreement as well.
I: Okay, then, how would you think of like the social inclusion or exclusion on the campus?
P: Do you mean in terms of I get feeling integrated?
I: Yeah, it could be anything you think of.
P: Um, I would say it's good. Again like I'm currently in the space where I'm actively trying to integrate myself within the university, and its people and all. But I haven't face -- I didn't find it difficult to speak to people or ask questions if I need to. So I would say, it's good.
I: OK, then, what about in the city? How do you feel the inclusion or exclusion?
P: The city is fine as well, although I must add that when I came at first like I was a bit hesitant, because I had heard that there wasn't a lot of like black people in the city and all. And so that's already was kind of making me wonder like, how would I fit in, and all of that. Well, as time has gone, I've met other people from different backgrounds, and also it's been quite, I would say it's inclusive, but on the external, so if you just look at like the number of, for example, black people you can see on the road that can be discouraging sometimes because they aren't that many people. But at the same time I haven't faced any like racist act, or people haven't done anything to make me feel uncomfortable. So I would say, it's good.
I: Okay. And have you ever been to other cities in the UK?
P: Yes. So I've been to London. That's where I am if I'm not here.
I: Okay, then, do you find that there is difference between these kind of big cities and this small city?
P: Yes, I'll definitely say there's a difference, because there's more diversity in in

terms of the people you would see. So Manchester, for example, there was so many different people like I didn't that I didn't really know. I saw quite a few black people as well. So it's been – It was more diverse in that way. There's definitely a difference.
I: And then do you feel different when you are, for example, like in Manchester and in [a city in the south of England]?
P: In Manchester, I would say I felt -- I didn't feel that different. But in [a city in the south of England], for example, in some of my courses, I might be the only black person there. So already that difference is like right in my face. But I wouldn't say it makes me feel uncomfortable when the lecturer creates that space for me to know that I can actually share my opinions, and I haven't, as I mentioned, I haven't experienced discrimination. So my classmates as well, don't act funny towards me. I feel like I actually have that space to present my whole self. So, even though externally like I might be the only black person in comparison to somewhere like Manchester where they are more black people, I don't feel like I can't be myself here.
I: Have you ever experienced anything, for example, like rejection from a group because of your accent?
P: Um, no.
I: Okay. So basically people treat you like equally even when they recognise you are not a like British local.
P: Yeah.
I: Okay. So is there anything that happens to you with language or accent? So, for example, like communicate in English or different accent.
P: So have I found myself in a position where I use a difference accent when speaking.
I: Yeah.
P: Yes, I would definitely say so, but it's quite unconscious, so it's not something I feel like I actively have to do. But there are times where like, because I pick up on the accent that other people are speaking with, I automatically switch to that because you want to feel more included, I would say. But It's not, It's not something that happens often most of the time. I actually feel more comfortable just speaking the way I usually go. So yeah.
I: And then, do you think a language or accent is a really important part in your life here?
P: Language, I would say English. So my first language is English, but I would say it's important here, like I can't imagine if I wasn't able to speak English, how I would be able to communicate with other people. But in terms of accent, I wouldn't really say so, because no one has expressed to me that they found it difficult to understand what I've said. And in my A-level school as well, everyone understood perfectly what I was saying, so I wouldn't say it's been very important for me to have an accent, you know.
I: Okay, after we talk about all these things, is there any anything else you want to add to this interview about your feelings or your thoughts of being an international student here?
P: I'll just say, being an international student here, it's been a good experience, because I knew what I was setting myself up for, in terms of coming to the university.

And so it's been a good experience for me. The only thing is most of the time, like people say, [a city in the south of England] is mainly dominated by white people, and so those of minority groups may not feel as comfortable in coming here. But I would say that being here has been good for me personally, it's actually challenge me to want to mix with people outside of what I'm used to, people from different cultures and backgrounds. So yes, my experience has actually been quite good.

Interview 12
I: Okay first question, what's your motivation and expectation for studying in the UK or studying in [the University]?
P: Okay, so the motivation for coming to the UK is because I wanted a good master's degree. And I know that [the University] is one of the top universities in the UK you know, and then they also happen to have the January starts. And so that was a great motivation to come to [the University].
I: Okay, and your expectations?
P: Yeah, so I mean the expectation was to have a great education and hopefully a better life compared to where I was coming from you know, and then have exposured to more experience you know. Being in an international university, I knew I was going to meet a lot of people from other countries you know, learn about other cultures, and then obviously, learn about the UK culture as well. So those were the expectations.
I: Yeah, definitely. Have you made new friends here?
P: So I mean this is my, because we are the January start, this is kind of like my second term so to say. So first term, I wasn't able to meet, make friends or anything. And then I think coupled with the fact that I joined late, so the course started in January but I joined in February. And you know, so everybody had kind of formed their friendships, so to say, and then I joined late and yeah. But by second semester, second term, I was able to get to know my classmates better. And so I have one, I have one very good friend. Her name is [a name], she's from China. Yeah, so yes, I have made a good friend. And then because I'm also staying on the university accommodation, my flatmates are also, I mean, I get to know my flatmates. So I can say I've made friends like that.

I: It's great to know you have good friends here. Are you happy with your current social life? And how's your relationship with local people? I mean, do you want to make friends with British people?
P: So far so good. I think I've only made friends with the person so far. And that was recently yes. And I mean, the reason for that is because it's, you know, coming from a different culture and background, I don't really know what their likes are or what their dislikes are. And then, I don't have any, I don't have any local person in my class, we're all international students. There's also no local person in my flats, so I didn't really get that opportunity. Yes, so the only time I got the opportunity was when I wanted to buy something on Facebook market. So that's how I connected with this particular person, she's from [local city], and she was really nice and open, and then she also said something like 'if you ever need anything, get in touch with me', and so

that was very encouraging, but this only happened last week.
I: I see, but that's still nice, I mean that person is nice, and you get started to meet different people yeah. Have you met any people from your home country? Are you friends with them?
P: So I've met two people from my country. Yes, and the way I met them was we were taking some modules together, and that's how I met them. So usually when you're online on teams, you can see the people who are, so at the names you know, once you look at the name, you can tell these people are for my country, and then we're able to connect. That's yeah, how I made friends from my country.
I: Yeah yeah, so do you feel you have met your expectations by now? Or you still feel...
P: No, no, no, I wish, by now I thought I would have made more friends, yes, so I'm not really, I'm not where I want to be.
I: I see. Do you feel it's quite challenging for you to meet people? Or like, just need a chance, more chances to meet people?
P: I mean, to an extent, I'm not particularly too social. But then, if there was an avenue for meeting people, then I would go. So recently, I just found out that there was a meetup in, I think it's, it's somewhere around [a building in campus], near the swimming pool in [campus]. So they, there's a meeting there for students. I didn't realize earlier, but from September, I will start going, and that would help me. So I mean, most of the things I'm not aware of because I came late, and then it's like, it was hard for me to catch up, you know.
I: Yes, yeah, it's like you missed the time when everyone else was socialising, and also didn't get enough information.
P: Yeah, yeah, but I want to meet more people.
I: Yeah, that's good. Yes. Thank you. Okay, next question is did you ever feel understood or misunderstood by others, here?
P: No, I would say I don't feel misunderstood. No, no. I think what just happens is that, I just realized that we have different ways of thinking and reasoning you know. So I'll tell you something that happened recently for instance. There was this day in class that I was having a snack, and then someone said to me, 'don't have a snack while the lecture is teaching, it's rude'. You know.
I: Oh really?
P: Yeah, so the person was saying, 'oh, from where I'm from, it's rude'. You know, so I think it's just more like trying to understand other people's culture, and then you find that based on their culture, they expect you to know, they expect you to understand their culture as well and act like they would act, you know. So I think that's the experience I've had.
I: Oh yeah, just people need time to get to know each other and need a chance to talk sometimes. Yeah. So did you have experience that you feel someone really understand you, understand you really well?
P: Let's say so, I would say so.
I: Could you give me an example?
P: Yeah. So I mean, so what I noticed is that when I'm speaking to, I had an issue with

one of my courses, I was speaking to the lecturer, face to face, you know. So after the course, after the class, I had to speak to him, and throughout, he didn't ask me to repeat myself or anything, so I felt really pleased that you [he] could understand what I was saying. But no, he wasn't willing to help, he didn't help, you know, he didn't help with the issue, but at least he could, he could hear me, and, he understood what I was saying. So yes.
I: Oh, he didn't help, okay but he understood what you said, okay, that's still good I guess. But I understand the feeling. Is your lecture British or?
P: Yes, he's British, yes.
I: Yeah, okay. After this experience, being understood by someone here, do you think, how will this experience influence your life?
P: I mean, he's made me, it made me more confident. And in fact, I applied for a job at [a company], which is telecoms, and you know, after the interview, I left the interview feeling, you know, I was having doubts whether I can get the job. And then a week after the interview, I got a call from [the company], and they told me specifically that I interviewed very well, they were very pleased with me. And that I got the job.
I: Oh that' so good! Congratulations, that's really good!
P: Thank you.
I: Do you also feel supported here? By people around you, in general.
P: So I had issues with support, and that's because I joined late, I joined in February. So I just expect that university would kind of cater for those kinds of people, you know. So it's like, whatever has been done and discussed is already gone, is passed. If you come late, it's up to you try and catch up or, so I really struggled with that. And it wasn't a good experience, my first term wasn't a good experience at all. Most of the time, I was trying to catch up, I was trying to understand how things are done. I was, in fact, I had a bad experience in one of my submissions. My, I didn't know how to use the Turnitin, and the plagiarism percentage came up really high. Because I didn't know what it was, I just submitted the assignments, and yeah, you know, I didn't see. So in terms of support, I didn't really get as much support as I thought it's.
I: Sorry to hear that, I mean, they should do more to support students, especially for international students, you know. Anyway. But you mentioned that you started making friends this term and made several friends, do you feel you get support from your friends?
P: Yes, definitely. I mean, now, because we know each other more, you know, on my term one when we're really new and kinda like strangers to each other. There was something to have made us bind or you know, I could have made the friends earlier in term one, in term one, it was only it was strictly about just go to the lectures and back, go to lectures and back and yeah, so but now in turn to we kind of know ourselves better. So I mean, if I have a problem with understanding in module, I can, you know we've exchanged phone numbers, I can text to say, 'oh please do you understand this, what was the literacy', yes. And then apart from that we've also had time to hang out, you know to say, 'Oh, would you like to go to [a city nearby]?', 'Would you like to go to [another city]?'.
I: Yes, yeah, it's just nice to have friends, to help each other to hang out. Okay, so next

part, I’m gonna ask some questions about language. How many languages do you speak?
P: I would say I speak two languages fluently, yeah, I would say. So one is my native language, which is [the name of the language], and then the second is the English language.
I: Is English kind of your native Language?
P: Um it's a second. It's, it's the official language in my country, yeah, but it's not the native language. We only just speak it so we can all understand ourselves. Because [participant’s home country] has a lot of local languages, so English was selected to be like, the mode of communication among everyone.
I: I see, so everyone knows English so people can communicate, because you also use different languages in the country, like that.
P: Exactly.
I: That's pretty cool. So you speak English in [participant’s home country], but you know, even, even we all speak English, but like, we have different accents, not the same as the British accent. Will it bother you?
P: Yeah, I mean, yes, it bothers me. You know, but I've come to realize that it's okay to maybe ask them, you know, ‘please, can you repeat yourself?’ or ‘what did you say?’ you know, yes. And then I just sometimes if, depending on the accent, sometimes if I can't just get it then I would kind of like, escape from the conversation just because it's too much trouble you know.
I: Yeah I know. Did you ever feel being exlcuded when you talked to people, because you speak in different accent? Or say, people treat you unequally.
P: I haven't experienced that. I don't know. It could be, because I haven't, I haven't been going out with the, you know, the locals. So I haven't really, no, I haven't experienced.
I: Sometimes it's not only with the locals, you know, did you have this experience with people or students from other countries?
P: I'm not sure I've experienced that. No.
I: Yeah, yeah that’s good. Okay the last question is, how do you think that all these things, these experiences shape your life?
P: I mean, I mean, the initial thing I would say for me is, the initial thing is to crawl back into my shell. You just don't want to, you don't want to, I don't want to feel rejected. Well, you know, the initial feeling is to stay on my own, but I know that won't help me. Yeah. I'm trying to see how I can venture out, go out. If I see anything online, see if I can attend, if I see any program being organized, I’m trying to participate in as many things as possible. Yeah. So that's how I'm handling it.

Interview 13
I: What's your motivation for studying in the UK?
P: So I went to British school from 4 to 18, so a lot of the students would end up going to UK and so, I mean there're lots of good universities, good opportunities, and I mean universities in [participants’ home country] are not as good. And also I like, I want a experience you know living in a different country, even though I've already

lived in a different country. But yeah, I, oh and [the university] specifically, I mean, because it's not too far from London, like better weather you know, compared to other parts of the UK. And I visited the uni a few years ago, and I really liked the campus and like how green it is.
I: Yeah, the campus looks great. So you visited the campus before you joined the uni, that's nice. Did you have any expectations for studying here before you really joined the university?
P: I had some friends, I have some friends in the older years in [the University] as well, so I heard they really enjoyed themselves and it's a nice like pretty quiet small town. But there's still lots of like, there're still nice places to go out, clubbing or like bars or whatever.
I: Yeah, this town is small but quiet and good for living.
P: Lots of students around as well which is very nice.
I: Have you made friends here? Are they mostly from the same backgroud as you or more diverse, like from other countries?
P: I know a few friends who went to the same school as me, different nationalities, mostly British who went to [the University] as well, and so I'm friends of them. Most of my friends are British, I have a friend who's half British half [participant's ethnicity]. I went to the [home country] Society events, but I found that most of the students were like Masters or PhD. Yeah, because I guess, you know, for some people it's expensive to study in the UK, so like, I mean, not a lot but like some international students, they only go to the UK for like postgraduate.
I: Yeah, yeah. So most of your friends are British, then how better do you feel you fit in the British culture, the British society?
P: I think that I mean, growing up in a British school around like, I mean, my school was 50% British, 50% International, so growing up in a British school has already given me like a good idea of what the culture is, like what the society is, like you know like music, like humor, all sorts. And so I think that's why I found it a bit easier making friends of British friends whereas I haven't lived in [home country] or Asia for a long time, I guess it's quite different experiences. And so I find that I've adapted to society quite well, yeah, I haven't been down to any issues but I think my experience is quite unique compared to some other.
I: That's good to know you fit in well but still, did you meet any challenges and difficulties?
P: Um, not really, everyone's been quite nice and friendly. I mean, to be honest, the only that like racist incident I had was actually a local, this young kid, I was just on [a street] and then yelled out, like seven eight year old yelled out like [] and it upset me quite a bit but I'm, yeah I haven't encountered any racism from students.
I: Oh sorry to hear that, I have met once too, I stay in the UK for four years and I've met once, like someone passed me and said []. Honestly I was really shocked then I'm like, thank god he didn't attack me, that's very horrible experience. Anyway, most people are nice, so. Is there any other challenges you met, like finding places to live or something?
P: No no, um I will stay with four British girls next year. Um sorry, there is an insect,

one second.
I: That's okay. Okay, next question is, in general, do you feel people around you can understand you well?
P: I think so. I mean, sometimes they're like, sometimes I mean, you know, [the city] is quite a white town. And I mean, I have a, so my friend who's half Malaysian half British, I grew up with her in [a country] as well. And so there are some things that she can understand about, you know, feeling like you stand out from the crowd sometimes, because her friends are also mainly like British and white, so she also understands. But it's not really like the issue that I get upset about, but occasionally, you know, something would happen or where I'd feel like, you know, not the same as my British friends, but generally, it's okay, I can talk to my, my closest friends about anything. But at the end of the day, I mean, it's not their fault, but they won't understand like, racism, compared to, you know someone who's Asian.
I: Yeah, I understand. Can you tell me more, or give me an example, like describe a particular situation that you feel really understood or really misunderstood by someone?
P: Um, like, misunderstood or understood by my peers?
I: Like anyone around you.

P: I mean, I feel generally quite understood. Because, yeah, I mean, I have some other friends as well, who are like, half Indian half British and so they also, you know, they also understand and so, I think it's good, like having people who have shared similar experiences to you. And oh, yeah, I mean, I had a conversation with my friend, so he's black, black British. And once we're just walking to the club, and we're talking about how sometimes it feels like, I mean, not our friends, but like some British people, they only go for, like other British people. And I mean, sometimes it's true, sometimes it's not. But you know, he also understood, and you know sometimes he, we feel a bit insecure. But then also to remember, like, everyone's different. And just because, yeah, because I mean, both of us, we are in like British friend groups and so, you know, sometimes we think, ‘Oh, wait, why is my friend getting all these boys? Why is my friend getting girls?’ And then, you know, there's also so many other factors, you know, sometimes it might be my fault, it might be me not putting myself out there or something like that. So it's not necessarily like, ‘oh people are racist’. Yeah, so it's good to have like, the other friends of colour who can understand.
I: Yeah, it's nice to have friends who have similar experiences and have same feelings about things, I mean that makes people feel understood, right?
P: Yeah. And even if I talk about it with my British friends, like, they'll try to understand, of course, yeah.
I: Yeah, yeah it’s still nice of course. Then, do you have a specific example of being misunderstood by people?
P: To be honest, I mean, I'm quite privileged to say I don't think so.
I: Okay, yeah, that's fine, don't worry. Okay, so in general, you feel people around you can understand you pretty well, and even they don't, they are trying to understand you, right? Does this experience, this feeling make you, for example, more open to talk to

people? Like, any changes you have?
P: Yeah, I'd say it's added to my confidence. I mean, like, it's not really a misunderstanding. But for example, I mean, names, so my full name is [] and so technically my first name is [], family name is []. Because when I was younger, my family and parents always call me [], like my full name. So sometimes our friends will ask my last name or whatever, and I'll, I'll explain and they say, you know, 'it's quite interesting; oh, I didn't know that about [Participant's] culture' or something. So in a way, like, you know, almost a blessing in disguise but, you know, I have my parents that I've grown up with my name being called [full name] instead of just [first name] or something, because, you know, as a way of educating people, unintentionally.
I: Yeah, yeah, I see, so your family is giving you a different cultural background, that's something others won't understand sometimes, but you can always explain, right. Yeah. Next question is, did you have the experience that people treat you differently because you speak English in a different accent than the local people or say British people? I'm not sure if you have this kind of experience though.

P: I mean, generally, because my first language is English, and so it's been like, fortunately very easy for me. I mean, the closest thing I can think of is like sometimes, you know, like I wouldn't know how to pronounce like, a British town or something. Or sometimes I'll say a word and maybe like in an American way or something, because I've heard it on TV or something. But my friends, I mean, my closest friend, he'll make a joke about it, but not in a mean way. I mean, I can imagine like having a strong international accent and you know like the language barrier, I mean, is difficult sometimes. Yeah, I mean, fortunately, I haven't gone through that but I can I understand.
I: Yeah yeah. I don't have more questions, do you have any questions to ask or anything else you want to share?
P: Can I add something?
I: Yes.
P: So I mean, you know, my parents, they always ask me, 'why don't you have more Asian friends?', and I mean, of course I wouldn't mind having more friends you know, from the same background, but I found that, you know it can be hard because a lot of international students stay in their own groups and cliques. Because I mean, but it is natural, and I think it's fair, because I mean, moving to a new country is not easy you know, you want to have some people who going through the same thing as you, who understand the same like potential issues, but, and then like, from an international point of view, you know, sometimes it can be harder, or like, more intimidating to talk to these, like British groups who are so fluent in English, who you're worried, or they may not understand your accent. And so I think it's a hard thing you know, assimilating like, you know, like breaking the bridge between British and international student groups. But also I understand, you know, the British point of view, where you know, let's say as a Briton, you're worried that these people might not get the same jokes as you and your friends or might not have that much to talk about. And so I

don't think it's anyone's fault. Like, in terms of the divide, I think it's natural. I mean, if a bunch of British students moved to America for uni, I think, some of them would so stay together, because you know, it's hard to assimilate in a new culture. Like, I mean, language is one thing but culture as well and like you know growing up with different TV shows or music, different historical influences. But yeah, I think it'll be like, I don't know how, but it would be nice to break the bridge. But at the same time, I don't think it's anyone's fault. It's not easy. It's simulating like different cultures, but as long as everyone's respectful I think, and willing to learn more. Yeah yeah.
I: It's really nice to hear this. Yeah, I agree, it's not everyone's fault, it's just, like always being hard for people to join a new environment, especially when they have different languages and cultures, of course something else would be different too. Yeah. So, from what you've talked, I feel you're actually closer to the western culture, to British culture, so I don't know if I understand you right, are you saying it's not easier for you to make Asian friends than making British friends?
P:Yeah. I mean, I visit [home country] every summer holiday, and I have some I have lots of cousins, but I don't really have like friends that are, I mean the only friends I have in [there], like my mom's friends' children like that kind. I haven't spent time there. You know, I didn't go to school or do any activities there, like just visiting the holidays. But I mean, I think I could, because generally I'm quite a talkative person, talk to lots of different people, and so I could, but at the same time, like the place, I mean, I don't see that many Asians, like in the clubs that I go to or the pubs. Yeah, and in my accommodation, there weren't many, because I think some international students as well, like they go private accommodation. So I mean, like, it's also a matter of like, just where I am and just like, wrong place. I mean, not wrong place, wrong time, but just different place different time. In so like, my accommodation, I think there was, I mean I was in on-campus accommodation, and there's like 40 people in the building. There are a few people from like South Asia, Africa, but not really Asia, like East Asia. And so it's just like coincidence really, but like sometimes, I mean, do you know the club []?
I: I don't know actually, where is it?
P: If you go past [a restaurant], and then you turn right.
I: Oh I know, I guess I know where it is.
P: Yeah. So on the nights that I go, I only see maybe like, by less than five, like three to five East Asian girls as well. And so like, because there's not many of us, like in that club on that certain night. Like, usually I'll just talk to them. And so like, that's how I actually met a friend, a Singaporean friend. She grew up in Singapore all her life, she went to International School and so her friends are like a mix of British and international in Exeter as well. But I mean, even though we didn't know each other at all, I think one day, we were both probably intoxicated and we both just started talking you know. Just, it was like we just asked each other ‘Oh, where are you from’ and stuff, it's nice to bond over something like that. So yeah, I mean, like, given the opportunity, like if I do see like other Asian girls and stuff, like I'll talk to them, but like, I mean, for example, you know [a club], I used to go there a lot a few times in my first term, but then I didn't go there as much and I know that there are more

international students.
I: Yeah, yeah. It's not very often to see East Asian people in a club, I know. Most of my Chinese friends they don't go to club, I used to go to club but only with my European friends. I mean, it might be because like, I think it's like cultural difference or just generally feel unsafe, or like unfamiliar to that kind of environment.
P: Yeah, yeah, unfamiliar. Yeah I mean I guess British students, you know they've grown up in you know like they also maybe went clubbing earlier and they know what British clubs are like what British pubs are, and so it's more familiar, like it's not really a scary environment or like there's less hesitation.
I: Of course, I think so. And so it's kinda like a gap between international students with local students, that we don't do some of the things they do, and then, like we don't know if they want to make friends with us you know, and same for them.
P: Yeah. Like it's not easy, I mean. It's already a hard thing talking to a new person, any kind of new person. And let someone who you know probably has not shared the same culture and so like what do you say from both sides, it's not easy.
I: Yeah yeah exactly. And I'm curious, do you have friends from other countries, other Western countries?
P: Um, I mean, so I met Singaporean friends, a few, I know a few like British Indian British Pakistani. Yeah.
I: Yeah yeah, like they have a similar background as you, I mean they have the British background but also their own culture.
P: Right, yeah. Like I think that you know, even though maybe some of the friends I've had, even, I mean I don't think they will, but even if some people I've spoken to, like hesitant at first you know, once like they get to know me and I get to know them, I think they realize that you know, like, there are international students who they can talk to, and so sometimes like I think it's always a blessing in disguise in a way for me, because I hope that, by me, you know sort of like being in the circles and stuff, teachers and British students that, you know it's okay.
I: Yeah, it's really great to know your experience you know, I mean your experience is quite unique compared to others, I feel you are seeing things in different ways.
P: Yeah, yeah and I think it's important to like learn about British cultures. As an international student, we chose to go to their country. I mean, it would be nice to learn about international culture, but you know there's so many countries you can't learn about every single one, but we are in the UK, so it's good to make an effort and yeah, I think, sorry there's one thing I wanted to add, is that okay?
I: Yes, of course.
P: Because, I talked about this sometimes with my family and friends, because you know, it is quite a unique thing. But I found that the badminton club has been very international, I mean some sports are more British you know, like rugby, netball, hockey whatever but I found that like in badminton it's been quite nice because I mean badminton is a very Asian sport, like I've seen sports and activities is a good way for, like British and international students to mix. Like the committee which I'm in is, I think one of the most diverse sports committees within Exeter you know, like half British maybe like half international, so I think activities is a good way to bond.

I: Yeah, yeah, I mean I don't really know that, but yeah that's very interesting to know.

Interview 14

I: What's your expectation for studying here and living here?

P: Um, my expectations, actually, were fairly basic, I just needed to have, I use my masters and my undergraduate facilities infrastructure as a standard, so I just needed to have a library and some sort of institutional building and a decent place to stay. And I feel [a city in southwest England where the university located] has, you know, sort of surpassed all of those expectations a lot. I really like the campus, the facilities are fantastic, the place, the people are nice, houses are nice, so there's not much to complain about. But yeah, I mean, just in terms of like livelihood, I feel like everything is a little quiet sometimes, but I think that helps the studying, so I have no complaints.

I: Yeah, and do you have any expectations for like meeting different people, making friends?

P: Yeah, I didn't really think about it too much. When I first arrived here, my intention was just like to study really well and do really well in my course and managed to figure out my professional goals you know, while I'm here. But yes I met a lot of people here. And it's really, it's actually been one of the best parts of my past year that I've met people, not only for other [same ethnicity], definitely very active [same ethnicity] population, so you don't feel away from home very often, but more than that, I met people from Palestine, from even other people from the UK, from the US, and it's really nice. I find it very interesting to meet new people and just see it from backgrounds. I think it really broadens your mind, makes you think of things that you otherwise wouldn't have thought of. And it's really really fun.

I: Yeah, friends are really important in life. Yeah, I have met lots of home people here, in my department, that's quite amazing I feel, and you know I also have friends from other countries, but still you know people from home country are quite different.

P: It feels nice because you have a sense of being at home that you can talk in your own language, you can eat the kind of food you want to eat, and that feels safe, it feels warm. So whenever you're okay, you want to go out meet other people, but I like having the option of switching into who speaking in [a language] or eating the food I want to eat at home, because everybody are very nice. Yeah.

I: Yes. But have you met any challenges living here?

P: Um, up till now, not really, which something I'm very happy and very grateful for. I do sometimes feel a little bit of, like that certain opportunities that I apply for, not to do with my main course, I think my main preferred, my main sort of PhD has been fairly straightforward at the moment. But when I apply for smaller internships or projects outside my PhD, then at times I felt like there is no good reason for my application not being accepted. So for example, there was a small, I think there was a ‘phone from home’ that the university was organizing, where we basically students pick up the phone and talk to prospective students and parents. And we had, all of us applied the same position and we all got email saying that you haven't been accepted.

So for me, I felt like, I mean, you can sort of, if it's just your application that has been rejected, you can sort of understand, but then we saw that everybody in my, in my circle, who was [same ethnicity as the participant] was rejected, and people who I have spoken to who have gotten the job have been British. So I felt like some things like that, I think there's an assumption that, that our English might not be that good, or we might not be very confident speaking, which is why we weren't selected. So sometimes, I mean, it's a suspicion, and there's no proof I have that it's happened for that reason. But at times, I do feel that there is a certain preference for British students or white students as compared to non white students. But it hasn't affected my preferred main professional life. It hasn't done that, so I'm not making, this is on the side. Sometimes I feel that there seems to be a preference, like people who are white seem to be getting ahead a lot faster than people who aren't.

I: Yeah It's kind of, feel a little bit unfair, like sometimes I don't feel it's my problem, maybe they just judge me by my English or something else.

P: Yes yeah, I'm sorry to interrupt you, I find that maybe sometimes also, it's something that, it's something you can't prove, right? Like, maybe you're being like, sometimes I feel like maybe I'm being too defensive, maybe there was something in my application that wasn't good enough or something, that's the most tricky part you can't prove that it's happened because of that reason, nobody will admit those things. I think that's what makes it a little tough.

I: Yeah. Apart from that experience, how much do you think your speaking patterns or your accent influenced your life?

P: I wouldn't say too much to be honest, because back in [home city] as well, I've studied in English medium school all my life. My mother tongue is not English, but I am much more fluent in English as my mother tongue. So that I think really helped, both in my application and my interview. It also helps when I give presentations, because I've been told that there's a good command over language. So a lot of people I feel, even amongst PhDs, some people despite their background, they have a little bit stage fright, so whenever they have to give presentations or conferences, they're a little hesitant, and I don't have the problem. So I'm very happy talking to people, whatever PowerPoint, whatever, even without preparation, I can do it, no issues. So in that sense, I feel my speech or my accent hasn't come, hasn't been a hindrance, it's been a benefit, actually. But I have seen it with other friends of mine, I have seen him with other friends who maybe come from the south of India, who have learnt English, but they speak their mother tongue more commonly at home, so their English grammar is not that good. So a lot of them struggle with writing long paragraphs, like if, for example, they're writing reports then their grammar might not be correct. And that's pointed out very heavily when they get their feedback. Those haven't happened with me luckily, thankfully enough, but it has happened with them.

I: Yeah, I know, for me, English is not our first language and we don't really speak it. So it's really a big challenge for most people to learn it and to be confident to communicate in English. Yeah, yeah same to me, and I also know some people still have problems speaking English even after finishing their study, they just feel really uncomfortable communicating in English.

P: Like I have some, I have some friends of mine who are Malaysian Chinese and Chinese who live in my building. I think in the beginning of the year when I came here, one of them came to me and asked me that, you know, the readings he had to be doing every week, and he just kept coming to me to ask me if I could help him read one reading. And that's when he told me that it's so difficult, like it takes him like three times the same amount of time to do one reading. And the class expects him to do like, say five readings in a week. So he was really struggling with, like 'how am I supposed to do so much? I'm struggling with the pace of it'. That's about it, yeah, but we and that's why I understood like it'd be very scary as well, like, everybody around you speaks in English, lectures are happening in English, material is given in English, writing is supposed to be in English. And if that's not something you're confident in, then I'm sure that must have been really really hard.
I: Yeah, yes. And I would like to know your thoughts about that for international students, will it be easier to make friends with other international students than with British students? I mean, even some of the international students can speak English pretty well and some of them can't, but they all kinda know English could be a problems so then being more patient to others?
P: I agree with that, like that is that does tend to happen. Like I feel like a couple of my flatmates, we actually ended up having conversations early in the year because of that. Like we all understood that you're going through the same feeling and I think it's easier because the other person will be a little bit more patient like they will understand where you're coming from, I think British people don't, they take it for granted that people speak English, so they would have less patience with you. But I also feel that sometimes it's easier to stay within your group. Like if I'm an Indian, and I can't read English very well, it's much more safe and comfortable and easy for me to stay within a group of Indians only as come as opposed to, especially when I had that option. For example, if I'm from Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, but I don't have my own country people around me as much, I will find the next group, which is the most ethnically close to me, and stick to that group, as opposed to going outside and meeting somebody else. So I've noticed that a lot with people who are from particularly East Asia, where it's easier for them because of language barriers to stay within their own group. Some of them tend to step outside, but not everybody. Like the general trend that, I've noticed is that we'll talk during professional conferences or professional meetings, but to step out of your comfort zone and start a conversation with somebody and go through that every single day about, you know, struggling with the language becomes a little uncomfortable for people who've studied outside one's home already or something like that. They tend to be a little bit more friendly, like they tend to open up and talk about their insecurities and, that tends to happen.
I: Yeah, yeah. Thanks for sharing these thoughts, I do feel the same. Another question is, is any people around you who make you feel that they really get you, they really understand you?
P: So I think that does happen, but not in its entirety. So, at times when I'm like, with my closest friends who are all [same ethnicity as the participant], then none of them are from my course, they're all masters students. So I think a few of them understand

like personal parts of my life, like they understand the kind of person I am, the kind of things I like doing, why I'm doing what I'm doing, what I like to eat, and they know when I feel sad, I feel happy, that kind of thing they understand very nicely. But I feel like the PhD is such a different way of living, and a different way of working, that somebody who's not from your costume, or from a history background, may not understand it. So in that sense, I feel like there's a little bit of dissonance, where my working patterns, my studying patterns, when I need to be working, what I need to be doing, what kind of work interests me why I feel insecure about my work. That's something they don't understand really well, I found that a lot more people who aren't in PhDs, who are in the second year or third year, they are a lot more understanding about that person, but in my life, that from my sort of my worries with the work, but I haven't until now found one person who can do both things, like I haven't found somebody who understands me in entirety as of now, because I think there's quite less number of [participant's ethnicity] doing PhDs here, at least in my department. Yeah, I only know of three and we aren't very close. So like, if I have professional concerns, or professional problems, I can go and talk to some friends, but I don't have somebody who understands me in time and priority.

I: Yeah, I see. It's really hard to find a person who understands you totally, but it's okay as you have several friends and they understand different parts of you, of your life. So at least you, if you have things to talk, you can find someone to talk. Then do you feel people from the same country as you can understand you better than British peers, or people from other countries?

P: Yes, I think at a certain level yes. Because they, they already know a lot of background information. So if you imagine yourself as a painting, they already know they're familiar with the colors you're using in the background. They're familiar with the trees, they're familiar with everything, so you don't have to explain everything to them. The details of the painting, you might have to explain to them, but that doesn't take too much effort. When it comes to somebody from a different country, you have to explain the entire painting syndrome. You know, you're starting from scratch, talk about how families work in [home country], how mothers fathers work in [home country], how your particular social background and how that impacted your life. So I have, I mean, I've made a lot of very close friends here who are not [from home country], but to open up to them, requires me to start from scratch and explain everything to them, which sometimes takes too much time. So my friends who are from [home country], just because they know the background already, like just because they know a lot of things that I was talking about. It's not like they know me from the get-go. It's not like from the first moment we've been very good friends, I think with anybody you need to develop that relationship. And so on some days, it's nice to talk to somebody who has no idea about your cultural background, like some problems you want to have a different perspective on. But overall, I would say yeah, I think it's easier to be understood by somebody who is from your own country, just because they know the background, right, they know the background story. So it's my thought.

I: Yes, I agree. Sometimes it's just easy to talk to people who have the same

background with you, especially at the time that you already feel quite down and need people to understand you. Then you need to explain more, you know, I may prefer to stay alone.
P: Yeah, it's not like, it's not their fault. Like, it's not something you can hold against them, they just don't know, right. So there's so much of cultural difference as well, like, a lot of my English friends, if I have fight my parents back home, if I talk to my English friends about it, they will not understand what the big deal is like, their relationship with their parents is so different than how our relationship with our parents is. So to even communicate like that, you know, like we don't have drinks with parents, we don't go on vacation with our friends with them, it becomes a little like, it becomes more like a curiosity like you describe your country to them. But when you're when you're looking for comfort, and you're trying to be vulnerable, then comes a little suffering sometimes.
I: I, like, I don't know, I think we probably have similar feelings that you know in our cultures, like lots of things have a very long history, so if I want to explain this, I need to explain the history. So I always found it hard to really tell them what's happening, or need to explain a lot.
P: Yeah, you can explain, like on a day when you feel it then you can explain it. Like the other day, I was talking to a friend of mine, who's an African origin, second generation UK born citizen. And so I was talking to her about the class system in India, and it just, it was all news to her. It was all like, 'Oh my God, that's really happen', they were not talking about the problem I wanted to talk, it became about the history of the class system and how it's like, 'so interesting', and 'so bad' and everything. So then it becomes more of a point of how interesting this conversation is, as opposed to moving on to what you actually want to talk about. Right.
I: Yeah, yeah, that, they would just feel like all of these are interesting and that's something they don't know about. But that's my, that's not my point. Yeah, I understand. Then have you had any experience of feeling misunderstood by someone?
P: Something that, umm I don't believe it's happened to me yet. I don't believe that this idea of misunderstanding has really crept into my life at the moment. Because I haven't been in a situation like that, as of now I feel like. I've travelled a lot sort of like, in and around [a shire in southwest England] nearby, just some day, like a day trip two days or something to smaller places. And even that has been very, very, like, in the universities, like in [a city in southwest England] University, I can't imagine a place where I will be misunderstood like that. Because I mean, I can communicate fairly easily, everybody around is usually international students, so they don't have the kind of discriminatory tendencies. But even if you go to smaller villages, like [a town], or you go to like [another city] nearby, over there, sometimes I might be stared at, because I might be the only [participant's ethnicity] person in the vicinity. But apart from that, I haven't, I haven't really experienced any of that yet. Sometimes I feel a little bit weird because supervisors, I think, like there's a sort of work ethic problem, like in the sense that I think East Asians or Asians we end up taking work very seriously, and then of taking criticism very seriously. Because for us, it's like, because usually I can, from my perspective, I can say that there is very little work life

balance, right? Like at home, also, we're always asked to work very hard, make something for ourselves, and you know, put a lot of pressure on our professional life. And over here, I feel like because they don't come from background like that, so sometimes I feel like it's a small, small misunderstanding. But sometimes I feel like it's difficult to communicate that to my supervisors that there is a lot riding on the fact, that this is my PhD, and I'm doing it right now. And, like, if you email me five days later, after I've given you a deadline, then it's not working out for me, like I'll be panicking. Like, even for the upgrade, it was supposed to be very relaxed time of the year for me and I was working quite nicely, you know, like slowly building on my work. And I think one week before my submission, or five days before my submission, one of my supervisors who hadn't been replying to my messages for a very long time, back to me and said that in all caps, that if you submit this upgrade document, you will fail because your referencing is really bad. All caps, exclamation mark, exclamation mark. So in that moment, I felt my heart stopped. I just like I almost started crying and I felt my heart stop. And sometimes I feel like they wanted, they intended to do that. Because when I spoke to them at the next meeting, they did apologize, they didn't mean to do that, or they didn't have that impact. But I feel like they need to understand us maybe if they were, if the other person was [same ethnicity], they would have understood that we work really really hard and we receive criticism on our work, we take it really really hard. Like we can now be like, okay, you know, that's it, we'll work on it tomorrow at 6pm, I'll shut my laptop, I'll go for a drink or something. We don't do that. We keep working until 1 am, 2 am, and just because we are so nervous about what we're doing. Yeah, so it's too small things, but I feel like, I mean, it hasn't become a big issue for me yet. I feel like this is these personality changes happen anywhere. And I personally, I quite prefer the way these guys work. They work from nine to five and they don't work up to five. That's compared to how we work at home.

I: Yeah, sorry for you, like that really made you uncomfortable and upset. Well, I mean they probably are nice, just being quite direct about things. For us, it's just not encouraging.

P: I mean, I have two supervisors. One of them is very, very nice and the other one is like, she'll be very direct and not intelligent, so I mean, I didn't know that before, now I know it. So I'm trying to prepare myself for it a lot more. And I keep telling myself that, whatever it is right now, it would have been much worse in [home country] believe me. So I'm like, okay, it's fine.

I: Yeah, sometimes we just need time to get to know each other. Yeah. their style, the way they talk. But at the meantime, I'm sorry to hear this, I can really understand that feeling of 'heart stopped'.

P: Yeah. I mean, I definitely in that moment, I remember I shut my laptop, and I went outside my room and crying. I was just like, 'oh no please don't say that to me', I mean, I call all my childhood best friends up, and I was telling them what happened. And all of them are giving me all sorts of advice. You know, all these boys. Like, most of my friends are guys and guys have a different way of reacting, like girls will hug you and tell you that you will be alright, guys like (telling you) you should do this do

that, so it ended in a long run. But yeah, that was a difficult moment to go through.
I: Yeah, yeah, really a bad moment, but luckily you have gone through. Okay, the last question, I think you already mentioned some, do you feel being supported? From university, your supervisors or friends.
P: Um, I feel from my supervisors, I think that the least amount of support, I feel like, I don't have a very close relationship with them at the moment, which is sometimes a little worrying. But again, as you said, like I think it will develop over the years, you can't expect to become close to everybody immediately. They have supported me to a large extent whenever asked for support, but I feel like I've always had to ask, which is a little difficult, people like I feel, like, you don't feel like ever saying, 'oh, I need help' you know, like, and if you are saying you need help is got really, really bad. From their side, I haven't seen like a forthcoming way of like, 'oh, let me help you with this', or 'if you need anything', maybe that's how PhDs work, maybe it's supposed to be self motivated completely.
I: Yeah I see what you mean, it's hard to ask for help sometimes.
P: Yeah I feel generally, I feel like it's hard for us to ask for help. And we are, I think people, I'm working with one Indian professor who's teaching us how to read and write or, and I think my relationship with her is a lot more bomb because I think she understands that there are certain things we will not do out of like culture, we will not do like we will never go and tell them 'oh, you know, I'm struggling with my work this weekend, I need your help', we will never do that. We will just wait till the deadline, work really hard towards deadline and then submit the work you know, so we will never reach out and ask for more help or ask seem like we're doing demanding. That's a cultural difference. So I feel like my British supervisors don't really understand.
I: Yeah, true, I mean, yeah in our culture, we won't just ask for help, we maybe do after building the relationship but not at the beginning.
P: Yeah, especially for like, especially if it's like a professor-student relationship. Like, for us, it's very hierarchical, like, even calling my supervisors by the first name something that they kept telling me, oh, call me by my first name, I felt that was, like, I kept using their second name and saying, and always from a point of like superiority, like, you can never call them on WhatsApp or just say hi on WhatsApp whatever, there's so much of a difference, even if they don't think what we think of it that way. But that's, that's them. From my friends, I've faced quite a lot of support, I feel like they've tried their best to help. But I guess again, a lot of PhDs is doing it your own way, because your pattern is different. And the way you study, what you're doing is so different, you can't really help, you can't really expect one person to be with you throughout the day. So a lot of my friends, like we used to have study sessions together. So during the upgrade of the examinations, we have a group to study together, which is really helpful. I made some very nice friends within PhD cohorts of different departments, not my department necessarily, but in the Palestine Studies Department, in sociology department. And that's been very nice, because they really understand. They're all in their first year, so they understand what you're going through. And it's quite similar, even if what we're studying is not the same thing. But

at least you understand the pattern and the sort of, it's been very helpful because they get to more conferences that I don't know about and then they tell me, and you can extend information like that. That's quite nice. But yeah, I mean, in terms of the staff of the university, they've been very, very helpful. My other friends who I go for, like gym with or other classes with is also helpful. So I think people from across the board have done little bit, have contributed a little bit. And in general, it's been nice. It's just with PhDs, you can't help but feel a little bit isolated sometimes, especially with now the end of term coming, near the end of this year, all my friends or master students will leave and so I mean, that's a challenge vs. British people, we have to face you know, but apart from that, it's been good.
I: That's good yeah. Do you feel you're fitting in the new society in the new environment now?
P: I do, I do feel that I feel like initially it has to be a little more hesitant about going places like, feeling confident about going into places, I think now and that's also not to do with like just social behaviour I think, like if I and my friends are working together down high street, for example, and she's British and I'm not, if somebody sort of crosses our path someday she'll say hello and good morning you know, how are you, like that. Initially, I would not do that because it's not like I would feel uncomfortable, but I would not know when to do, when is the right time, or should I say it right now. That, I think, over the past year, I've learned how to do that. Like I've learned to say it, and I think you end up saying that, I think people here very nice they don't mean to be mean to you, they may be going on with their day, I think there are so many international students, they don't know what to expect, so I think if you would just being polite, if you make the first move and say good morning how are you, just a little nicer little more polite I think everybody is gonna be quite happy. It just takes some time to get used to be able to say it first.
I: I see, I see. Sometimes making British friends can help a lot to fit in this society. They can teach you the way, like how to act or react in some cases.
P: Yeah definitely, yeah and also like how to walk into a place, you know, it's not even like I don't think anybody intends to keep you out of some places, but I feel like initially when I see a restaurant, with only white people in the restaurant, I also assume that this is not for students, it's too expensive or I'm not supposed to be inside here or something like that, but over time, when I went to places with my friends, then I realized no it's not like that you know. You can still ask for a glass of water, things like that. So I think a lot of it is in our minds, as opposed to their minds, we are assuming a lot of things, a lot of barriers and, you just have to learn or get the confidence.
I: Yeah yeah I have the same feeling. Like friends from home ofc can make me feel more comfortable and safe, but making friends with British people really helps with a lot of things, just like you said, more confident or know how to do in a situation. For example, how to write an email politely, make it sound nicer, you know.
P: Yeah yeah, that's very helpful, even understanding how they receive calls, how they respond to somebody, it's very nice like, a small example when you have people on the streets asking for money, I think the way of dealing with it was just keep your,

just don't look at them, just keep looking ahead and walking past, right. That happens a couple of times, I'm just not looking at them, just walk past them, I felt very mean, but I can do that. But the other day I was walking with a friend of mine who's British, the person asked for change and she just looked at him and said 'I'm so sorry I don't have any, but would you want some food instead'. And he said, 'oh no it's fine, you have a good day and you two have a good day' and then he walked off, and I was really surprised.
I: Oh yeah I'm surprised too, you can just say it!
P: Oh like now, when I walk past them and they ask for changes, and I just politely tell them 'I'm so sorry I don't have any, have a good day you know'. It just you feel like you begin to pretend these things, , you won't find it in the book, you just have to pick it up from experience.
I: Yeah that's true, that kind of thing, you just need to learn from others, no books will tell you how to do, and after you learned that, then just feel finally I don't need to be mean or impolite.
P: Yes, yeah.

Interview 15
I: Are you doing a PhD here?
P: Yes, I am. But I also did my undergraduate at [a city in southwest England].
I: Okay. How long have you stayed here? Stayed in the UK I mean.
P: I've lived here for five years, it's going to be five years in September I think, yeah.
I: That's cool. Is English your first Language? Oh sorry, [a language] is your first language of course. How many languages can you speak?
P: Um, so I speak [a language] and English fluently. I can understand and read Spanish but can't really speak it. I'm like, at an intermediate level with French. I've started learning Italian, but it's very basic at the moment.
I: Wow, very impressive, you can speak five languages!
P: I mean they are all at different levels, but yeah.
I: That's actually really cool, I tried to learn some languages, but hard.
P: I think when I'm bored, and I just pick another language, it's probably like a good hobby to have.
I: Definitely.
I: Are you first year PhD?
P: Yeah, first year.
I: Me too, I'm doing [a course]. Okay. So, what's your motivation and expectation for studying in the UK? And maybe you can talk about your feelings from the first year you studied in the UK.
P: Yeah, I think my first year was really hard. I think, you know, no one, I think it's always going to be hard, because you come from a very different educational background, even like British people struggle. But it was a completely different educational system from the [home country] one, I was being asked to do things I'd never done, like write essays or think critically really, so that was quite challenging I think. And just, you know, settling into a new country, you know, becoming an adult if

you will, yeah, it was quite challenging here. But since then I've settled down a lot more, I've really enjoyed my time here. Yeah, I mean, it's probably why I'm still in higher education. If being terrible, I probably would have like, stopped after my undergraduate. But now it's been, yeah, I would say first year mostly was very challenging and there have been other challenges. But overall, it's been a very positive experience.
I: Yeah, first year is always being challenging. Why did you choose to study in a different country not just studying in your home country?
P: Um, so I wanted to do [a course] at University, I was pretty set on that. And in [home country], it's pretty much knowledge, it's pretty much like accepted, that unless you're going to certain disciplines, you're probably not going to find work. Well, you're probably not going to end up working in that area after graduation. So I was very set on [a course], which doesn't have a lot of exit routes. And also, the courses in [home country] felt like they would be very boring, very theory based, not really looking at real world, not really engaging with things like [a topic] which is where I was very interested in. And, and in a sense, I think I always wanted to come and study abroad. I just didn't think it would be something I do as an undergraduate and maybe like as a Master's student, but like, it's a long story, but basically, I finished high school abroad, and didn't manage to get a place, but ended up speaking to someone who said, you can just apply directly to UK universities. So that's what I did. And it was mainly because of that. And I wanted to study [a course] and I knew I wouldn't do it in [home country].
I: I see, I mean you made right decisions, right. Well, did you have any expectations for your uni life?
P: Um, I think I was, I'm not sure if I had any expectation. Yeah, I knew that was going into a better educational system, I knew that like [the university] was much higher ranking than any university in [home country]. So I think I had expectation of academic rigour, academic excellence, but also it felt like it would be quite hands-on with tutorials and lectures. Yeah. I think those were my only expectations.
I: Did you have expectations for making friends or contacting with different cultures, something like that?
P: Um, yeah, I think I was quite worried about all of that, yeah I mean, as you would be. I think I was quite lucky because I joined like group chats very early on. And I was talking to people that also had offers for [the university] for a really long time before actually, you know, moving to [a city in southwest England], so I need like, at least a couple people, which I think really helped. So yeah, I think I was a bit worried about like, making friends, but I already had a few, so I was, I felt like a bit more confident about that. I was really worried about language, I remember spending, I remember spending couple of nights lying in bed really worried about people not understanding me or making fun of me or, you know, classes being so advanced in English that will just not be able to keep up with. And I think those are like the main two things. I don't think I really considered like how moving abroad can actually affect your day-to-day life, I think, it was a very naive 18 year old.
I: Yeah, I can't imagine going to a foreign country at a young age, like, I came here at

about 21 years old, it's not a young age, but I still feel I don't know what to do, I know nothing here, and I don't know how to make friends you know, everything is different, it's just difficult living in a foreign country.
P: And it's, I think that's the thing, I think I just didn't understand how much the culture will be different. I remember walking into Sainsbury's for the first time to be in complete shock. Because I knew where anything was, I was like, this is not my supermarket at home, I didn't know where things are. Yeah, it's always hard, I think.
I: Ture. So back to your first year, you also had some language problems? Because for me, honestly, I feel you speak like a native, so I don't know, what was your problem with English?
P: I think you're right, I mean, thank you. I think that really depends, like I know, especially when I'm meeting people for the first time, I can, oh, what's it called, I think just basic, basically that, but I can just get really stuck, or almost have like, a stammer trying to get words out. And I always feel quite on edge when like new people or people that I know aren't also international students, because I think there's the sense of, 'Oh, it'll be fine if I mess something up, like no one here will judge me'. But yeah, it definitely changes and there are just words still I cannot pronounce or mistakes I make. Ah, yeah, you know quite basic. I will always be making those mistakes.
I: Oh yeah, I'm having these problems too. Do you feel people treat you differently or, unequally, because you are not native speaker?
P: Um, I think I'm very privileged because my accent is very neutral, or it's, it sounds quite, you know, American, which I think makes people treat me differently than if I sound very distinctively foreign as in like, [home country] even. But what I think has always been really interesting is when I say to people, ‘oh, I'm [ethnicity]’, or, you know, ‘I've just moved here like a year ago’. It's the way that they react to it, like there's always such a shock you know, like, your English is so good, which is a lovely compliment, but it also feels kind of backhanded. You know, like, I think when you were an international student, you know how many steps you have to go through to even be considered. English tests still haunts my nightmares, it does sometimes feel a bit condescending, like, I didn't know what people expect, but you need to be at a very high level, just understanding and speaking English to even be considered. So that feels sometimes a bit, I don't know, I don't think people have bad intentions, but it does come across as a bit condescending.
I: Oh, I see. I didn't really think about it, but yeah now I feel that. Okay, and from your experience, do you think, um and how much do you think language or having an accent will influence your communication with other people or even your daily life?
P: Yeah, I think it definitely does. I can remember in first year, especially being just really afraid of like putting my hand up you know, and commenting on something for the whole class. I think it took me most of the first time to get comfortable, even with just speaking to my tutor. Yeah, because of all of those questions of am I going to make a huge grammatical mistake? Am I going to just forget what I was trying to say? Or they're just not going to understand what I'm trying to get at. I think it also stopped me going and speaking to, like my tutors, because I was just quiet. I think that, you

know, in a way, I felt very confident but more with my peers, than we're talking to like tutors or lecturers. And so I think that would be like the main barrier, I felt was just, yeah, lack of confidence, or, you know, just being I think a lot of it was also being worried to how I was going to be perceived. Like, I didn't want anyone to think I was stupid, or that I didn't deserve to be there, because like, I couldn't pronounce a certain word. Or because I, like I took a longer time to make my point.
I: Yeah. Sometimes I feel, I'm worried that if I can't, like you said, take a longer time to make a point, then people will just lose interests on what I'm going to say or think I just can't make a point because I can't speak English well, you know.
P: Yeah, I think for me, it's more often I just can't remember the word. Or there's a very specific expression for it that I'm trying to translate that maybe doesn't translate very well. And I don't think people have ever like stopped listening to me, but they have cut me off before like, I think it's just a thing as well within tutorials and I think maybe with some [a course] students that if point isn't coming across very quickly, they're kind of, they will cut in, they will make their points.
I: That's just their style right. It's definitely not friendly for me, I sometimes speak slowly in English because I can't make a sentence or can't find words. I don't know if you also have this experience.
P: Um I'm [ethnicity] and we speak so fast, I don't think that slow was an issue for me. I think I just had a lack of vocabulary. Like I remember going to my first restaurant, and just blanking because I didn't know how to ask for food in English, like knowing that context, and just kind of imitating the friends I was with, or just you know, asking them like 'how do you ask for food?' you know. And there were things like, how much do you want the steak cooked, I have no idea what they meant. Or like going to the hairdresser's and asking for certain things. I don't think for me was the slow to me, it was more just that lack of knowing how to ask, and knowing how you go out certain interactions.
I: Yeah, yeah I know, the restaurant thing is kinda, typical, I still have problems knowing the names of food, you know sometimes, they are not even English, so I can just point at it and say 'can I have this please'. And I need to read the descriptions of the food so I know what I'm ordering.
P: Sometimes there's something on the menu, it's like a type of meat never heard of before you just like googling what is veal.
I: Yeah, yeah. But at the meantime, most people are quite nice, like they understand that you're a foreigner, so, even we don't ask in the right way but they can understand. However, do you have any negative experience?
P: No, I don't think so. I think, you know, people have always been very nice. And, yeah, there have been times especially at the hairdresser's where I've had to maybe move through it more slowly, I could tell I was annoying the heck. But you know, but she, it ended up being fine.
I: Yeah, at least it ended fine. Um, ok, do you have many friends here?
P: Yeah, I would say so. I have as much friends as I would want to have. Yeah, I have, like, just a close group of friends.
I: Are they most British or [participant's ethnicity] or other international students?

P: I think most of the friends I've had here are British. And I've had like a few international students on my course, but no [home country] friends.
I: Did you have British friends since first year?
P: Yeah, I already had a few from that group chat I mentioned. But also, I then made quite a few friends in my course or my friends' courses. And I think most of the group tended to be British.
I: I see. Do you feel your friends, in general, can understand you? I mean, not just understanding what you say, also understanding your feelings and stuff.
P: I think, you know, back in first year, or even before I came to uni, and I was communicating mostly online, it was sometimes tricky to communicate, like, you know, something that happened or how I was feeling or just things in general. And also, there's just so weird differences, like cultural differences, even how you write a laugh. So, in [home country], we often do lots of ‘k’s. And the first time I put that in the group chat, no one had any idea what I was on about. Or, you know, just different ways you'd go about saying things. It was a bit of an adjustment period. And I think most of the time, people understand me pretty well. Sometimes I need to like, expand on what I was saying, yeah, maybe get my point in different words. But I've also found that some times, and these haven't been like people that super close to me, but people that will hear you may like say a word wrong, and think it's really funny, and we'll just repeat it, can sometimes be a really weird position to be in. Because you just feel a bit like, well yeah, clearly I made this mistake. But I think it's different who it comes from as well. I've been situations before where I've gotten, you know, really annoyed, at some points, pointing that out, and keeping pointing it out. But yeah, I would say usually, I think people can understand me, I'll drop some like [first language] sayings as well, that makes like, no sense. But it makes no sense in [participant’s first language] either. So it's not a language barrier really.
I: Yeah yeah. Is there any example that at a moment you feel someone really misunderstand you? It doesn't have to be your close ones, just anyone in general.
P: Um, I think it's probably happened before, especially in my first year of living here, where something I was saying just wasn't being pronounced well enough to be understood. But I think it probably turned to be more words. And I will just try to say many different ways. I mean, it still happens. Yeah. Like, I don't know, I sometimes my brain just forgets how to pronounce them, and that can create that can lead to questions or people be like, oh, what does that mean? And, but it I think it's usually been quite small for me. Or you know, I've transplanted a [participant’s first language] word into a sentence I'm saying, or I've just made it sound slightly English. And sometimes, because it is a word here, and sometimes you just have no idea who I'm talking about. Or I feel like sometimes I'll use expressions that are very [first language] and people just don't get at all. Or I think it has happened before, I think it's really interesting is how you express pain. Because I feel like you will always express pain in your mother tongue. And [home country] people are very vocal, so go 'Ow'. And I think I find myself sometimes doing that. And I do wonder if people around me think I'm hurting myself somehow or if I'm just like, making sounds.
I: Yeah, yeah that’s quite funny. Did you meet any [same ethnicity] here?

P: I think I met with a Brazilian person or two, but I also think I was very, I don't think I put myself in a position to find out [home country] people. I think I was more just interested in making friends because we connected in some way. Also I think I also didn't want to become too reliant having people that spoke [mother tongue]. Yeah. To kind of feel, you know, inserted in the community. Yeah. But in a way, it is a bit of a shame. I think I've only met like, two or three people that were [same ethnicity], and we've always had, like, nice conversations. I think as well for me, and I don't know if this is just something that everyone feels, but I find it deeply embarrassing to speak in English and then switch to another language with the same person. So I think I'd really struggle to have like, [home country] friends and they will hear me in both languages. It's just really embarrassing. Like why would you do that?
I: Yeah, I mean I understand that, so I don't speak English with my [home country] friends, but still, sometime you can't avoid that. I feel bit embarrassed to let them hear me speak English.
P: It's just it's very weird. I don't know how to explain, just feel really weird.
I: Yeah agree. But do you feel having some friends from your home country can provide more support? Like, especially emotional support?
P: Oh yeah. I think in my first year I started, I struggled a lot with my mental health. And I think it would have been nice to have, you know, even someone that was very, you know, I had friends that came from Paris or Brussels. And I think it would have been helpful to have talked to them about, like, you know, their experiences and how they were adapting. Yeah, but I also feel like at the time, I wasn't, like really ready to talk to other people about it. But yeah, I do think maybe having more [home country] people in my friend group would have been nicer, even just to talk you know. There's just always going to be things that you can explain to English people about your food, your culture, but they're never going to get. So maybe yeah, it would have been nice.
I: True, and I'm sorry to hear that you struggled with mental health, how do you feel now?
P: I think, you know, it's just a really different experience. And it can be really gruelling. And, you know, I think moving abroad on your own, wherever your age is always a huge shock to your system. And you're just learning how to live in a very different language in a very different culture. You don't have your support network with you anymore. So yeah, it is quite tough on time.
I: So did anyone from your first year provide supports? or make you feel supported? Did the university provide anything to help?
P: Alright, so I started feeling anxious as soon as freshers week ended. So, I think I was probably feeling that way throughout, but because there was so much going on, I don't think I really realized that, you know, I was not feeling okay. And I think it took me six more weeks to go and speak with someone with a professional well-being services, like, I was talking to my boyfriend about it, and he was, you know, very supportive. But he did say, you know, maybe you should go and talk to someone. Yeah, I think I put it off for a long time, because I was just, you know, saying to myself, it's probably just homesickness, you know, it's a big, it's a big change, maybe it's just that. And I did go and had an appointment with wellbeing, did CBT for the

number of weeks, they give you CBT for, and I do think I was given good support. But I also feel like, I mean, the number of weeks of support you get is just not enough unless it's a very minor issue. And I think mine was, it was just going to need a lot more work than that. Yeah, I also feel like, I do wonder if, because when you're an international student, if wellbeing almost attributes homesickness, and this change, big change in your life, as the only reason why you're struggling, or if they're like, plays a big role in how they see it. Yeah, I would say I was given good enough support, but I also feel like the way I was struggling was very specific to me. And, and I don't think CBT was the most helpful way to go about it. So since then, I've had, you know, a few years of private therapy, which were very good. Yeah, I would say CBT wasn't great, just because it didn't, it helped a little bit, but it didn't change.
I: Like they didn't really solve the main problem. If you could just try, or they tell you to change your behaviours, that's not what you need, that's not very possible at that time.
P: Yeah, exactly. And I think as well, I feel like there's just a lack of support for international students generally. I think people I mean, I don't know how it goes on, but I feel like international students are probably not consulted about the kind of support they need. Like I remember there being a huge focus on I think, like edge classes at the beginning of the year, which I'm sure would be helpful for some people. But it felt very much like, we will help you with your English and everything else kind of on you. And I think it would just be nicer to just have a bit more targeted support maybe.
I: Yeah I agree, but sorry to let you talk about these experiences, it's not very pleasant for you.
P: No it's fine I mean you know, it wasn't a really tough year and was really tough at that time, but I'm in like, in a different space now. And I think, I've said, maybe looking back, I would have done things differently in certain things, but you know like it's I think just kind of part of growing up, you know, knowing where to go for help, all of that.
I: Yeah yeah, it's good to hear that your experience, your life is much better after that period of time.

Interview 16:
I: What are your motivations for studying in the UK?
P: Okay, well, the thing is, at least in my high school, it was very, like studying in the US and UK was the seen as very prestigious you know, what we expect from there is to get very high level of education and also that, plus also they teach in English. So you know, the English is going to be good. And yeah, just lots of courses on offer, and just you know, the Russell Group and all that.
I: And what's your expectations?
P: Um, I thought it was gonna be very, like intense, like, very difficult. But the IB (International Baccalaureate) ended up being much worse than university. So I like all the professors and here is very international, and lots of societies, so I really enjoy that.

I: Yeah, yeah. Have you met any challenges living here?
P: Challenges? Well, you know it was COVID when I came here, it was 2020, so that one. I guess main challenge was when I first came, was to find my way around. Like, the campus is so large, and they're like, buildings all over the place, so finding your way around, because no one really shows you where to turn up at the lecture and know where you're going, yeah that's the main and also, kind of the main challenge was like being part of like societies and stuff. Yeah, it's quite challenging, but like some societies post on Instagram or some Facebook, some group chats, so you have to kind of figure out,so you start meeting people.
I: So do you feel it's quite difficult to make friends here?
P: I mean, at first yes, but societies help a lot. So if you join one society, you meet someone, and then you meet their friends and their friends and stuff. Especially shared accommodations.
I: You lived in a university accommodation before, right?
P: Yeah, I was at [a building]. So we had some flatmates there, yeah, honestly, societies was the best way to meet people.
I: Yeah, it seems you have lots of friends now.
P: Yeah, well, yes. Also, I would like to meet more people ofc.
I: Ofc, so are your friends most from the same country or same background as you? Or maybe you want to meet people from other cultures more?
P: Oh I see, for me, because I I joined the Singapore society and the Korean society. I also joined like one Scandinavian society event, but they were all like Americans, none of them were actually Scandinavian. But the reason I joined those societies is because I had a friend in that society. I mean, lots of people through there. But like, yeah, I have mainly, I have lots of postgraduate friends. And because, I don't have many British friends to be honest, because it's hard to fit in with them. And they're known to be very posh, very like posh British, they are always together.
I: That's funny, but it's pretty cool you joined the Singapore and Korean society. Yeah it's kind of like that, I met some friends in my accommodation in the first year, they are from different countries, and then they brought me into their societies and met more people.
P: Yeah yeah kinda like that, that's the best way honestly.
I: It's really helpful. Okay, yeah, so this question is, did you ever feel misunderstood by someone, or at any moment you feel being misunderstood?
P: Oh misunderstood, um, I mean, not that I'm misunderstood, but sometimes, like if I have some British friends and if I hang out with them sometimes I don't get their like British sense of humour or something, I don't get it. Or like random references I don't know. But mainly, I mean, it's not uni related, but at work, sometimes we have quite a few, like, you know, like mainland Chinese, they come and ask for, like products or something and they can't speak very good English. What my coworkers do, which is very annoying, but they like, instead of speaking slowly, they speak fast but just louder. It's not gonna help you know. And then they get like, visibly irritated. So that's, that's like, the most clearest example I think of it.
I: I feel that's quite funny and stupid that they don't speak slowly but speak louder.

P: Yeah, I know! And I'm just, I was, I went to my coworker and I asked her to, like, find this specific product she was looking for, and she started speaking louder and faster. And I'm like, 'you know, they are not going to understand that', Like, they're [the costumers] confused. And then I like spoke slowly and stuff, and she's just like, 'okay okay' and left. But yeah, and stuff like that, it just irritates me.
I: Yeah. Could you tell me more about what you are thinking at that moment?
P: I was, felt bad for the customer. And I thought the British are very, like, they can be very, like snobbish or nice. Because if you don't, they get annoyed with you if you don't speak English right. Because then they're, first of all, most British suck at languages. Also, if you don't speak English, they don't even try to understand you. Yeah, that's the main thing. You know, so they can be quite ignorant or like, communicating in those circumstances.
I: So, does this kind of experience happen frequently?
P: Ah, once in a while. The thing is I don't meet that often, but it does happen. I have some, I have like one Chinese customer who come, who came in like a couple times and he always came to me and asked for help.
I: Oh is that because he can understand you? compared to other staff.
P: Yeah yeah, I think they can understand me because I, I speak slower. And then I try like more simple you know, not like, because my coworkers they tend to, they just speak fast and just unnecessarily complicated words you know. So for example, if I'm selling a face wash I will just say like wash face, this and then, I just simplify it. And then just you know, like take time to understand because it's sometimes if they don't understand the first time, they get annoyed.
I: Yeah, it's hard for foreigners.
P: Yeah. And most of them, their English is fine but the British, they're just very stubborn so.
I: Yeah yeah. Ok, so, did you have any experience of feeling understood by others? Or is there a particular situation that you feel understood?
P: I think most of the time I am. I am like, I do feel understood. However, for me, if I don't get a joke, or if, this is a thing that English is my first language. However, if I spelled something incorrectly or say it incorrectly, I just use the excuse that I'm [foreigner], when English actually is my best one, but like, they don't know that. Yeah. So they're like, okay, okay, okay. So I get I have slid that in a couple times. But yeah.
I: How many languages can you speak?
P: English and [a language], but English is my best one. And a little bit [another language].
I: Cool, so English is actually your first language, so you generally don't have language problems living here, right?
P: No, just sometimes like some British, you know, slang or I'm just like, ‘Oh, I'm [foreigner], I don't know that’.
I: That's quite normal, not understanding the slangs. How do you feel about that, like, not getting their jokes and slangs? Do you feel that bothers you?
P: I mean sometimes like, it applies to a couple like, I don't know, English, like

historic references or football or jokes and I'm just like, I have no idea what you're talking about. Or like TV shows and stuff like that. Like references to those that everyone knows except me and you know, I just try to get along with it.
I: Yeah understand. Then, how do you feel about having an accent in communicating with people? In your case, I guess it will be not having a British accent, do you feel people sometimes treat you differently?
P: Not like treating me differently, but I have people like, I have many people like, guess where I'm from. Like, they can tell that I'm [foreigner]. And like I thought I sounded American, which I'm glad.
I: Really, wow, I don't feel you have any [international] accent though.
P: Oh and for me, sometimes i pronounced words incorrectly, my friends just laugh and then they correct me. That's it.
I: Okay, I see. You know people from some other countries, they may be not good at English or have a strong accent. So sometimes they can, they have different experiences, like feeling that British people ignore them because of their accents.
P: Yeah, that's true, that's true. But yeah, I mean, because sometimes it goes with the understanding part, or it's a very strong accent, yeah and they won't really want to listen, especially if it's American, then they make fun of it.
I: What do you mean about making fun of Americans?
P: Like sometimes in the store if we get like a real American customer then my British coworkers like, ‘Oh my God, Americans’.
I: Is that real that British people don't really like Americans? I heard some people said that before.
P: Yeah. And just the accent because it's so loud and like, umm it's just different, you know.
I: Oh that's funny, yeah, and good to know.
P: Yeah, but no, I don't think it's a problem or something, It's just they make fun of it to be honest.
I: Yeah, yes. So you have stayed here for two year, do you feel anyone really support you here, and do you feel the university gave you enough support during these two years?
P: Like, in terms of, like academic or?
I: Academic, emotional, literally everything you can think.
P: Um, I mean, turn to social, welfare, all of that I haven't really had to use. So, apparently, there seems to be quite a lot of stuff going on about it. I mean, like services available. So I'm guessing that's good. Academic, I'd say so so. Because, for example, in my first year, I had problems with my course, like, I tried applying for a different one. So I applied for economics and medical sciences and the whole thing was a mess. So they like said one thing. So one person said, ‘yeah, you're in the course’ then the other, someone else says, ‘No, you're not’. And it just went back and forth. And like, yeah, a long time. Uni is slow, and replying Emails are slow. And the worst thing, like there's a hierarchy, so if you call, for example, [a building], something if you call, they won't know anything, they're completely useless. So they always had to ask management, and that takes a long time. And everyone's always on

holiday and they're just so slow and inefficient, and very annoying.
I: Yeah, I know. For me, I also called several departments to get my CAS done, it took a while, because no one can really gave me an answer, they always just tell you to contact someone else and you even can't find those people.
P: I know. But things honestly, there's quite a British thing. And even at work, there's a very, like, it's a hierarchy basically. And it's just they don't even think about, especially international students. They come so far away. They had to, like get answers quickly you know.
I: Yeah, agree.

Interview 17:

P: I went to an American school for a few years, so I had the accent left.
I: So do you mean you stayed in America for several years?
P: It was like in [home country], but American School.
I: I see. How long have you been in the UK?
P: Three years. Because I did a foundation here. So I'm going in, so yeah it's going to be three years now, it's going to be the fourth year, yeah.
I: Cool. So could you tell me what's your motivation for studying in the UK?
P: Well, I think I really wanted to go to an English speaking country. So it was kind of between America, Australia, and the UK, and the UK was the closest to home, and universities were the least expensive. And I kind of thought that it would also have a big international student base, because like people from all over Europe especially, would come there. And I also saw that it does have like a lot of international students, which I really liked. And yeah, I always just kind of wanted to, like I always plan to go abroad for study, like leave [home country] and then UK was just like, the ideal option.
I: I see, yeah, did you have any expectations before you came here?
P: I don't know, I wouldn't say so. I think I had less expectations and kind of like, when I got to university with the, I don't know, the whole student life, it kind of went over my expectations, which I was really happy about. I did think, I don't know, my expectations were kind of like, it's really easy to meet people, it's really easy to socialize. Mostly like those two were big things.
I: Yeah, yeah. Did you have many friends here?
P: Like I have, yeah, I think we have like a little circle. It's not like a really big circle, and it's all just international people that are like, yeah, and a group and then just like here and there random people from the course. So um, I have like, I don't know, five or six people that I hang out with constantly and then, like people to go out with, people to I don't know, meet for campus and stuff like that. But they're all, yeah, they're all international students.
I: Oh, what countries are they from?
P: Mauritius, Portugal, Pakistan, Dubai. Like everyone is from a different country.
I: That's really cool, yeah. Did you meet them in your course?
P: Yes. So Well, no, I met a few of them during the foundation year at INTO. And

then some of them met new people in first year and then we just kind of like, made a group out of it. So I don't think I don't think I hang out with anyone from my course. I don't think, I think it's mostly just like people from that I met on the outside.
I: Okay. Do you find it easy to make friends with other international students? What is the reason you think make you become friends, like, do you feel you understand each other better or something?
P: Yeah, I think we just clicked more, like we had more in common in terms of being in a different country and like, being international students and like, with British people, I also noticed that they tend to kind of like stick together. And I feel like it's like when people usually do tend to go more towards the people that they live in the same country with because they have more things in common. And even though like with my friends, like we're not from the same country, but we have that in common, which is like being an international student. And then we're kind of like bonded over that and just you know, getting used to living in the UK together.
I: Um, have you met any people from your home country?
P: No, no, met one, I think for a while I was in hunts for people from [home country], because there was absolutely no one from [home country]. And I think I met one girl, but she was doing like her third year, so she left now. So I'm starting to do the, I'm the only one there.
I: Oh, I see. Sorry that I don't know much about your culture, is there any country that has similar cultural background with [home country]?
P: Well, it's in the Balkan areas, like, east of Italy. So it's like, it's Eastern Europe, kind of. So I think we're very similar to like, Eastern European countries, like especially, I don't know, Serbia or Bosnia and countries like that. But also, like, similar to Poland, similar to the Czech Republic. Like it's very, it's very Eastern European country, yeah.
I: Do you have any friends from those countries then?
P: I haven't met any really, no, I met like, I think no, not really. Yeah. It's weird. Yeah.
I: Oh yeah, that’s pretty weird.
P: It's like, I don't know. I just, yeah, I don't know. Like, I know that in Eastern Europe, I can't speak for every country but I know in [home country], like people don't tend to go to study abroad, and if they do and if they go to the UK, they're more prone to go to London or Manchester or Leeds or like city, so everyone that I know that is setting in the UK, they don't really go to small towns they go to more like bigger cities. Yeah so might be that.
I: Why did you choose this small town?
P: I don't know, I really liked that it was a student town, and I don't know, there was a campus, everything was on campus so I wouldn't have to like go around the city to lectures, locations, all that. So I think I really liked the campus. And I kind of I wanted to because I lived in a big city my whole life. It's not really big, it's really actually small, it's like 1 million people, but for us, it's the biggest city in [home country]. And so I kind of really just wanted to go somewhere like small, where everything is just reachable, approachable and all that.
I: Yeah, understand. And for me, I want to stay in a small village just, you know, feel safer.

P: Yeah, exactly. And that's a really safe city, which was a big thing so.
I: But also, living in a small city sometimes is quite boring.
P: Yeah, it gets really boring. Yeah, that's true.
I: Yeah yeah. Will you sometimes think that it may be better to have friends from [home country], so that you connect to each other better?
P: I think so. I think like, I see a lot of people who meet with people from their own countries, and you know, they speak their own language, they can, they can make comparisons between their country and the UK, and just like really on a much closer level, because they're from the same country. And I kind of always, like missed that a little bit. That's why I was on a hunt for [home] people, because I really thought like, I would be really happy if someone I knew was from [home country]. So yeah, I definitely like, yeah, I would definitely, I wish there were more [home] people not even like hundreds, you know, a few.
I: Yeah. Yeah, I totally understand. But with other international students who are not from [home country], do you still feel that you can get support from them, being connected?
P: I think so. Yeah. I think like, we get along quite well. And it's really interesting, because there's so much diversity in the group. And because like, everyone comes from a different culture, everyone has like, different backgrounds, so it's like, really interesting how it's all brought together, because literally every single person is from a different country. And it's just like, yeah I think, I don't know, I think I would get the same amount of support as I do if I had [home] people there. Like, it's really, yes, it would have some benefits more, but ultimately, like, support wise is really really really good with these people, too.
I: Yeah great to hear, that’s nice having these people around, right. However, did you ever think of making friends with British people?
P: I did. Like I joined quite a few societies, and I do have a few like, British people. I do, I do have two British guy friends who I get along really well with, they are one of my closest friends. But like, and I did join societies, and I did join, like, I did go to sports and everything, but I still never really completely felt like we clicked in the right way. Not because there was anything wrong with them or were wrong with me, it's just we had different interests, which might just be like, because of who I am as a person, like, what my interests are what I like, but yeah, I don't know. I also lived with people from the UK, both in my first year and my second year. And it's not that we didn't get along, it's just like, I kind of isolated myself a little bit because I didn't really feel like we had a vibe going on. Yeah, so it's not that I didn't try and it's not that like, again, that anything was wrong with it. I just always felt like I had more of a connection with international students.
I: Yeah understand. And for them, they don't really have to make friends with us, I feel.
P: Yeah, they're in their own country there, it's much easier. They have their own jokes, they have their own banters and it's really, once you get into it, you first have to understand that. I know the first few months that I was in the UK I had so much trouble even trying to understand what they were saying, like it's a completely

different just sense of humour and everything so.
I: Yeah, I know, like even we can use English fine, but still don't know the jokes. Yeah. So since your accent is neutral I wonder if people can tell you are not a local.
P: I think they always get that I'm American, or like, European American. So yeah, never [participant's ethnicity] and I never in my life got asked if I was from [home country], which is fair enough, it's a small country, but it's always either like Russian or American.
I: I see, so they can tell you are a foreigner, by your accent, well then, do you feel, in general, they treat you differently because of your accent?
P: I don't think so. I think I never got like that type of feeling that it was like, 'oh, you have an American accent that's weird' or anything like that. Um, but I would notice that like, when someone would notice that I'm not a UK student, or that I'm not British that it would like, they would tend to more migrate towards someone who is British, at least that's like, in my experience, they would, I don't know, if we're in a group of people, and I would talk to someone and we're like, having [a conversation] you know, but like, as soon as they, not all of them, obviously, but like, I did have a few experiences like as soon as they noticed that you're not a British student, like, they will say 'oh, you're international', which is yeah.
I: Like they kinda mean to, no, not mean to, but still kind of ignoring you?
P: Yeah, in a way. Again, not all of them. Like I had some amazing experience with British people. Yeah, so. But I did have a few times where like, they do notice that you aren't a British student, and they kind of being like 'alright, okay'.
I: Yeah, what was your feelings at that moment? Or your emotions, reactions?
P: I was never really bothered by it, I would just kind of be like, because it kind of goes both ways. Because I would also like tend to be more close to international people. So like I do understand that it's normal for people to go to what's familiar to them and was closer to them. So I was never like, again, they could they could say the same for me, they could say the same like, oh, international students tend to not hang out with us and everything, so it could really go both ways. But again, I never really like minded it. Because I was always really happy with the friend group that I had with international people. And I just knew that I also just didn't completely, like get along with British people. So I never really like minded.
I: Yeah, I agree that it goes both ways, so it's hard to say what's the reason, or complain why they don't talk to us, ignore us. But still sometimes, this experience is unpleasant, people may get upset.
P: Yeah, they can be like, yeah, it might kind of like disheartening and feel like they don't belong in Exeter or something. Yeah, I don't know.
I: Yeah, and you know some people just interrupt you or something.
P: Yeah, it can be really uncomfortable. I think they sometimes just think like, oh, they're international students, hence, they don't know how to speak English well, hence, I won't even bother to talk to them, because yeah, like annoying or something.
I: Yes, exactly. Okay next, think about people around you, could be your friends, acquaintances, or just someone you meet in the street or shops, did you feel anyone really understand you?

P: I mean, yeah, I guess like my close friends and everything. I feel like for me, what I do is because, [a city in southwest England] is a small city and because there isn't really much to do and much places to go to, just like be alone, I often just decide to go home in the middle of the term. Because that's where I feel like the most comfortable, like whenever I get overwhelmed, either by people or with uni, or with anything, and it just kind of gets to a point where I can't like manage it anymore, I just go home for a week because it's really, go to [home country], it like costs 20 pound you know, it's not expensive. So I pretty much whenever I reached that point, I think even in [the university] I can't say that, I have that, I don't know, full comfort yet, but that's kind of expected because I'm not from there. And you know, I miss my family at home, my friends at home and just like literally just being on my couch at home, like the simplest things which I just sometimes lack in [university]. So yeah, but then again, yeah, I guess I get the most like support and comfort from my friends in [university] that I really get along with. But again, sometimes that's also like, sometimes you just need your mum and dad.
I: Of course, like it's family, that's where we belong.
P: Yeah, definitely. Yeah. Where you grew up and everything, so.
I: Yeah. Can you think about an example, just to describe a moment, a situation that you feel really understood by someone?
P: I mean, I don't know, I think it's when, I guess, I don't know, if there's a period where, where I don't really feel like I'm, where I don't really feel like I'm being myself, like, I don't know, I started to go out too much, I started to, I don't know, not clean my room every day, I started to I don't know, fall back and lecture, stuff like that, and then I'm just like, right, I'm overwhelmed. I'm spiralling into something that's just not me like, or sometimes I just don't leave my house for like a week, because I just feel really uncomfortable to be or go anywhere. And then I usually talk to my, I think my closest friend would be the one from Pakistan. And she would usually like, because it all just comes down to, just being homesick and just like, missing the routine that you have at home. Yeah, and then like it completely changing when you get to [university], obviously, because like lectures because of uni because, yeah, just a completely different lifestyle than I have [home]. And I think she would always just like really understand that, and she would always just, like, know what to say and kind of know, like, how to calm me down, mainly because she would also go through similar things.
I: Yeah, that's really nice to have such a friend, understand your feelings and can comfort you. But just curious, your closest friend is from Pakistan, I don't know if English is her first language, so do you feel there's any difficulties when you communicate with each other?
P: Not really, because she also went to an American school, which is quite lucky. Yeah. She also did like the foundation year, which also had English and I think most of us, like most of the people that I know, really do have a good level of English, which is like, sometimes they're like, there's like a little communication barrier. But almost, like, rarely really. So it's really easy to talk to.
I: I see, thank you. Um, well then did you ever felt misunderstood by someone here?

Still, not only your friends, just people in general.
P: I don't know. I think, I think like in my house, I'd say last year, I lived with nine people. Well, there was nine of us in total, quite a lot, and they were all British. And they're all people who I lived with in [accommodation] in first year, and then because like houses go off quickly, so like in October last year, we decided to get a house together. And then I was like, I wasn't really close to them, but I was I would hang out with them way more. And then kind of in second year, I completely stopped hanging out with them like I would never go to the living room, I would barely go to the kitchen, I will just stay in my room most of the time, because for me it was when I get home, I usually prefer to just like, go in my room and chill, and just be by myself and like, get rest for the day and everything. Whereas they would, like meet in the living room and drink and stuff like that. And I just like I didn't really like that. But I also really always felt bad to tell them because I thought like, because I felt like they would say ‘oh, she's the international student and like, she's doing some weird thing just not hanging out with us’. And they did approach me like a few times, like, 'did we do something wrong or anything?' I was like, no, it's fine. But it was just because I never felt that connection with them. I never felt like we really got along in a way where I would completely enjoy hanging out with them, specifically, like they had a different type of like sense of humour, they had different interests, different jokes, different things that they like to do on a night out, like, yeah, just everything pretty much and I just I never fully like couldn't, couldn't put myself into that. So I think I don't know if misunderstood would be the right word to use, but I guess that was like a situation throughout the whole year where I just like, I lived with them, but I was I literally would just like be in my room or be at a friend's house or anything because I just like, didn't feel like I got along with them to a level where I would feel comfortable with them and stuff.
I: I see, it's not really like a misunderstanding, but still you don't feel that they understand you, something like that.
P: Yeah.
I: Yeah I get it, but sometimes it's just simply because we don't have similar habits. I know because I also lived with people from different countries before. Yeah and some universities, they just arrange for British students to live together, so they do things together. I mean, I sometimes feel their life style is weird, but they may feel the same, so it's nothing wrong, just different.
P: Exactly. Like, I need my alone time like, every single day, or sometimes I need a few days just be alone, whereas they, at least in my experience are like together 24/7. And I can't do that. Like, I also can't like, again, after I get home, I like to go to rest and everything, whereas they will talk for hours more in the living room, and I just don't like it.
I: Yeah, yeah. Right, like even living with someone from the same background, it's still, they still might have very different habits, so ofc, it's gonna be harder to get along with people from very different backgrounds.
P: Yeah, yes.
I: Okay, the last question is like, how do you feel the supports given by the university,

or your friends, and communities? Like have you been supported enough?
P: I think it's good, at least in my experience, like I think I reached out to wellbeing a few times. And I think like they always responded quite well and they always like, would give me someone to talk to, they would also send me like a bunch of links to different people's like an email like inside the university but also outside the university. And they, so I think in terms of that, at least in my experience, like well-being worked out quite well. And I did feel like I don't know if I had to apply for mitigation or something where I deferred one module this year to finish it in somewhere, like, they were quite understanding and everything. Yeah. So I think in terms of that, yeah, it's quite well, but like outside of the university, I don't really know.
I: I don't know if I can ask this, so you don't need to answer it if you don't want. What is the reason that you went to the well-being centre?
P: I think it would just be in those moments, where I didn't really feel like myself, where I would just notice that, things that I would use to make me happy, which I would do that on a daily basis, which could be writing, which could be drawing which could be cooking, getting up going to town, getting coffee, like all those things which are really small things I would notice, that would completely be stopped doing that, I had periods where I just like wouldn't want to leave my house for a week, like I would literally not get dressed, clean my room, do anything, go to the door, but like no, today is not the day. Or well just be like there weren't be moments where I felt like me and my friends, wouldn't be like we'd kind of be on the outside, I know everyone would just separate a little bit, I felt a bit like, I just didn't really feel comfortable that kind of be like myself, I felt like I would be losing myself. And then I would also start I don't know, missing lectures stuff like that, and those would be the moments, where I would like to reach out to well-being and also probably just go home for like a week or two just to get back into everything but yeah mostly like that.
I: Yeah, yeah, I did have those moments as well, just feel there are so many things to do but I don't want to do, then just feel really depressed, so I just tell myself everything gonna be fine just need to finish this.
P: Then there's always something else.
I: Yeah true, but things gonna be better eventually, right. Thank you, that's all I want to ask, thank you so much for joining the interview today.

Interview 18:
I: Have you stayed in the UK before?
P: Yeah, I've been to the UK a few times. My partner is actually from here, we had a study abroad, so we kind of spent a little bit of time back and forth.
I: Did you really live here for a long time or study for a long time here?
P: I think it was maybe like three weeks or so.
I: Okay.
P: So this was my first experience, like really being entirely immersed in English culture.
I: Yeah okay. What is your motivation for studying in the UK? Is your partner a part

of the reason you study here?
P: I mean, it was, it was a different consideration, I think it drew me to take a look at the programs in a different way. But for me, what brought me to the UK and also specifically [the university] was the actual topic and the courses, because I wanted to study [a course], but I wanted to do it from a specific lens. And there aren't very many programs like this in the world, so that was a really big factor. The actual program was really what brought me here. And also, if I wanted to do my master's in the [home country], because the programs are longer and actually expensive than it would be to do it here because it was only one year, even though it's international fees. So because, you know, my partner kind of made me look at different universities, but ultimately, it was the degree itself that kind of brought me here.
I: I see, did you have any expectations before joining the University? About your life here?
P: Do you mean like studying or living here? Or both?
I: Oh Both.
P: So I definitely have some expectations. I mean, I had some, but I was kind of open to like just seeing, especially because I moved here in September, end of August in 2021. So I knew that because we were still kind of figuring out where we were at with COVID, looked different than it ever had before. And probably it was, so I knew that it was, we were just going to see what happened. But yeah, I did have some expectations, particularly in the school system, because I did my undergrad in the [home country], and the school system is very different here. So I think it was quite a rude awakening, I think in a lot of ways, I expected to be given a little more hands on help, because that's more common in the [home country] part of it was hard to tell, because this is a master's degree where I did an undergrad, I knew that there was a different level of what to expect and a higher level of education or a degree. But there are a lot more hands on in the [home country]. It's much more independent learning based here. And it's a lot more of, you know, what we're learning, figure it out yourself. And I don't work extremely well in that as well as I do with having more hands on learning. And you know, there was also the pandemics that people were still kind of figuring out how to do in person again. So I knew there'd be a lot of transitional things. But yeah, it was definitely really hard when I got here and I did feel quite a lack of support, I think in a lot of ways. And particularly. I'm studying [a course], and I came from a [different field] background, I did my undergrad in [another course]. So I was brand new to [the course participant studied]. I had some experience quantitative with, you know, statistics, but doing anything coding based was brand new. And I did expect quite a bit more support than I think what I got, it was a lot more of like, Trial by Fire, figured out yourself, google it, kind of stuff, that was a bit disappointing. But I think overall, I adjusted to the expectations, I guess. And it was it really was just getting back into school. I also had five years in between my undergrad and my post grad. And so it was getting back into a different system in a different country, a higher up level than I was used to after the pandemic and when five years had gone by between what the education system wasn't as now. So a lot of adjustments.

I: Yeah, I understand. Because we too, like in [home country], people will help you, teacher will help and give you lots of things. Even though you may have to learn by yourself but they give you everything you need.
P: You have to figure out yourself here. And, very difficult and I not... I'm gonna be honest with you, I resented it a little bit when I got here because of being international students were paying significantly more, than what they're paying, and to be told, like figured out yourself. And there was an assumption of like, well, this is just how we do it here. So you need to assimilate and deal with it when we're paying a lot more to actually, I found that very difficult to deal with. And I was really frustrated with the university, I was very frustrated with how that kind of worked out here. I think it was difficult too because I found it quite difficult to socially adapt to as well, partially because of the pandemic. And I'm more cautious, so I wanted to be more cautious in terms of like, what space it wasn't, I didn't maybe join as many things as I would have. But also, you know, the drinking culture is very different here. And like most activities here are like, drinking to a level I'm not comfortable with, like not something I really participate in. So I found it a bit isolating.
I: Yeah, oh, I really understand. I spoke to some other people before, other international students, and they said the same thing. They were saying like, oh, English people are so weird they can drink all day. That's so true.
P: Yeah, it really does. I mean, and even if you don't, even if you're okay drinking, to some extent, it's just I think, well, I'm also I got here and I was 27, and a lot of people here, I ran into a lot more undergrads or people who are doing their masters who were, you know, 6 to 10 years age difference for me. And I probably would have been more comfortable with that when I was in my early 20s, or my late teens. So there was a bit of a gap to in terms of what you're interested in doing. So it was a little bit tricky. But you know, I found my friends eventually, so it was alright. But there was like a feel of wanting to join any sort of societies, there was tons that were very interesting in terms of like topics that they discussed. But I knew that most of the things they did to socialize were like, centered around just drinking. And also, you know, again, it's the like, in person contact stuff that I just wasn't really super comfortable with for a lot of the year because of just kind of moving out away from lock-downs in the pandemic, I wanted to be a bit more on the cautious side, on the safe side.
I: Yeah, I understand, do you feel the age is actually a problem? Because like people doing, especially people who are doing masters, their ages can be really different. So for mature students, I guess they have different experiences than young people.
P: Yeah, I felt like it was very geared towards young people, I think there was a pretty big gap. Well, I feel like it, it felt like it kind of fell into two categories that were quite separate from each other. There was like a lot of young people, particularly again, at this time, this is a very bizarre time in history, because we're dealing with a lot of like the effects of COVID on top of other things. So I think because of that, I do understand that a lot of kids who were 18, 19, 20, 21, just been stuck inside and missing some of those really key social years, really wanting to you know, go and explore and experience that. So I think there's a lot of like catering to that age

demographic. And then you kind of have people who are like postdocs and who are doing like the PhDs or like staff. So there was like an in between, I found myself in one at the time, and oddly enough, I got very close with one person here, and she's kind of my only main friend here. Actually, I did eventually make two close friends. One of them is 22, and the other one is 26, the 26 year old, she was a lot more like me, where she kind of came into academia a bit later. And so we had a lot of like bondings, she also didn't, you know, want to do a lot of things that other a lot of younger students were doing. And my friend who's 22, I had no idea she was 22 based on her personality, she was like 35 the way that she acted, she's doing her PhD, she's on a PhD track right now. So she presented much older, much more mature and she was just not interested in a lot of the things that other people around her age are interested in, so part of that is how we bonded and she's also an [same ethnicity]. So we were able to like bond over some similarities. But I think it wasn't really until I started meeting people who were more like me, and it was difficult with the age created a really big gap. Anyone who, you know, was in school projects or groups with, gives you the opportunity to talk with people, it didn't take long to figure out that we weren't really interested in the same things or doing the same thing, so I think, it was pretty significant. And I, it's gonna sound weird, because I'm only 28, but like, I felt old a lot of the time and I don't think 28 is very old. There's tons of students, especially masters students, there's tons of masters students were all sorts of ages, but I did feel like it was very, very heavily geared towards undergrads and people under the age of like 23.

I: Yeah, I know, yeah I understand. The other day, I met a girl who is 20, and she asked me out at night, late night, but I just feel no I don't want to do it, I 'm tired I want to sleep. You know, just we are not interested in the same thing anymore, and I'm only 25.

P: Yeah, everything's fine but you just don't really want to. Well, I think there's also, um, when I was first in college, I think I always kind of felt a little bit different with my own personal relationship, with like alcohol and drinking was, I never really wanted to drink a ton, so I always kind of had a bit of that separation, but it was a lot more room to engage in it and do it because that's what the social culture was. But now, I don't know, I guess as you get older, you start to figure out what it is you do like what it is you don't like. And I feel it's probably a little easier to kind of find people that are similar to you and kind of stand for firm and what it is like to do. And I think when you're younger, you end up just kind of doing what's popular a lot of the time because trying to make friends and you're trying to be a part of the social environment. So I think there's a lot of, there's like a big disconnect between that, especially in Britain, they have a very specific relationship with alcohol.

I: Yeah yeah I feel that too. People here seem, they like going out and drink with friends.

P: And every social event here, like every single social event, there's some involvement of alcohol. I went to a mini golf course, and you when you first get there, they have you wait, and there's s massive bar at the mini golf course. And then through the course every like four holes, there was another bar, and there were people

walking around getting you drinks, and I was like we are playing golf. It's just every little it's like, it's almost like anywhere you go, there's an opportunity to drink, which is just a little weird to me. Yeah.
I: Oh, oh, I mean, yeah, why would you want a drink when you play golf, or doing sports.
P: Yeah, it would be a big barrier, I think for socializing, if you're not as interested in, they do have things I guess where they have like a sober society, but it's more of like the entire society is built around the idea that you're sober.
I: Yeah, yeah, it's not really friendly to those people who don't drink.
P: Yeah, I've had a big problem with that here.
I: Yeah, it's just harder to make friends with people who drink, with Britons. Yeah. And it's also a very important way to fit into the society maybe.
P: Yeah, it definitely makes it quite difficult. Also, I mean, the drinking culture, part of it is little different here that it's you can drink at 18 here, and in the [home country], you can't drink until you're 21, which like people drink before they're 21, it's very usual, but culturally, you can't go into a bar until you're 21 you can't do certain things legally. So like here, there are some things that are nice, like if you're going to drink, most 18 to 21 year olds drink at some point, but you can't go to like a safe environment to do it, but here you can go into a pub you can go somewhere and even like university sponsored ones [a bar], you can go somewhere that's like on campus, this is a central hub, it's near where you live, you can do it a bit more of a safe environment.
I: Oh yeah, yeah, that’s also true. Okay, and you know, you are [nation] and you speak English, so did you have any difficulties communicating with people here, because you have different accent or you use different words?
P: Yeah, I think it would be easier because I mean, there's so many languages spoken in [home country], my first language is English. And most people in the [home country] like they assume your first language is English, even though there's so many spoken so I thought it would be pretty easy because my main national language is also the national language here, it's more little things that you don't expect to happen. So I'll use a word that I think means something and then it means something different to them, and you get it wrong, so that happens more often. And you know, it's just different vernaculars or different slang that you'll use I guess. It's a lot of the slang terms that sometimes I don't know what people are saying to me. Or little things like they'll call a class what we will call a class they call a module here. I guess a degree, they would call a course. So it's just like, slight differences, and they're easy enough intuitively to figure out. And then like, when I'm writing my papers, I have to add 'U's where they're not supposed to go, and learning British English is just adapting to what I already know, but adapting it to British English. It hasn't been too bad, but I think like the language itself is okay. It's, we went all say something, that means the the word exists in both British and American English, but they mean something different. And the other, like, we don't know that we're saying something different, so it causes confusion sometimes. That's been the biggest thing I would say.
I: Yeah, I remember when I first came to UK, I called crisps chips, so people just

confused why I want chips after dinner.
P: I imagine especially if English isn't your first language and you move to Britain, it depends on what kind of English you learn. You could have learned Australian English, British, American English, Canadian English, there's so many different kinds. But also, I lived in Australia for a little bit for a year abroad, and like Canadian, Australia, New Zealand, British English, they all kind of British English is kind of like the base for a lot of those. And I know, so I feel like the odd one out.
I: Yeah, yeah. It may sound bit rude, but you know some British people may not like the way [home people] speak. Did you ever meet that?
P: Yeah, I've gotten that, I've definitely gotten that. I think it's partially how we speak, and I think it's more of the way we communicate, less of the words we use, well, I guess you could fall into that. But I think [home people] communicate very differently than British people do. British people operate on this assumption, in my experience of like these things that go unsaid, it's these underlying things that they expect you to pick up. That might I don't know what you're saying, because [home people] are sometimes irritatingly direct, to kind of a ridiculous extent. And I think with [home people], you kind of know where people stand, where you stand with people a lot of the time. And I think the the passion level that [home people] tend to have, even if they don't really care about something, they're very expressive about it, so you did know where you stand with people. So I'm used to that. And I grew up with that. Here, I feel very confused about where I stand a lot of the time, and whether someone actually, like understands what I'm saying, or like, understands me and where I'm coming from. And then I definitely get a lot of I think politeness functions in a very interesting way in this culture, and I think British people really want to appear polite. And it's like a really big social nono to not appear polite. But that means that they may say something to you that they don't actually feel to be true, and then you don't know where you stand with them. You don't actually know if they like you they don't like you. But if you were upset by what they said, they'll just quietly be upset with you, and you can't figure it out so you can't fix it. And they expect you to know, they expect you to figure it out a lot of the time. And it's just it's this underlying culture of things that I haven't quite figured out. It's not my preference for communicating.
I: Yeah, yeah it's something you won't figure out at the beginning, then after you understand this, you just feel, oh they actually didn't mean that. Like they say sorry a lot, but they didn't mean it sometimes or they just say sorry but don't actually care, something like that.
P: Yeah, yeah and they say sorry, in a very weird way, weird to me that, instead of excuse me, they'll say sorry, like to begin a conversation and I'm like, why do you start by apologizing for your existence?
I: Yes, they do start with sorry a lot, and honestly, I feel I start to do that too.
P: Yeah then you start to adapt to it, exactly. Part of it too, I think being here is figuring out how much do I maintain of my own identity knowing, and how much do I assimilate just so it's easier to communicate and it's easier to be accepted here.
I: Yeah, you gonna change yourself a little bit.
P: Yeah, I find myself like, even the intonation of how I speak, I know that I can't

change really how I accent mostly, I usually don't have to tell people I'm [ethnicity], they usually, (when I say) 'I'm from [home town]", (they will reply) 'oh, I know'. That's pretty obviously, I can't change that. But I, you know, it's certain things that you say the way you interact people saying, ‘oh, sorry you should’, you know, to kinda make a position you do learn to assimilate and adapt to the places around you. But I think it's been a little bit difficult for my identity a little bit, because I like where I'm from, I'm from the [an area], like [home town], and we have a very particular vernacular and in the [area], I'm really proud of where I'm from. And it's, I know that if I speak in the slang I grew up, and no one will understand me.
I: Yeah, I know. It's kind of the same thing like, you know, some people will try to learn some kinds of British accents, but for me, I just feel like I will try to pronounce it right, but I don't want that accent because then I just feel I lose my identity, it's not me. Like I didn't grow up here, so it's gonna be weird if I have that accent.
P: Exactly, exactly. It's difficult, because I think Britain is a really interesting place, and I think the world is really trying to figure out the relationship with like, immigration and assimilation I think. Because Britain is so based in immigration, and so much of what makes it fantastic, is because of immigrants, and because of the relationship with immigrants and diversity. But there is this assumption of the this like pressure to assimilate, to adapt to what they do as they're normal. So it's this weird kind of balance, I think, to figure out if you're someone who was immigrated here, it' a little easier I think in a school environment, because you have something, you have something there already for, you know, you have this, and there's lots of international people around and a lot of times people will be really interested if you're from somewhere else. And they, you know, maybe they haven't heard someone with your accent. They're like, Oh, that's very cool, like where are you from, and then start the conversation. But yeah, I mean, I get a lot of, I think there's also a lot of assumptions, because I'm [ethnicity], I'm sure you also get that. Well just they think a lot of things about you when they find out where you're from.
I: Yeah, yeah. Then have you had any bad experiences because you just speak differently, like people treat you differently or unequally, things like that?
P: It's more of the underlying micro aggressions, I think and also, yeah, I'm white, and I have an American accent, so I don't think in terms of immigration, I don't think it's difficult to me in this country at all. Like at all I'm like, almost as easy as it gets in terms of like an immigration experience. So I haven't really experienced too much of it. But you know, little things like when I first got here, this may have been less of like how I speak but I think it's my first week here and I was picking up my, the card that, like the BRP card that you have to get. So I was picking that up. And I hadn't gotten to the university yet. So I was I stayed with my partner for a week before I got here. And so I picked this office near his house. And they were asking me, what's your address, and I thought they meant my university address, and I hadn't picked an apartment yet, so I wasn't sure. And I was trying to figure it out, I was like, Oh, do you want a university address and she was very frustrated with me for not knowing. And I got that experience a couple of times where people would just be irritated with me for not knowing something that was standard in this culture. But it was not something I really

would have known because it was different from I used to. Even someone who was born here wouldn't know how to do it, because they don't have to pick up the BRP card.
I: Yeah, there're lots of things we don't know, I mean it's ok or normal not to know these, that's why we need help, and they should be more patient and give more support.
P: Yeah, yes, you knew someone doesn't understand, I guess it's, I think it comes from a more personal place, it's just like wanting something to move smoothly, and it takes patience for it not to move as smoothly as you'd like it to. But at the same time, it just takes a moment to step outside of yourself and know that someone just doesn't know something. So why bother being upset with them, it's something because they can't do anything about it.
I: Yeah, I know, I don't want to be rude, but someone or some types of people are just really really impatient, they're like 'how can you not know this? Why do you need me to explain for you? '
P: Yeah, yeah. Yeah. Interesting to see like, which people get more frustrated with you more easily than other? Yeah, I haven't had as much in terms of my communication and what I want, it's more people just usually know exactly where I'm from. Like, I've had some weird questions. Somebody heard my accent, I don't even think they asked me where I was from, I may have told them but I also want to say I'm from [a state] people think [a city]. If you've ever been to [a city], like [a state] is a very long state and humongous. And I'm from the northern part of it. And then the culture of Northern [state] is very different from the other part of [state]. And like people think [another city] when I tell them I'm from [state], I did not grew up near anywhere close to [the city]. Someone asked me like, do I know [an actor], and do I surf every day, I've never surf ever. No, I know of [actor] as a person, but no, like, there would have been no reason for me to come into contact. Always little things like that, but I haven't really had I think I've been quite shield, I think I have a lot of privilege, and a lot of ways I think I have a lot of structural privilege. I speak I do speak English, I can figure out what people are saying to me for the most part, except for a couple of little words. And I also have an accent of people can pick out right away and will usually know things about [home country]. And even if they're annoyed, I get people who are usually more interested and fascinated. And if they're annoyed because of British culture, they'll probably not tell me.
I: It’s actually quite funny, but yeah, true, they will not tell us, they're just gonna be polite, or pretending they're polite.
P: Yeah, I mean, people find it really interesting. But I haven't had too many negative experiences, it's just some embarrassing things that I've done, that I didn't know about, like the you know how the money that they use, there's like pence, and then there's like 50 P but it's pence, like, it's 50 pence, but they say 50 P and I was like, like a pub or something, and nothing was like 50 P and I was like, Oh, how many p and then they started laughing, I mean, I didn't know that that wasn't normal. Little things like that.
I: I see, yeah.

P: Because I mean, it seems normal to me. That seems like what you would call it because I hear people say that, but it's the little tiny things you won't know.
I: Yeah they do, yeah there’re things like that, when you try to copy the way they speak, you just always make mistakes.
P: Almost like you can't win, you speak the way you speak, people do look at you weird or they, there they make some comments usually because, conversation that happens, good, bad or neutral, it's a comment and it's a focus, and then you try to adapt. You don't sound like them, and you do it wrong a lot of the time and like for me a lot of words, like I said that I'm used to, like I found out here, you know, pants in the [home country] means trousers, just different here. So if it was like it was really hot out in the summer, and I was like, oh, you know, I just don't like wearing pants this time of year and that sounds very different. I'm talking about trousers not underwear. That, that just you know, make it embarrassing.
I: Yeah yeah, I know. And I also sometimes feel no clue about the way they speak or do things, like I can't get these rules, for me it just seems those rules change everytime. You know, it just always make me feel or remind me I'm still a foreigner here.
P: Yeah, yeah, I think the government definitely, I find highly unwelcoming to immigrants. And like I said, I'm about as easy as it gets, in terms of like the immigration experience. I'm from a white, a pretty like, it's not even like, it's seen as a white wealthy country, it's not really what the [home country] is, but it's seen that's how it's run to run that. But like, I don't find this country, I guess it's quite confusing sometimes, because I think there's a lot of rhetoric around welcoming immigrants, particularly in university systems. But I know a lot of that has to do with like, international students probably make up I don't have like accurate and up to date figures on this, but I'm, I know that they make up like a good chunk of the revenue that universities make. I know that they build in the budget for how many international students they get in and they really recruit international students because they can charge us a lot more and there is there's no legal cap for how much they're allowed to charge us where there is for home students. So it's, there's like this notion that it's friendly to immigrants. I don't know I don't think that there's a lot of, I think there should be a bit more support and, it seems extremely classes to me also, I'm just I'm gonna name it. It just it's very expensive to be an immigrant here. It's extremely expensive, they make it very clear that you're not going to be getting any public health, the system in terms of visas are is unbelievably expensive, university is unbelievably expensive. And if you don't have help it's very hard to do in terms of even getting here, getting a bank account was very difficult to do and you can't really do much without a bank account here.
I: Yeah yeah exactly, like everything they want you to do is like showing you are a foreigner and they just want money from us.
P: Exactly it really feels like we will allow you to be here but make sure you give us money.
I: Yeah, and like at least please support us more and appreciate the things the money we bring, not just leave us alone.

P: Yeah, I think it really comes from this notion that the only people who benefit from migration are migrants, which is preposterous to me considering like, how many times you hear English people talk about how much they love curry, and how much they talk about how Tikka Masala was invented in Birmingham, like okay, but that was an Indian person who did that because of history with that, but like in terms of there's a lot of incredible benefits to having immigration, to having a healthy immigration system, an accessible immigration system. And I think there's so much that everybody benefits from when you've got people from different places who get to meet and be around each other. And Britain has this like, narrative that we like immigrants, but also this demonization of them as well, especially right now. Yeah, even like the notion of like, a foreigner, like that word, it just gets thrown around so much, more in office, like a home office I think. And yeah, it's kind of I think, psychologically, it can be quite difficult to be an immigrant in this country and levels to it, magnitudes to it, depending on where you're from, what your background is, what you look like, how you speak. There's all sorts of different intersecting aspects. But I found it quite difficult, actually. And I don't think I was expecting it to be as hard as it was, like, I kind of naively was like, well, I speak English. And yeah, but I didn't appreciate how wildly expensive it would be, I didn't appreciate it, um, I didn't really understand how much the academic system was quite different here, like we said, of kind of like really being on your own to figure it out. And that's not necessarily the way that I work best. And especially when you're paying so much to be here. And it's been so difficult to get here and adapt. And you feel very different a lot of the time so, yeah I think there's a whole lot more that both the country and the universities could be doing to make, like international students are more welcome.

I: Yeah, yeah, I think that's also why I'm interested in international students experiences in a wider range, like people always feel language is a big problem, but it's much more than that.

P: Yeah, I mean, I think it just it must create such a significant barrier, you have your native language not be the same as the native language here, but even so just the notion of like feeling like an outsider, it's very interesting how that's almost a universal experience.

I: Yeah. So I talked to some people, and I found interestingly that people have different feelings when they are at different stages. For example, at early stage, they like, the main problem is language, how to really communicate with each other, but the longer they stay, they finally get into the cultural part, which like, even I can speak English well, but I still don't feel I'm in this society because their culture kind of like just kept me outside.

P: Yeah, yeah, it's, it's also, I think, an especially difficult time, because we're getting more like kind of, you know, back to normal, I don't think there really isn't normal anymore. But we are starting to, at least at this point, it's much different than when I first got here, when I got here was right before the delta wave, and then that was before the Omicron wave. So we've had a couple of kind of ups and downs in terms of like how much we can actually be around people, be social and being with

each other, and now is a bit of a better time for them in terms of being able to do most of the things we could do before any of the lock downs. But I do think it, it kind of adds to the feeling of isolation in a lot of ways. And interesting like that's such a universal experience, I think for a lot of immigrants, because, like I said, this country is like built on immigrants and most people that I know, like most people generally that I know who are British, there's very few of them who their family and their ancestry is purely British, it's very, very few of them, um, yeah, a lot of it is like European. But still, there was just there's very few people who like, you know, within one to three generations didn't have family or ancestry from a completely different country. So it's interesting that these problems exist for people who have like, just immigrated here considering like, who makes up this country. Yeah, I mean, I think that also was quite difficult about Britain was, it's part of that culture of saying certain things and having certain things on the surface, and then certain other things underneath the surface. I think there is not that different from the [home country] to be honest. But this kind of notion is, you know, like a brochure where they say like, we're very diverse campus, and you get into some of that experience, and then not actually, I don't think the university does enough to really welcome students from diverse backgrounds, whether that's religion, or their sexuality or their gender, I don't think they do enough. And I think they pretend that they do more than they do. I think they know that it sounds good to say we're diverse, but they don't really put a lot of things into place to actually do it and listen to the students. Yeah, you're telling them what they need, I don't think they're really interested in doing a lot of the structural work at the moment that it would require to make people feel more comfortable who feel different.

I: Yeah, I really agree.

P: Yeah. So I'm pretty the same. But I, it's the truth. Like I was talking with a friend about this. I feel like I've heard the phrase, like, it's just not done quite a bit here. And it's the most bizarre reason to give for doing something to me. It's just like, that's just how we do it, or it's just not done or it's tradition, like, weird reason to keep doing something and not dig into why you're doing it.

I: Yeah. It's really hard to tell them to change or to try a new way to do it, they're just like, no this is the way we do it.

P: Yeah. And that's quite different for me from this in this country. Because, you know, [home country], it's a very old country. But the modern notion of it, I guess, the modern, like, manifestation of it, yeah, 1776, it's not that long ago, that's when our constitution was built, that's how like the modern nation as it is now. And so there really isn't a lot from before that period of time. I think the oldest buildings that we have, are probably from the late 1600s, maybe 1700s. Whereas here, there's something preserving their history is quite different here. Because, we have buildings from like the 1200s here, and you find that in the country that I'm from, it's just anything that was standing at that time is no longer there. So I think they have a different pull towards wanting to preserve tradition and preserve certain things that, you know, they may not maybe hundreds and hundreds of years beyond questioning why you would do it, it's just we need to preserve what we have.

I: Yes, that's true but also kind of annoying sometimes.
P: Oh, it's extremely annoying, I don't agree with it. And I think it ends up being a reason to, I don't know, it's one of those things, that progress is just always one of those things that you have to be examining why you're doing things, what effects they have, does it still make sense in a modern context? Are there better ways to do things so that people feel more included or so that things move more smoothly? That's kind of how the world works is, you have to continue with it because it's going to consistently change.
I: Well, then in general, are you happy with things here, with your life here? Like, in general.
P: A good question, it's kind of a complicated one, I guess for me, because I guess I've also realized that everywhere you go is great and has its problems, everywhere has issues. And everywhere has really unique things you can't find anywhere else in the world. Everywhere has really interesting people, and people tend to want the same thing. no matter where you go on the planet, they want love, they want protection, they want to experience things and experience people in life, they want safety, they want a family and community. That doesn't really change that much depending on where you are on the planet. I think right now that it's a complicated question for me, because as an [nation], I feel like I'm watching my home just completely implode on itself. So it's not something I really want to go back to at the moment, but it is home. And it's a place that I care a lot about the people there and the direction there. So that is part of the reason I don't know if I could ever see myself staying here permanently. But that's more of a tie to there less of because of here, although there are some things here that I don't know, like I really enjoy the amount of space that you can have in [home country]. That's not the case. In the UK, it's just it's a much smaller country, a lot more people and a smaller amount of land. So certain things like that, or monarchy, like there's certain like structural aspects that I don't know that I would really stay in Britain forever, but I am happy to stay here at the moment, I'm really enjoying my time here. And I like getting to just be in a place that's different and experience something that's different. And and I think it's been really beneficial for me as like watered down as, as the experience has probably been, I think it's been very beneficial to be able to go to another country and experience being an immigrant in some respects, even if it's a very like mild, pretty easy version I think, in all things considered, especially because of what's going on in [home country] and the rhetoric around immigration, I think it's really helpful to have like a little bit of experience of like, what it might be like to feel like you're not in a country that you were born in. Even if it isn't like directly comparable, you know, I don't think we can necessarily compare, I think it's very individual, you know, for each person and their particular situation where they're from where they're living what not. But I'm happy living here I think for the moment and I'm really getting to see all the different things that you just you can't see anywhere else, it's a very unique place, especially London. I just got a job in London.
I: That's nice!
P: Yeah, I'm really excited for it, it'll be really good. I'm I got a position that you go

off and they're a really interesting organization to get to, like be a part of and get to be near London, so I am really enjoying getting to explore all of the different incredible parts. You know, I'll just you take the good and the bad, you know, it's just it's always a balance wherever you go, whatever you do.
I: So next question, is about your social network social relationship. You mentioned before that you have two close friends here, one is from America, and where's the other one from?
P: The other one she is from here she's from the West Midlands actually also, like a little bit of time, a few places, but she grew up more like in the Midlands, and I think she's lived here for quite a while, like in this area, like in [a town in southwest England] and spent some time in southwest before coming to [university city], she's been here for probably like five or maybe 10 years or something.
I: Cool. And do you have other friends, like friends from other backgrounds?
P: So those are my two friends who are in the area. And then I've met people through, like coming here in the past. So a few years back, I met up with someone that my partner worked with, we met up with him and his girlfriend and I got quite close with his girlfriend, who's also [a nation] oddly. She was here for like eight years, and she's very much a Londoner at heart. And she doesn't really like she understands a lot of things about coming from the [home country] and growing up there. But she doesn't really identify as [her ethnicity] very much anymore. Her accent is kind of modelled now. Interesting.
I: Oh that's interesting.
P: Yeah, especially when she's around, I think when she's around me, more of the [her national] accent will come out. She slips more into like the British accent because she's been here so long. And another person I've gotten close with, she is a friend of my partner's sister in law, so I met through family, just met at like a birthday party I think, for for his sister in law. And we got really close because we were just really similar people. But she lives in Southampton, so I don't see her too much. Those are like my main four friends that I've made here. And so two of them are American, two of them are British, although the one in Southampton, she grew up here, but she is from Zimbabwe and she moved here when she was eight.
I: Oh, I see. So do you have a moment or situation when you feel someone really understand you?
P: Yeah, like a specific moment?
I: Yeah, just give me an example if you can.
P: I mean, I think with the Americans, it was a little easier, just because there was some already common understanding there. But with each of them, it was usually like an interest that we found out of actually, I think, all four of those people, so I have ADHD, I'm neurodivergent, and all four of my friends are also neurodivergent. One of them is on the autism spectrum and the other three all have ADHD. So I think like, finding out that we operate similarly, and we didn't know about that until after we had started talking, and people come after we were very interested in or, you know, talk about doing something, and they would say, 'oh, I do that too', and like those moments, I eventually figured out all of my friends I really gravitate, all of them are

women, all of them are neurodivergent, all of them identify as queer. So we said why and all those things, we had like some base identity things as well. But I think so with my friend here that I met the one that she is [same ethnicity as participant]. We, like we initially like that was how we first spoke to each other because she heard my accent. And she was like, Oh, are you [ethnicity]? Like, oh, I am too like that's funny and spoke in class. But then when we actually became friends, we were working on a class assignment. And we're talking about a show that we both liked. It was BBC Sherlock. I think I mentioned it and there was like a specific, like, small niche community online, that was like, fans of the show and like specific realm, and it's not a very common one. And I mentioned was like, Oh, I'm not sure if you've heard of this. And she had heard of it. And it was really, really cared about for a while and I really cared about for a while, so it was one of those moments where something that you liked that not many people around you do she happened to also and we just got along so well after that. And then we started thinking that that day I think we spoke for like, we're working on an assignment and then we went to get lunch together and we walked home together and we spent most of that day talking about really deep thing. Yeah, that's a big part for me is, in British culture I think there's a lot more comfortability around like surface level conversations, like stuff like that. And I don't, it's hard to define but I really where I draw a lot of connection with people is through more deep conversations of like, yeah, yeah. What do you really care about? What are the things you struggle with in life? What are the things that you really makes you who you are? What are the things that you even thinking about yourself lately and thinking about your identity or what are the books that you read that really make you think about something differently those kind of.

I: Yeah.

P: All of friends that I've made here, we've hit a point where we started to talk about something quite deep. That's usually when I draw a lot of connection with people and when I really start to feel understood, it's typically over something like an interest that I mentioned that I have, and they have also, and it's the way that we enjoy that interest and again, because of all my friends, are divergent, I think that the hyper, we all hyper fixation is a really big part of ADHD, and so all of us like we have something that we've like, hyper fixated on, and it's nice to find someone else who understands it. All the weird ways that your brain works that other people think are weird, but like, they don't think they're weird.

I: Yeah, it is funny, but also it's just like the special things, the very important things for us are the same, that's how we feel understood.

P: Yeah, I mean, that's what a connection is, it's when you really feel seen, I think by people, when you feel understood by people, that, particularly the feeling of being understood has been something very hard for me to find here, so it just, it felt so freeing and so fantastic when I like met people who were interested in similar things to me and who like really felt like they understood me in certain ways. And it just feels like seen.

I: Yeah, from what you just said, it just reminds me something like, yeah I just always have the feeling when I contact with British people, like they always stay in the

surface questions, so just feel they don't want to make friends with me you know.
P: Yeah, the only British people I've gotten close by are people who want to talk about deep things or things that like, I'm very interested in, like politics and in social justice organizations, and a lot of social movements. So I really like talking with people who like having deep conversations about those things, and who are interested in talking about social phenomena and things that are happening in politics and aren't afraid to talk about things that can be seen as controversial and uncomfortable. I really enjoy talking about, I mean even he doesn't agree with me just being okay with the conversations about it, it's a really big thing for me. And so most people who I've been friends with here who are British, it's usually they're willing to talk about those kind of things, they like talking about, they like going to a more deep place talking about themselves.
I: Yeah yeah, some of them don't like to give you an opinion, like they don't agree or disagree, they just like, 'oh really, oh you think that way'.
P: More knowledge is like, 'oh, that's interesting'. I've always heard like, 'oh, it's an interesting one'. I'm like, I don't know what that means, what you're trying to say it means it's a very surface level way of not offending anybody. Yeah, but like, I never want to purposely offend anyone when it's not necessary at all. But I'm not afraid of saying something that's true for me. That someone else, if it's not a way, you know, maliciously trying to hurt anybody, if you're just like stating, like, this is how I feel about the monarchy, this is how I feel about this particular politician. That's just your opinion, and it's not directly hurting anybody. People sometimes veer away from that. I mean, [home people] do it too. But I think in a different way that the British people do and there's this like, the way that they use the word controversial, saying interesting 'oh it's an interesting one', like, it's just the catch all that they use controversial, and I've noticed they use instead of offensive, they don't want to be controversial when they mean they don't want to offend anyone, and they don't want to do something that causes like, waves.
I: And they say no offense, but they gonna offend you anyway.
P: Exactly, it's like, 'well no offense but', and then they say something terrible. You're like, well, it is an offense and like yeah. But again, it's the kind of thing that you're saying, you know, is it directly insulting to somebody especially someone's identity or their being? [Being interrupted by street noise.] And the banter culture is quite interesting here because I feel like there isn't really space in just normal conversation for people to like, be controversial or say something that might offend someone and not appear polite, even the like not wanting to offend people, I think it's not wanting to appear and polite, but then what will happen is especially if you've been drinking, you're in the pub or whatever, the banter culture, the idea that like you can say something insulting, but it's all for fun. And like, it's a weird way to communicate in thoughts, in your opinion to somebody if you feel like you can't do it if like, the space isn't really there to do it in normal conversation, but you have to do it in kind of a cloaked way of, of like, within banter and you know, don't be sensitive about it. It's an odd way to communicate.
I: And they gonna tell you don't take it personal, you know, I just never get it.

P: You know, and I mean, it's not really, I don't personally think it's very fair to tell someone don't take something personally, because people are going to take it if they gonna take it, and if you've hurt someone's feelings, then they're allowed to, like, feelings be hurt. And sometimes a lot of times, I think it just comes from people not wanting to own the impact that their words have just said, the hurtful impacts that there weren't that they just care about the intents and that the fact that they didn't hurt someone should be enough. But I mean, it's just it's a lot of that cross community, cross cultural communication. You know, it's a little bit weird.
I: Yeah, yeah, and one thing is really important for feeling understood is, I mean it's not necessary that you agree with me, but at least you show me that care about and you know what I'm saying, which is based on that we have to talk, have a proper conversation I feel.
P: It's nice, like, those are the people that I tend to really enjoy, and I think the culture here, it's not quite as expressive as I'm used to, so it's a little harder to find people who are willing to have conversations like that with you. And like all the people that I'm friends with who are British are all okay with listening to my opinions on things, and, you know, giving their opinion whether they agree with it, or saying 'well, I don't know, actually, I feel this way' and like being able to have respectful conversations where you're not afraid to like offend someone or you're not afraid to say something that someone may not disagree with, or someone may not agree with. Like just having real conversations about what you think. And, because to me, that's also how you can really evaluate if you still think what you think, you get to hear different perspectives that maybe you don't know about before, that's where a lot, that's where a lot of growth is that's where that's where connection is, where intimacy is.
I: Yeah, yeah, exactly.
P: There's this big, there's quite a barrier, I find sometimes that because of the cultural difference.
I: Yeah, definitely. So, do you have any experiences of feeling misunderstood?
P: Yes.
I: Could you tell me more, I mean, give me an example?
P: I sometimes feel quite misunderstood here, sometimes. Again, the people that I'm friends with, you know, we tend to find people who thinks things like we do, so we don't feel so weird. But generally, the biggest one is the monarchy, I've gotta say, it's just so fundamentally weird to me, the concept around it, and I've started paying a little more attention to, I've started making it more of a focus to study histories and current manifestations of anti racism work and decolonization work. And so being in a place like Britain, that is like the hub of colonization is really interesting. And I think sometimes when I try and talk about it, certain things that look weird, seem weird to me, and the monarchy is a fantastic manifestation of a particularly when we're living in a period of time of a massive cost of living crisis. There's just there's, there's things that could be talked about and addressed, and, you know, I feel like I feel quite misunderstood in that a lot of the time. People don't really see where we're coming from. So that's one of the bigger ones. But I think in a more like simple way. Even just little cultural things like in [home country], we don't usually it's changed a bit because

of the economy, but we don't usually buy houses as early as British people do. I think it's just culturally, people tend to buy them a bit younger here. And there's a notion of like, you buy a starter house, but you plan to sell it and if you want to move, it's fine, you can just sell the house and buy another one. Whereas at least what where I grew up and how I grew up, depends, you know, the [home town] is very wealthy, and, but I grew up with the notion of like, it takes so long to save for a house most people don't have access to that so easily at their 30s and then when you buy a house that's like the place you plan to be. And there's there isn't this like, turnover around it. It's, I feel like people don't really necessarily understand where I come from, we're, like my partner and I've kind of talked about this because his standard is he thought he'd buy a house much earlier than I ever did. But also, you know, economically, things have changed so that it is taking people longer. So factors to it, but little things like that were like cultural differences where I feel like oh, it doesn't make sense to like, buy a house early, and people are like, what do you mean that that makes the most sense, you're being weird. Am I?

I: No, no.

P: I'm trying to think like when I particularly feel misunderstood. When I use [home town] slang, I feel super misunderstood. But that's where like, quite literally my communication, people don't know what I'm saying. I think also when I express myself, which it feels natural to me, my personality also, it's not just you know, that I'm from [home country] that my personality, I'm not as much of like a shy person, I'm more comfortable being expressive. You know, being loud and being energetic. And that's, it's looked at as very weird here. Very weird.

I: Yeah, yeah, they don't normally do that, but they do become expressive and loud when they watch football or drink beers.

P: Yeah.

I: Anyway, so what were you thinking or how did you react when you felt misunderstood?

P: I'm trying to work more with that. Because I think when I was younger, and I still, this still happens, sometimes I think I'm trying to be more active about not doing what I used to do, which was going to place a shame of 'Oh, I've done something wrong, or I'm doing something bad or I'm, I'm too loud of a person', rather than like someone wasn't expecting that, and like that was, you know, it'd be too much for them, but doesn't mean that like, I'm wrong in that way. And I think my initial reactions were usually to go to a place of shame and feel bad about myself that I've done something wrong. And then I should stop and I should change and I should do something different. And now it's more situational, I kind of have to read the particular context and situation, but I have tried to, like, work more on not kind of going immediately to a place of shame of that, like, you're wrong, you're doing something wrong, but maybe someone wasn't expecting it, or there might have, someone else's reaction tends to have a lot more to do with them than you.

I: Yeah, it's not always because we did something wrong, or they did something wrong, could be more explanations for that.

P: Exactly. And like, what you were expecting to happen isn't what happened is a lot

easier, I think for people to say like, 'why are you doing this, that's wrong, because I'm uncomfortable, I didn't like that and expect that so you're wrong'. And it's an easier thing to do. Especially when, especially if you're talking about if it's a person who is British and you're not, like 'oh yeah, you guys are weird, we don't do this in Britain'.
I: I can't tell if it's a good thing or bad thing, like we also can just say, no this is how we do, so you know, we don't need to blame ourselves.
P: Yeah. Kind of an easy excuse to be honest. It'd be like, oh no, that's what we do, maybe just you guys are weird. Yeah, that's the thing is, maybe I'm not the weird one, maybe you've been around people like you, and I'm just presenting something different to you. And so it's very easy to present the thing that's different, that's weird. And like, like, no one's wrong. But I mean, I think there's a really interesting advantage that people who are not from the UK get in the sense of like, we get to experience multiple cultures, we get to see what, it means it's really helpful, because in some ways, like when you've been raised only around a certain thing, and then you move somewhere different, you get, like, oh, not everybody does that, okay, so people have all sorts of ways of being in all sorts of ways doing things. And when you're exposed to multiple things, you kind of get to pick what actually makes sense for me, what's something that I like to do when you have all these other options, and you also start to learn that like, when people say that, that's weird or bad, that just means it's different to them and it's something they're not as comfortable with, they're not used to in the same way. And when you've moved to a place that you're not from, you're surrounded by that all the time. So you're a little bit into it.
I: Yeah, I so feel being in the new environment actually shaped my life a lot.
P: Yeah, definitely, definitely. Really, I mean, there's really no way that you can't, it's kind of it's, it would be almost impossible not to, it's such a unique experience and like, I don't regret any of it, I don't regret moving here and I think, it's the right thing to do. It's been a really expansive experience, I think it's really helpful to figure out who you actually are, and what you want, and it helps you hold on to certain aspects of your identity and hold true to them, be a lot more confident than them.

(Part 2)

P: So you know, when I first got here, like, it felt very difficult and I was quite insulting in some ways that there wasn't more help and that you were really just on your own. And I don't personally find a lot of help from the international student support. I know there's a lot of narrative, and there's a lot of rhetoric around there being support and help, I didn't find that practical support to actually be there, I found that there was a lot of investment in like campaigning and saying that there was support for national students, but I don't think, and I don't think this was like, on the part of the staff, I don't think it was their fault, especially because of the circumstances of the pandemic. I think just a lot of people didn't talk to each other, don't know what you can do and what you can't do. And I imagine that lots of people who left during the pandemic and new people who came on maybe couldn't train them as much as you would have if you could do face to face. So I understand the structural

problems that existed. But the point is, they didn't, they haven't invested but they need to invest. If you actually want to have a fully functioning, thorough support system for international students, they have lots of campaigns and brochures that say they support us, but they don't. And they do it all while saying, all while asking us to pay almost double what the domestic students here are paying, and we know that the government here doesn't have a cap for what they're allowed. So they can use us to fund whatever they want. They can use us to charge whatever tuition they want and say that they worked for us, but they don't, it's not actually there, I don't think they've really done the work to invest in international students the way that they need to if they actually want people to pay that much. And I do find it quite insulting the amount of times that all these opportunity, they're around you all the time, and you're told, oh, we'll treat you just like everybody else, and you're amazing, you bring so much culture and diversity to us. And then there's all these opportunities flying around like oh, you weren't born in the UK, or Oh, you weren't born in the Commonwealth, sorry. So you're not eligible for this thing. And like, it's not just the universities, but it's the government too. It's the amount of times that they let you know that they make you feel other all the time. I felt so other here.

I: Yes. Yeah. I completely agree with you honestly.

P: It's very unfortunate and I think it's interesting at this period of time to, I think the world has started to move towards like people understand that. If we figured out that it's trendy to say we want diversity now, we're no longer going to effectively exclude certain people, because that doesn't look good anymore. Now, we'll put campaigns together to make it look like we're diverse. But how much are they actually making students feel safe? How much are they actually making them feel welcome? How much are they making themselves uncomfortable enough to figure out what it is that we need and not prioritize themselves and their bottom line and their finances before our comfort and our ability to thrive? At the same level as some students, particularly given that we've had to pay so much money to go through the process to get here, we have to learn an entire new system that we didn't grow up with, unlike British students, we have so many more barriers that they don't really put that much into place to really solve. I think they put a lot more into branding and campaigning that they do than actually doing it. Yeah, I mean, I know you're probably focusing on social support, but like, the social support in terms of like finding people who are like you, but also having people be, I don't know, willing to work with you in a different way, and knowing you come from a different background, but also I think accessibility is something that they're terrible at, particularly financial accessibility, like the UK to me is a very unfriendly place if you're poor, if you, they don't want, they make it clear, they make it super clear when like no uncertain terms that they don't want poor immigrants here. They make it impossible for you to be poor and be an immigrant here. And like, it's just, it's very devastating I think, especially it's psychologically very confusing when you read these things on their websites and they say these things and then that's not the experience you have. And then it makes you feel weird that you did something wrong or you should have reached out or you should do more and this like gaslights you.

I: Yeah.
P: Yeah, it's still very British at the end of the day and it feels very, like focused on the home students and I don't know, I just it's very hard to not feel othered the way that it's set up, and I don't, I'm not exactly sure how they would change things, to be honest. I mean, I think this research is super important, because the best way to figure it out is like, find out what people are experiencing, what they found the biggest problems to be and figure out from the actual people who've experienced it themselves. And then you can work towards like, working with them to find solutions. But, you know, I'm really glad you'd like I said, I'm really glad you're doing this research, because I think it's really important. And I don't really see the university really sponsoring many things.
I: Yeah, I mean thank you. It's gonna be hard to change anything, but at least international students can know that we're going through the same thing, we're the same, and we could understand each other and connect with each other.
P: Yeah, and I think it would be nice to find it, because I know they have some things, we're like, international students can meet each other, but I think it's really important, I think finding community with people who are experiencing similar things is really important. And we get to a point where you're not, it's just it segregates people also, if you don't do that, as well as finding ways so that like people who are all feeling outsiders, it's great if they have community and they can find other people like me, because that's how you survive. But ultimately, that's not solving the problem of why they feel like outsiders. And if they like, if you find ways to make it so that they don't feel like outsiders, you can actually integrate them into the community in a different way. Instead of just asking immigrants to assimilate or different and they're asking us to do something we can't do. We're not from Britain, we can't assimilate and pretend to be British. We're not, it really enriches British culture that we're here and that we're different, you can see they forget that.
I: Yeah, still we can find a way to maintain our social life, not get isolated.
P: Yeah, I mean, I think also when you feel different, very easy to get isolated, and not great things tend to breed in isolation. You know, so I think the university could definitely do a lot, a lot. I'm way beyond just saying they have international student support that doesn't actually, it's just been very hit and miss. Sometimes I can find a helpful answer, it totally depends on the person that I get in the mood.
I: Yes, yes, sometimes you may just meet someone who knows nothing, or tell you to ask another team, or something like that. I even met that I asked three or four different people but still no answer.
P: Yeah, that's the thing. It seems like nobody talks to each other. Absolute nightmare unless you find the right person who can help you in that moment, and usually it's a more direct way, it's usually like if you're just sending like an inquiry or opening a ticket, it can take very long and then you can add up with multiple people who don't necessarily know what you have discussed beforehand. And it can just get really complicated. And I seem like there's a really big lack of like, centralizing the system, and also people talking to each other. My guess is a lot of people left during the pandemic, and there's a lot of new people and I know what it happens. You've got a

different team and people are learning things and you don't know things until they happen or it takes a while to get comfortable and really know how to deal with a lot of these little things. But it doesn't mean it just makes for something that's so inefficient and you just don't feel like there's actually a lot of help out there. And then what ends up happening is like you don't reach out because I know the rhetoric is like, just reach out to us. But the thing is that only works when you build trust, University is not building enough trust with their students in general. But also with the international students, they're not building the trust necessary for people to feel comfortable coming to them with their problems, because it's a vulnerable thing to do to ask someone for help. And you need a lot of help when you're an international student, and they do a lot of talking about how easy it is to come to them and talk to them, but they haven't built the trust to make it easy, actually efficient, and they break that trust often when people come to them. And the systems are completely inefficient and ineffectual. They break that trust, and I don't think they really understand that's on them. The onus is on them to create the trust. And unfortunately feels quite exploitive if they haven't built that trust and then they hand me twice the amount of tuition. Yeah. And then you're told you don't get any public funds if you want to be an immigrant here and you want to stay here. It's very frustrating, you could do a lot more.

Interview 19:

I: What's your motivation and expectation for studying in the UK or in [university]?

P: Yeah, maybe, honestly I just want to have a break from my career. So, um, I have been working for almost 10 years before this, and it's not, it's not exactly in [a course], more in business, I feel like I need, I just need a break from my career. So yeah, I thought like, why not study? So I went to, I applied to several universities and UK is one of my options, because there's no language barrier here like because I don't think I can I will be able to learn another language. So yeah, then I got a scholarship from [university], so I go here.

I: Is English your first language?

P: No, no, English isn't my first language. But yeah, at work I usually use it, so yeah.

I: I see, is it your first time coming to the UK?

P: Yeah.

I: How was your experience, your life here?

P: I think my concern is a bit different from other students. Because I think like, because I'm a mature student, right, so I'm more thinking about what, what I'm going to do, I'm more worried about what I'm going to do after studying instead of, like what I study. Even though there's, there's a challenge in my study as well, like, I have been away from [a course] works for almost a decade, so it's kind of hard to get it again. But I feel like in some of, like, I don't know, like the sociality, and everything is obviously a bit different from my country because my country is mostly like a Muslim country, so like, we don't do the party, it's like, not as wild and stuff like that. But yeah, again, I feel like it's, it's not that significant, like not that big of a problem.

I: Yeah understand. So, okay, any expectations you had?

P: My expectation is, I must say I don't have much, to be fair. Again, my main motivation is just I need a break.
I: Okay. Yeah.
P: This is a break, so I feel like this is like sort of my expectation.
I: Do you feel like it's really a break or do you feel more stressed because you may also get lots of homework to do now?
P: Yeah, but it still felt like a break. Because at the end of the day, like course, from school, like, it's only impacting me right, it's not impacting other people. While at work, whatever you're doing is impacting the company as a whole. So the responsibility is not that heavy. Yeah. So I still feel like this is kind of a break.
I: Yeah, so how long have you worked before?
P: Nine years.
I: Wow that's really cool. I feel you are very brave to choose to study again after working for 9 years.
P: Thank you.
I: Have you made any good friends here?
P: So obviously from class, first of all, like, during class I got to know some people and then I also joined several events hold by the uni. Yeah, and I attended to the events. But the only problem that I have is that again, I'm a mature student, so, and most of people in my class are usually like you, like they go straight from undergraduate to master. So I feel like my worry doesn't really... if I speak about my worries, like, what I'm going to do about after this, one of my biggest concerns is like the UK salary range is low and stuff like that, they're not there. Yeah. Yeah. They can't really understand. Yeah. Like, it's good to have friends like, there are some friends who I hang out with, but yeah, only at that level.
I: So like, are your friends most British or international students?
P: Most of them are international students, but I do have some British friends but that's because my housemate is, so I ended up like, knowing his friends as well.
I: Okay, cool. How do you feel about the relationships with different people, with people from different countries, like, do you feel close enough or can they understand you well?
P: At first, I don't. Yeah, I feel like it's okay. But once I like, [home country] has a society, the society here, right, and that's, that's where I've felt like always really home, but at the same time I spoke with other international students, there is also connection because we're in a foreign country together. Meanwhile, with the locals, I feel that we can be good friends, but the problem is, I feel like we're a bit hesitant to reach out to each other. Like with my housemates, I ended up like, we ended up still talking until now even though like I'm not, we no longer live together. But yeah, but I feel like they're a bit hesitant to approach you because they're not sure, they don't want to offend you. And yeah, there are so many differences.
I: Yeah it's like we both are testing which part is comfortable for both of us. But like, they don't really understand our cultures or we don't understand their cultures. They just kind of like, hold back a little bit.
P: Yeah, yeah.

I: I understand that. Yeah. So can you give me an example, like, in a situation that you feel someone really understands you, that kind of experience?
P: Um, I feel that when I started working, part-time. Um, when I start working part time, like most of my colleagues are around 50s. But they have, they have, they do have years of working experience, so whenever I speak to them about my worries, they like, they really understand my worries. When working part-time, I feel like that's the environment that kind of like gets me more compared to uni.
I: Yeah. Do you have anyone who can fully understand you here? Or in general, do you feel understood here?
P: Like, again, I don't expect anyone [understand me] yeah. Because like, we only know each other for such a short period of time. Right? And I feel like most of my friends here is we're more friends because we're hanging out together, travelling together and stuff like that. Not because we go through [something], it's different. You know, like, when we go to go through something, like that, you will have more fun.
I: Yeah I see. And could I ask about that do you feel anyone really misunderstood you?
P: Misunderstood? Not really, but I feel like I'm a very closed-off person like I'm, um, I'm very, like introvert, I'm extremely introverted. So I get that. So for example, like with my housemates, one of my housemates, he really likes parties. So he doesn't, he really doesn't understand if I need alone time. So stuff like, he would knock on my door and like, do you want to join the party or like, yeah, it sounds like, and for me, it's hard to say I don't want to. I could tell you that, I don't want to be around people.
I: I see, I understand. It's not quite like misunderstood, more like don't understand.
P: Yeah yeah.
I: So, well, after you felt he didn't understand you or at that moment, what were you thinking? or feeling? or like on an emotional level?
P: I feel like, yeah, it's just different people like we, I also don't need him to understand me fully. Like, that's alright if he doesn't get what I say. Yeah, so like, yeah, that's, again, it's not a big problem.
I: Okay. But like, so, let's say because your housemate is British and you feel he can't really understand you when you want to stay alone, will it influence you when contact with other British people? Like, will you think that people from that culture just like doing things in this way that I don't like, so I'm just gonna stay away, like this thought?
P: Um, I do have one British housemate and the other one is actually Asian. The one who really likes parties is actually the Asian one.
I: Oh, oh, sorry. Okay.
P: I think I feel like the British one really knows boundaries. So on different occasions, like I told them that please don't make me go to parties and stuff like that, so the British can get it, the Asian one cannot get it. But it's fine. Because, it's probably because they're also very young, they're in their 20s, for them, like the definition of having fun is like being together with people. Yeah. So again, like, yeah, yeah. It's just different in that so I feel like that's fine.

I: Where is your Asian housemate from?
P: He's from Singapore, so I actually, really cool, we are completely different.
I: Wow, that's amazing. Like, I was expecting that, you know, like, you both from, South-East Asia, so it's probably, you will feel closer to each other, like the language.
P: Yeah yeah.
I: Maybe just, people have different experiences at different ages.
P: Yeah, and it just means I need to find the right people, you know.
I: Yeah, sometimes it's only about the person themselves, not about anything else. Okay. So the next question will be a little bit sensitive. So as a foreigner, like, when we speak English, especially when English is not our first language, we always have some different accents or different speaking ways than British people. Like, how much do you think having an accent bother you?
P: At first, it doesn't bother me much. I was like, I'm not I'm not even trying, because my, one of my best friends back home like he, after he studied in UK, like he suddenly changed his accent. So we said, okay, and I'm like, I don't want to do that. Like I don't have, like, I have my own accent because I'm [ethnicity], yeah, my accent. I know that my accent is a little bit weird, I start to pick that up. At first, I feel like it was not a problem before work, yeah, that's not a problem. But then I started to realize it's a problem when my, some of my friends like, cannot pick up my some words that I say, so I realised I do have that accent. But it gets worse when I work. Actually, that's when I realized, oh my accent is, it can be something that hinders me from doing my work. Because so I will, for my part-time job, I work in this [] company and all of them are British. And sometimes when I speak, I need to speak like, very clearly. Otherwise, they will not get what I'm saying. So yeah, it can be a big problem. But in terms of the uni, it's no problem at all. I feel the uni, uni is more diverse.
I: Yeah. Yeah. There are lots of different people from different countries. Like we all have our own accent. So like, it's acceptable to speak in different ways.
P: Yeah yeah.
I: But when they told you to speak clearly so they can understand you, were they really trying to understand you or did you feel they didn’t make that much effort to understand you?
P: It's more like they, they tried to, if they don't understand, they will try to get me. Yeah, it's just that, you know, you know that, I'm not sure, you know we're studying English, mainly from, like watching Netflix or something. And sometimes it's a mix between American English and British English, so that's where things like mix, mix up. Sometimes you use words, that are more like we spelt them in American English, or for, for lots of things like this. Yeah, but like, they always try to understand.
I: Good good. But have you ever experienced, maybe when you're talking and then people recognized you are a foreigner and they just feel like, like, they tend to, speak to other British people but not you?
P: No no no, never, thankfully, never. That happens so rarely.
I: Yeah, of course. But Does it happen you know, not only with your friends or other students, but probably in the market or anywhere else?

P: No no, in my, in most of my friends, it's actually their English is not, I feel their English isn't like, I don't know how to put it nicely, but not as, they even more struggling in English than me. So, so I think instead of, I know most of my close friends, by close friends I mean, the people I hang out with are mostly Chinese. In fact, they ended up speaking Chinese instead.
I: They feel more comfortable maybe.
P: Yeah, yeah. So yeah, they try to speak English when they're with me, but sometimes they're speechless, so they start to speak in Chinese.
I: Yeah, because in China, we don't use English. So for Chinese people is not only about the accent, sometimes it's about vocabulary, you know people just can't find the word to say. But when you communicate with British people, they're not, umm, sorry this is quite direct, they didn't have any problem with that, with your accent, right?
P: Yeah.
I: Great. Yeah. Then when you hang out with Chinese friends and they start speaking Chinese, do you feel kind of weird or isolated?
P: Actually that's not weird, but then, like, when you think about it, I know that they're not trying to ignore me, right, they just, they just, you know, I understand that speaking English is not easy for me, and I started from elementary school, I cannot imagine, being like from China, and they don't have the primary education for English, so like, I noticed the struggle for them. So at first, I felt like 'oh, why do you change the language?', after that, I understand that there is just they're just having a hard time expressing his feeling, her feeling and, and then I feel bad because I feel like it will be more frustrating for them because they want to speak to me in English, but they cannot. So yeah, instead of feeling bad, I feel like I feel bad for them.
I: That's so nice to think in this way, you're very kind. When you interacted with other people, with your friends, do you feel they gave you enough support, they can support you? Maybe emotionally, or providing you information or helping you in something.
P: I don't rely on, I try not to rely on other people to be honest, even back home. So be like, here, like, my expectation for people is also not that high. Like, I feel like if I, if I can make friends to, at least hang out with and like I can share my uni worries, that will be more than enough. Like, I don't expect them to understand me like, because I also, I also don't do that often to them, you know, because we are going to be here for only one year. Yeah. So I understand what they say to me will be limited. But I will say that at the beginning, it's very hard to like I said, it's a bit of struggling, because again, I'm fairly introverted, right. So even if I go to uni, I don't really enjoy speaking with people, yeah, make friends with new people. I feel like it's taking so much of my energy to do that. So I feel like at the beginning, I will say that it's more difficult to, like adjust. Yeah. Because, because the friends that I have, maybe also like only one, two people that I know during the first couple of months, it was a bit challenging, because sometimes I feel like oh, I want to go out, go to this event and I want to share it with someone. But yeah, I feel like, I feel like, after a couple of months, I'd like to settle as well here. Like I feel like even if I don't have anyone I can go with, I can go alone, I can always go alone. Yeah, yeah. And then like I obviously get to know more

people and I feel like I'm not I'm actually not the one who was struggling at the beginning. I feel like everyone struggles. Yeah, but yeah, but they just, I don't know, again, like with the distance and everything we just don't want to impose on each other. So yeah, I feel like oh, maybe it's also good, sometimes I can be the one who initiates like 'How do you do, I want to hang out'.
I: Yeah. sometimes, things just happen, maybe one day you just gonna meet lots of people and make friends with them even you said you don't have high expectations to meet people. Or sometimes, having a few close friends, then that's enough, right?
P: Yeah. You don't need a lot of close friends.
I: Okay, another question is, are you living alone here, or is your family here too?
P: I'm living alone here.
I: Do you call your family quite frequently? To talk to them and share your feelings?
P: No, not really, I don't have much to speak with my family, so not really.
I: I guess you're just really independent.
P: Yeah, I'm quite independent.
I: Yeah, good. That's good. Okay, I think I have asked all questions. Thank you for sharing your stories with me, it's good to talk to you today. Thank you!
P: Thank you so much! Good luck with your study, though.

Interview 20:
I: Okay, first question is, what's your expectation and motivation for studying in the UK, or studying in [a university]?
P: So I'm doing a PhD in [research area] and I'm in my third year now. The reason for me coming to the UK to do the PhD was because of the research mainly. So because I'm from [home country], and we do not have a lot of research or opportunities in [research area], which is what I'm doing right now. And the research group that I'm part of here in the UK is one of the leading ones, so it was mainly for that reason that I'm here. Yeah.
I: Oh that's really cool. And what's your expectation for studying here?
P: Yeah, so I think in terms of expectations, I hope I find a nice job, you know, a good job after, after my PhD. And because it's such a, I think such a tough degree to go through and so much sacrifice to put in, I think it would be nice to get a job, that is, you know, a bit, but like, one of those really nice jobs on the market that you need to be very qualified to get to, even if you want to go further into academia or something. That would be one of my expectations, so going further into academia, or just getting a really nice page of qualification.
I: Yeah yeah, understand. And how long have you stayed in the UK?
P: So I have been here for my undergraduate as well. So I started in 2013, and I finished my master's in 2017, and then I had a year and half of break just working in industry. And then I came back in 2019, was when I started again, yeah.
I: It's been a long time.
P: Yeah, I've been, I've been in uni forever.
I: Me too, but I didn't really have a job or something, always in uni. Do you want to go back home after you graduate or do you wanna stay in the UK?

P: I think it depends, because I'm open to both, in my family, they're all based in [home country] and my parents and everything, so it would not be a bad idea to go back home and stay with them because they're quite elderly as well now. Or even if I do get, you know, a nice job here and kind of move forward with that even, that would be nicer at the end of the day, just depends where I get the job that I'm kind of, I would kind of prefer.
I: Yeah yeah, of course. Did you have any expectations for making friends or for conducting social relationships here before you came to the UK or before you came to [university]?
P: I think, I mean yes. I kind of wanted to live abroad you know, and have your own group of friends that you can do things with, you can go out with and have that little community, which I think I had back in [a city in south England], which was where I did my undergraduate and Master's. And even here in [university], where I have my research group and my other friends as well. So I would say yes, so I had these, this expectation of, of having my own little group of friends. And that's been yeah, I've had, I've had that in both places. Yeah.
I: Yeah, are you happy with your current social network, current social life?
P: Um, I would say yes. And I kind of like I'm quite outgoing as a person, so I have like, several different group of friends. And the one well, the one thing that I missed at the moment is maybe that most people are home for holidays and things like that. Yeah, so I missed them. But I think other than that, I think it's yeah, I am, yeah, happy with my friends.
I: That's nice. Do you mind me asking more about your friendship?
P: Yeah, go ahead.
I: Okay, thanks. So I'm quite interesting, are your friends mostly from your home country, from the same background as you or are they mostly British or other international students?
P: So I, well, I kind of, like, I have a bit of everything. I have, I had one friend who was like, from Mauritius as well, the same, like background and everything. The reason why I say I had is because while she's moved to a different place now for work. And my flatmates were all like, British. And that was quite, that was quite nice as well. So we like, I learned a lot about the proper British culture and it's interesting, because I just feel like I got a very good, like, insight of British culture where I, I think I didn't have that back in [a city in south England]. Because there I was mostly with international people, that's how my, all of my friends were international or from [home country]. But here I have, you know, also like from my office, most people are British so I do have that as well. And then I have international friends from like, postgraduate society that I've joined to, it's a bit of everything and I think I would say I get along with most like, different groups. And in, I haven't found it difficult to kind of integrate with any groups. But it might also be you know, because I've been here for so long, so I've kind of like merge a bit more with a culture now. And now like I said, you know, back in [a city in south England], I'm probably wouldn't have a lot of British friends, but now I do.
I: Yeah yeah, I really agree, yeah making friends with British people helps a lot, like

learning the culture stuff, but it's hard to join them, to hang out with them at the beginning. So when you studied in [a city in south England], you said you didn't have lots of British friends, do you think what's the reason for that? Like you didn't really have the chance to meet British people or you met them but don't feel you could be friends or something else.
P: I think in terms of [a city in south England], I think when I moved from [home country], firstly, it was the fact that you kind of like, feel like, you know, stay with [home people] a bit more. So my first year was spent just having mostly [home country] friends because we were all very new and it's kind of nice just having that support of getting everywhere with people familiar you know. I think in my second year and up until my fourth year onwards, I kind of like just had international friends. I didn't have that many British friends, almost none like, you know I knew people but I wasn't like friends friends with them. I think it's, like [a city in south England] is a very international university as well, so you'd have a lot of international people as compared to [the university city] I think, which is a lot more British people. So I think that's one of the main reasons why because there's so many international people, you would just be, you would just find yourself in one of those groups. And I'm not, I'm just one, I'm just trying to like, remember why. And I think just being in that group of international all the time, doesn't really let you kind of like know more about how British culture really operates. Even in my flats, like, you know, every time I was put in a flat, it was with international people rather than in a British flat. Whereas here, you know, I got to live in a flat where there's just like, all British people, so it made a big difference. I would say I think, I'm just trying to think like, I think, I think I would say it's mainly, you know, more like, a good split between British and international people, so you would tend to be more friends with the international people. And also, I had another, I had another reason, I think the second reason would be, I think, when I just arrived, and I was still fairly new to the UK, it just took me a while to kind of like, you know, understand a bit more about the British culture and really feel like you can integrate as friends. So it was a mixture of that. So that's why mainly had international friends.
I: Yeah.
P: And I think yeah, I think it's, you do it subconsciously, I think you don't decide, like you know because you feel more, that's how I felt, like you're more familiar with people from home. And I think especially for me here working with, like indirect contact with British people every day, which is not something I had when I was in [a city in south England]. Because you know, I would go to lectures and I would come back home and stuff, there was not much, there was not really this every day touch with them you know. And here is my supervisors, my colleagues and my office so I am just in the British culture all the time, so it really makes a difference. Yeah, yeah.
I: Yeah, yes definitely. Thank you for sharing these thoughts and experience with me, I feel what you talked are really really great. Yeah, and because you have stayed in the UK for a long time, in [a city in south England] and [a city in southwest England], I wonder how you think about your experiences studying and living in the UK?
P: Yeah, okay. I think I really liked the fact that I came to the UK to study because I

feel like I was very shy and very kind of in my shell when I was in [home country], so for me, that made a big difference. Specially when I went to [a city in south England], I had this whole, like, I didn't know I could be, I could have like more leadership kind of roles. And I was very surprised you know, when you have like these societies, you know, extracurricular societies, and I could, I was finding myself being projected as a person who could be one of the presidents of those societies, and I was like, 'wow', like, when I was in [home country], I was known as the shy person in her corner, not having a lot to say, like, mostly keeping to myself and being very quiet. And here I was kind of like, seeing as this, so for me, that was a very big jump, in terms of like personality development, being this like very coming out as a shy person and being like this now really outgoing, confident person that I wasn't. So that was one of the main highlights of my time in [a city in south England] I think. And you know, having that little bit of confidence that I've moved from home, I've kind of lived on my own, I've made friends, and, you know, it sounds, it's daunting, it's scary. And then you go in, you're like, 'Oh, I've done it, so it's not like that difficult', and then I kind of had a bit of time working in the UK as well, after my master's. So I, again, I worked with a company that just had like British people, you know, because they wouldn't sponsor visas. So it was just people from local, locally. And, again, you know, just being able to kind of get along with them and really integrate myself and being here was also boosting confidence like 'Wow, I can work in the environment as well, and not just study'. I then moved back to [home country] for like a year and a half. And during that time, I was like, kind of, like just adapting again to [home country] life. That was, you could see the difference, because I think [home people] in general, are a bit more tolerant of, you know, they would think in the sense of 'okay, so I don't want to upset everyone, so I'm gonna do this kind of thing', and my thought was, 'well, I don't like this, I'm not going to do it'. Because I've picked this up from here, and that was a bit different, you know, family members, kind of like 'what?'. And then I came back to the UK in 2019, and for the first six month, everything was like great, you'd have an office, you have a new well job in terms of your PhD now, and just getting along with life, trying to adapt. I'd be honest, I was a bit lonely at the start in [university] here because I think I compared it a lot to [a city in south England] and say, you know, 'oh, no, I feel a bit left out', for some reason, I didn't feel like I had a good, like proper social start here. I had friends from my office mostly, but not like, you know, it's all very new and kind of felt a little bit lonely at the start. But then the pandemic hit, which was even worse. And everyone went home and I was stuck here for four months by myself with just one other flatmate because I think [home country] had closed its borders. And then I did spend about 10 months in [home country] working from home during the second year of my PhD because lockdowns and everything, they were really getting to me here, and my supervisors thought, 'okay, it's probably best if you spend some time with your family'. And then I came back last year, in may 2021. And that's when I think I really kind of merged with like [university] life and really merged with being here. Because then what changed was, you know, I started hanging out at the pub with my friends, which is something I never did before. You know, and then I started doing other things like going hiking with the outdoor society

and also having like, going clubbing with my flatmates while I did that in my undergraduate years, but more like, kind of having it as a main thing in life. And watching movies with the flatmates and kind of really having that feel like you are living in, I don't know, like, feel like you've kind of adapted. It only came last year, you know, really came last year. So yeah, this is, I think most of it.
I: I had similar experiences as you like, I really understand what you're saying. Because I came here, like my first time coming here was to do my final year because I was an exchange student. And they, it was like, I would say, really, really hard because I came here like halfway, and they already had their friends. And I was the only exchange student in the department and none really knew that I needed help or something. So I had no idea what I was going to do, I joined the lectures, but no one talked to me because I was just a stranger there you know. So at the beginning, I was alone and I felt so hard to make friends and find someone to talk. And then, I met a girl in my course, because we had to discuss some questions in that lecture, so I kinda had to join her group, because I sat next to them. And this girl was very nice very friendly, we just talked a little bit so she knew that I was new to this country something something, so she were like 'tell me if you need help', and she did always check on me, message me and ask if I need help on assignments. Yeah yeah, she helped me a lot actually.
P: That's nice.
I: Yeah, that's really nice. I just feel I was lucky. And also, all of my flatmates were really really nice too. They were all Europeans, and I had more difficulties adapting to the new environment, especially in language. So I didn't really join them at the beginning, I didn't know how to talk to them, so I didn't really want to talk as well. But like one day a girl just knocked on my door and said they were having party in the kitchen and asked if I wanted to join them. Of course I said no because you know I didn't know how to perform, what to talk. But she just said something like 'don't worry you don't have to talk to us, you can just sit there and drink'. So you know I just felt less stressful and joined them then we became good friends. Yeah.
P: Yeah, okay, that sounds nice too. I hope you had a good time.
I: Yeah, yeah, and after that I always hang out with them and so my English improved a lot too. Yeah, like my life just changed a lot from then.
P: Okay, that sounds, yeah, that sounds similar, you know you have that when something changes and you're like 'yep, changed'.
I: Yeah. Especially like the, you were talking about that you started going to pubs with friends, and that's what you never did before. Same, I never did it before I came here. But like it's kind of like I don't know, because I interviewed some people before and they were saying something like British people like drinking, and that's a main way they socialise with other people. So yeah we have to do things like that so we can meet people so we can join them. You know, it's funny.
P: I mean, yeah, like in terms of [home country] culture, I think if you know, I had this thought the other day, I was like my dad comes to visit me I'll bring I'll take him to the pub. And then I thought that's such a weird idea for him you know. Because [home country] is such a conservative kind of country, I can't imagine what my dad

would feel like if his daughter is taking him to drink at a pub. He would you know, but I think my parents have kind of accepted the fact that there's been a lot of light changes and they're not necessarily bad, it's just in a way of life in the UK. Because when I thought of this and I was like, ‘yeah, it's such a weird thing’, but it’s so normal now to just think to do that. But at the same time, you know in [home country], if you kind of like I don't know, like just the idea of drinking is a bit like looked upon as not that nice. I mean we do drink socially and stuff, now it's more like it's happening and stuff but before you know people would look down on you like ‘oh no’. And I just remember the first time I came to the UK the very first thing I saw one day just getting out of my accommodation was you know, there was a night out before and there was all these bottles and things that just left on the floor. And that like gave me a shock I was like, oh my god, what is this, and now you know after such a long time, it's just like, it doesn't feel like it was such a bad thing. Yeah, yeah.

I: Yeah, I know, it's so different, like something is normal here, but my parents will never believe I will do it you know. It's not like bad, it's just, things change a lot.

P: Yeah, yeah, I know what you mean.

I: Yeah, and also you were talking about you became more confident, that’s a nice thing, that’s great.

P: Yeah, yeah.

I: And I wonder if you feel that doing a PhD is a different experience as doing a Master or Undergraduate.

P: Um, so I mean, yes, there are like differences in terms of, in undergrad you kind of you know, have lectures and seminars and things like that and attend that and then learn from those. Whereas I think when I'm doing research right now is kind of like just me having this project, I'm working on my own, and I don't have anyone to kind of check on me every day, and things like I have, I have meetings with my supervisors every week, which is very useful. And you know they're very like guide, they guide you quite a lot, they let you they do like, they are there at all times if you need them, but I think the difference is you have more independence in terms of your project, in terms of you know how you're doing your own thing.

I: Yeah, yeah. Then how do you feel about your social network or relationships? Like, is it easier than before to make friends and stay connected with people in the department or in your research group?

P: Yes, I think so. I think this is just, I don't know if it's just me, I have like, you know because in my group there are loads of people of my age, age group, even if we have postdocs we are all still have the same age group ish. So now I'm saying, like, I have a good group of people at the same age in my office, which is quite nice. But at the same time, you know I've been able to maintain friendships with people that I've met from postgraduate society and also been able to maintain friendships with my flatmate. So these were like, and also you know my other friends who are from [home country], or who are from other places, who are [home people] but in the UK as well, so yeah I've been able to maintain friendships with a lot of different groups.

I: Oh that's really good.

P: But I've had friends from here as well, who kind of like doing a PhD but they are all kind of you know not really in touch with anyone else, because it's depends on the types of departments they are in and stuff like that, so I think yeah that's also quite important yeah.
I: Yeah I see, it very depends on the subject you do and the department you are in. I mean, we are quite lucky that we've made friends, some people could feel really lonely you know.
P: Yes yes, exactly.
I: Okay, so next question, did you have any experience of feeling understood by someone? Like, at a moment or in a situation that you feel understood.
P: Yeah I've had, I've had both like where I feel like okay this person really understands me and then I've had moments with someone as far as like yeah this person just doesn't understand me.
I: Oh really, I'm very happy to hear you say yes, could you tell me some examples?
P: Yes, like it's, I think this one comes more with the kind of connection you have with someone though, so you know from what I've kind of seen, as you can have a lot of like good friends and close friends but it's interesting that you have new meet up like one person that really understands you and I think it's more comes from like being similar to that person, like quite on the same like way of thinking, way of being and things like that, so I think it comes from that. And I'm just I'm trying to get like yeah, I feel like, I've heard that like feel very understood and very, very like you know you kind of like, you know when you meet your best friend and you're like yeah, this is why we are best friends, this is exactly how like I've kind of like had, 'oh my God this person really get me', and it's such a nice it's such a nice feeling of belonging, I think.
I: Yeah, yeah. Do you remember anything or like an moment that you had this feeling?
P: Yeah I think it's kind of like me having confusion about like something and then bringing it up and saying you know, like 'I don't understand why', like there was a particular situation, I was kind of trying to understand and I was like I don't get this or I don't understand that and then, you know the kind of way that the topic was welcomed rather than just shushed over or not like listen to, or like there's a level to which your friends can hear you when you talk, I don't know if that makes sense, but there's a level to which someone can understand what you're saying, but there's that other level where someone just really understands what you're saying. And that, like that attention that you need to be able to resolve this problem, or something that kind of dedication and how friendship, and I think that's what I think it was like you know this person is really my friend, like they're really here for me to understand me going through a bad time and me going for a happy time, both times there's still the same kind of person, which really is a nice feeling.
I: Yeah, sometimes it' just a moment that you feel this person understand you very well, but sometimes it's more like, like after going through a lot of things and it's still this person with you, that's how you feel this is my best friend and feel really understood. Right?

P: Yeah absolutely.
I: Yeah yeah, and do you mind telling me your experience of being misunderstood?
P: Oh yeah, that's not such a pleasant one because, again, this is one of my good friend, but I think it comes more from a place of, not really like misunderstanding your actions for it being like a bad day, I'll give you an example which is like really it's really funny so please don't take it too seriously because I was pretty like 'what! Are you serious?' when I heard it. So I have this one friend who is you know lovely, very caring and everything, but sometimes can misunderstand the way some situations go and make a bit of assumptions, and this is why things go a bit like... So I was meeting up with like two of my close friends and this one person included, and you know when we met we kind of like with eat with like some you know banter, talk and everything and just kind of like tell each other what's going on really in each other's lives. And my friend was very annoyed with me for kind of like checking my phone a few times and the reason why I was doing it was because I was you know, it was late, and I was going to walk back home at 11 ish and my phone had died so I was just trying to like you know, make it come back alive and so I was like switching it on and hope it stays, so it was a bit like it, I didn't, I wasn't even on the phone texting someone, it was just there, and I think she really misunderstood that. So she really was like that was rude of you to not listen and even tell me that was rude of me to go to the toilet when someone was talking and I was like well you know I can't help it, I had to use the toilet. So that was that part and then I think there was also kind of like us having a movie night or something, and some people who came over for the movie not wanted to have a bit of a nap or something like, you know they're watching a movie and they kind of feel tired or something. And my friend was like yeah they're not interested in this so we're not going to invite them the next time and was like, I was like no, you know, like that's not how it is like, it's fine even if they had a bit or like they don't have to sit and watch the thing all the time, like it's fine it doesn't matter, and I think that's where we had a bit of a misunderstanding a little bit. Like, she doesn't understand where I'm coming from and I don't understand where she's coming from I think she's more of kind of like maintain a bit more of a social appearance, like Oh, we need to be this way in front of other people and stuff and for me it's more like well, these are my close friends I'm just going to do whatever I want to do.
I: Yeah yeah, it just reminded me something that once I was watching a film with my friends in our flat, and I was texting on my phone tho, and one of them did complain about it, so I was like sorry I will stop. But like yeah, it's just a small thing, so I didn't take it seriously.
P: Yeah but mine became an argument and a fight.
I: Oh really!
P: Yeah, you know like, for me it's like such a small thing like you know checking your phone or something but it dragged on, yeah, and I was just like oh my God like so it in that way became a negative experience, because it was like it's such a small thing yeah.

I: Maybe you're too close so, like very close friends always argue about small things but after that you're still friends.
P: Yeah. Oh yeah I've had like negating the experiences in terms of like you know someone making a plan with you to kind of meet up the next day. And then you kind of wait for them to message you the whole day you don't hear from them, because you know you kind of like you have plans to meet on a Sunday let's say so you'd expect to at least hear from them the day before to know what time we're meeting or something or, even on the Sunday in the morning and then they don't message you so I kind of was like okay well they didn't message me, so I think maybe they will not gonna be able to make it. And even when you messaged them they're not replying so I was like okay well in that case, then I'm just gonna go and meet my other friend and that became such a big thing as well. Yeah we never spoke again after this because the person got really angry that I made other plans and I was like well, I mean, I did message you to ask you, about the time, and you messaged me at 3pm on the Sunday, you know, and I have no clue now because I've made plans with other people, because I thought well you're not going to show up because it's like the whole day's gone.
I: Yeah. So I wanna, also wanna ask where this person is from.
P: Oh, I don't I didn't remember, but that was an international.
I: Oh okay. I had a similar experience, so someone just asked me if I wanted to meet on Thursday, so I was like ok, but she didn't tell me when and where to meet, so I thought she probably would tell me on Wednesday or something. But no, she only messaged me at 9 pm on Thursday and said let's go out to get a drink, you know, I can't understand that.
P: Yeah for me it's, it's rude. Because I, you know if I don't hear from you, I will assume that you're not going to make it and especially if I've messaged you as well and you're not replying to me.
I: Yeah, that's even worse.
P: For me, the worst thing is they even check their phone and they still didn't reply, they check and they didn't reply, so I was like yeah they're definitely not going to show up you know, and I get the message and it's like, I'm like well I can't make it anymore, and then, when I contact them again they're like well I'm busy and I'm going to be busier and that's it and we're done. And I'm like is that really that bad you know because and even when you try to explain to them, try to talk to them they're just like I don't care I don't want to talk to you again. And it's very shocking for me, because I was just like I don't even understand what I've done.
I: That's very, um very, you know at least you can talk to me to say what happened, or we can explain to each other, but not like this.
P: It, it's like, do you not see what you've done here for me, and even you know I didn't mention in the message, like, I thought you weren't going to make it because it's Sunday 2pm so yeah I do have, like other plans now I'm sorry. I still don't like I mean, I think I managed to talk to the person afterwards, and they were like oh yeah if I was in your place I do the same thing. But then they still don't talk to you, and they still like hold the grudge and I'm just like I don't know what else to do because I've apologized and I didn't even think it was my fault but okay.

I: Sorry to hear this, that's very weird, but yeah ok, people can be weird so.
P: Yeah and without like, I think communication is quite important as well, but if you don't have that, like you know you don't get it, like I've also had that with other friends like the one friend like saying the things about like you know checking the phone and things I was like is that just it, like is that the problem, is that something else like you're not saying or whatever, because sometimes it could be something deeper that they've been passive aggressive about or I don't know but, yeah that's it.
I: Yeah where is your close friend, this friend from?
P: Again, international person.
I: Yeah okay, yeah maybe people just have different thoughts about things. Like the thing you said, you were just checking on your phone, but some people don't have the sense, like, I have to go home before getting too dark, so they don't know you were just checking the time.
P: Yeah but like, the thing of, it's fine if you think this but to actually like you know, bring it up and tell your friend, this is bad you shouldn't be doing that, I think at this point we're all adults and it's a bit too much like, and I was listening, I was listening to what the other person was saying. Um, I just thought that was a bit like too much because you know it's a bit difficult to like I can't tell my friend, like 'oh you're walking on the street and you're walking like this, you should walk like this', you know what I mean like, yeah I think that's a bit too much, and it's not like I was really on the phone talking to someone all the time, which is different than, I agree that's like too much, but, just, you just being on your phone and just kind of like checking here, and that does not make you like, you're completely ignoring something. So I think yeah, that was a bit of a stretch I think yeah.
I: Yeah yeah, understand. Okay, so is there anything else that happened to you, but not with your friends, maybe like when you were shopping, or when you go to other places?
P: No, not really, no. Most of the things are yeah that's kind of like normal everyday life yeah.
I: Yeah, great. And the next question is, did you have met any difficulties with English?
P: Not, not so much, I think, because we have studied English, I have studied English for quite a long time since I was very young, until now, so for me, it's kind of still part of everyday life in a way, you know, especially when you go to school and everything we learned was in English already apart from French which was in French, but everything else you know, yeah everything else is in English already, so it's not, it's not a big jump for me, it's just, the big jump is having to speak English outside of school as well you know, and when you interact with people, maybe at the start, I used to feel a bit tired at the end of the day off, you know, have to speak English all the time. But I think now it's fine, now it's like it's a very normal thing, and when I meet my [home country] friends and we speak in [mother tongue] then it's a bit like, it can get, it can take me a little bit of time to get into it because I speak English so much, so it's funny we were just laughing about it, like oh my God we are struggling a little bit, but yeah. But other than that, not too much. No.

I: Yeah, I see. But you know like even if we learn English for a long time, we still have our own accent, or we speak in a different way than British people. Do you feel having an accent is a problem or will cause problems for you in your life?
P: Um, you mean, um, I don't know, I don't know, I don't know like so far it hasn't, so that's, I think so? I don't know if it has, I think, so far, it hasn't, so I think that's like you know.
I: That's fine, that's fine. It's good you don't have this kind of experience.
P: Yeah I try to remember, I don't think I have it, or if I have I don't know about it so.
I: Yeah probably just didn't realize it. But that's also good you won't be unhappy about it.
P: Yeah yeah.
I: Okay, the last question, do you feel supported by your friends and by the university? Could be here in [a city in southwest England] or in [a city in south England].
P: I feel very supported by my supervisors, which is very nice. Because I think they care a lot about not just your work, but your well-being as well and anytime there's kind of an issue or something I can bring it up to them, and they've been very supportive. I feel very supported in my group as well, like if there's a problem and I bring it up, I feel heard and listened to and that people would be willing to help. Even among my friends definitely. Um but you know you, there's always there's always like some instances where you could be met with someone who's not that like, and you wouldn't know until you know you've kind of gotten into a situation where they are meant to show up in an in a caring nice way and they just don't, but you won't know that until you've kind of had that experience, but I think other than that, I would say yes in general.
I: Great, that's great. Thank you.

Interview 21:
I: What were your expectations for studying abroad?
P: Um, expectations, well, to travel to different places and countries and have lots of friends. However, when I first came there, I found myself feeling quite lonely and without many friends, especially [because] I lived in a studio. And also at first, I was worried about the pandemic and didn’t want to go out to social with people. And after that, I did go out more often and meet people, so I thought it shouldn’t be too hard for me to make friends, but (still I didn’t have many friends). I think it’s also because I didn't know anyone before, I didn't socialize in the freshman group. So when I arrived, I found that I didn't have any friends, I didn’t know anyone here.
I: So how did you meet your friend? I mean you have couples of friends now, right?
P: Well, I will say kind of like just happened coincidently. When I first arrived here, I did, just lots of stupid things happened to me, like my computer was flooded, my suitcase was lost, and you know just lots of these kinds of unlucky things. And my expectations for myself were too high, I had travelled abroad many times before, so I did not prepare in advance, like finding a companion in advance, or getting to know anyone. I chose a date in October randomly, and there was no one with me. I also had

some classmates in the language class, but they, I found that I didn't hang out with them very well, with some of them.
I: So you didn't have any friends for a while when you first came here?
P: Pretty much. I asked some of them to have dinner together at first, but they weren't good guests. For example, I bought the ingredients by myself and then cooked dinner by myself, no one came to help me, like washing the dishes and clean up after dinner. I just didn't feel like I fit in with them, I didn't feel I was one of them. It was just that I asked you to eat, but at least help me to clean up, because there were a lot of people, the room was really messy after eating, I had to clean up for a long time, so after that I never asked them to come over again.
I: Yeah, yeah, understand, that doesn't sound good.
P: Then there were some coincidences, something like that. You know in the beginning, my boyfriend at the time, now ex-boyfriend, was more concerned about that I would meet with other boys, since it's easier for me to make friends with boys, so before going abroad he told me he was worried. And I was a little stubborn, so I didn't make any male friends at the beginning. And also I had no female friends because he said I went abroad to study so I shouldn't always think about making friends, this and that. It made me feel like socializing was a mistake. Because I felt, at that time I felt not a lot of people here were really studying, like you know, they just wanted a degree but didn't plan to study hard. So they often say "let's play cards tomorrow", or "call you to drink next time", which I didn't like. Later, I met a girl who was an undergraduate student, and I was with her a lot more often.
I: Are most of the people you interact with here from [home country]?
P: Um, I know a girl who's from Malaysia, but I am not very familiar with her. We exchanged [number] but that's all, I don't know her much.
I: Ok, I see.
P: Yeah, probably like people around me also think [home country] students studying abroad is a little bit strange, like they have good family, like very good very rich family. I met someone he was saying something like, annual income less than 2,000,000 is poor, so yeah, I just met a lot of people like this. So, I just feel we're not the same, we don't have anything in common, like what you want to do and they want to do are different. So I wanted to study but they asked me to drink or play cards, and I said I didn't want to stay up late, I have to go to bed early. I think that might be the reason that I didn't make any friends, it's a simple reason but that's true.
I: Understand. Did you think about making friends with people from other countries and sort of getting out of the group, the circle?
P: Maybe, I didn't have much confidence in my English, and I also didn't have any chances to know other people I think. Besides, because of the COVID, you know like people who're from other countries, they didn't have high awareness in terms of preventive measures, so I didn't feel too comfortable to contact with them.
I: Okay, yes I see, especially in your course, mainly [home country] students in your course right, so yeah there're not a lot of chances.
P: And maybe it was because I had high expectations, because I had travelled abroad before so I thought it would be a smooth trip, but then I had problems with my

luggage and then I felt lonely when I first arrived here.
I: Okay. Why did you choose to study abroad?
P: Because I think it's harder to do a master in [home country], like the exams we need to take are hard. So I didn't think I can go to a top university in [university], which means I can't find a good job after masters. So I just thought maybe do a master abroad.
I: Yeah, ok, I did my masters in the UK too, but my reason was like I wanted to learn English, you know like I don't want to always feel English is a problem for me. So I thought I could be more confident to speak English after staying in an English-speaking country.
P: I felt embarrassed about this, it's just my English, I didn't know how to speak it, like my oral English was not good, it was a little different from my expectations. Like at the beginning, I couldn't communicate with others over the phone and couldn't understand them, then I found that I wasn't so strong and adaptable. Even that day when I went to apply for a visa, I didn't understand why that guy just refused to let me do it, so I couldn't do it. Another time was, I was calling a cab, I described [the location] for a long time, but the driver didn't understand what I was talking about, and eventually I failed to get a cab. Yeah, those were the things that made me feel defeated and felt like I wasn't as good as I thought, in language.
I: Yes, I understand that, like you can read, you can write, and you passed the English test, but you still can't communicate with others in daily life.
P: Yes, I always thought my English was very good, my classmates, my parents thought my English was good too, but after being abroad, the experiences made me think I need to study English more. Because of this language barrier, there is no way to deal with the things that happened, especially at the beginning, like it's hard to make friends, not being able to make friends with people from other countries. In the beginning, my friends had some foreign friends, but I didn't have the confidence to communicate with them. When we were together, I just didn't speak at all, or ask others to translate for me.
I: I know, but I think that's normal, when there're other [home country] people around, I also don't want to speak English sometimes, it's like I'm more concerned what if I don't speak well or something.
P: Yeah, just some of them did their undergraduates here, and their English is good, is better, so I asked them to translate for me. Maybe I just haven't been here for long enough, maybe it'll be better if I stay here for longer.
I: Yeah, sometimes it's just you need an opportunity. So when I first came here, I was surrounded by foreigners and I didn't know any [home country] people, so I had to speak English every day and gradually I could communicate with people.
P: Yes, that's what I need I think, an environment. Like the apartment I lived in was almost all [home people], the apartment I lived in was literally full of [home country] people.
I: Really, that's weird. Yeah so there's no environment for you to speak English. What other difficulties have you encountered besides the language?
P: Well, another one was that I didn't want to cook. At first I was quite happy to cook,

but then I just didn't want to cook anymore. So I wanted to find someone to dine with, you know I didn't want to cook by myself or eat by myself.
I: Yeah, yeah, cooking for oneself is really boring, me too, like I love cooking but sometimes I just don't want to, like I can just cook some quick food if there's only me eating.
P: Yeah, so I ended up with that the girl who was doing undergraduate, cooking together, eating together, spending time with each other. I can particularly understand why lots of students want to find a partner here, it's very lonely.
I: Yeah yeah, it's like food will taste better if you're eating with someone else.
P: Yeah, I felt much better when I had that girl, a companion.
I: Yes, true, having a friend you can get along with makes people feel less lonely. The next question is, did you have any experiences that made you feel someone understood you very well? Like at a moment or.
P: In the UK? No. I don't even think anyone can particularly understand me at home.
I: Oh, no? Not a single one?
P: But there's, like in some circumstances when someone says they understand you just to make you feel better, but I don't know if they do understand or not.
I: Oh I see, you can just tell me something like this if you want.
P: So like, when I had trouble with my parents, or I was worried that I would fail something, and then I told my friend, and he said he understood me, and that he knew why I was worried, like this. But then I wondered if he just said it to make me happy.
I: I see, but I mean maybe as long as you believe he will understand you, then he will understand you. Like you know, you can trust him because at least he's trying to understand, even if only to make you happy. Okay, then can you give me an example of a time you thought someone really misunderstood you?
P: A lot, I will say a lot. It's just that I feel like I'm not good at making friends with people of the same sex. What often happens is that they misunderstand me and then leave me.
I: Can you be more specific?
P: Well, I feel that no one in the UK can understand me, while my friends back home understand me more. So, people who go abroad have different family backgrounds, which makes things relatively complicated, and they are relatively independent too. I thought I was quite independent before, but after being abroad, I realised that I might not be so independent. And here, I feel like making friends is, like a lot of people aren't serious about making friends. I know someone who is older than me, she was, like at the beginning, she was saying that she only made friends with people who can help her, this kind of thing. And I feel there're quite a lot of people are like this, so it is difficult to have like real friends here.
I: Well, people we met here are all at different ages, they came here for different reasons, like we're definitely gonna meet all kinds of, different kinds of people, so it's normal and of course it won't be easy to make good friends. And you're only here for a short period of time, and a lot of people probably don't want to make friends even, which make things harder ofc.
P: Yes, exactly. But I am a person who makes friends sincerely, so I felt very

uncomfortable and misunderstood a lot. There is, so there's a thing about the 'older girl'. I know her because of the 'undergraduate girl', then the 'older girl' thought I was 'competing for attention' from the 'undergraduate girl', like she thought I wanted to be the girl's best friend, that I wanted to be the centre of the world, something like that. But I thought I was more sincere to the 'undergraduate girl', but the 'older girl' was like she wanted something from the girl, and she was very good at flattering, and then the 'undergraduate girl' thought the 'older girl' really appreciated her. But obviously I took care of her all the time, just because I wasn't adulatory, so this 'undergraduate girl' thought this 'older girl' was better to her. And on her [the undergraduate girl] birthday, I prepared a gift in advance, and I cooked a meal for her. While the older girl didn't even know that day was her birthday, she literally was the last one who knew, and she just came to eat with us. However, the undergraduate did not thank me, she also said that the rice I cooked was a little dry, so I felt very sad, very aggrieved. I just didn't like to say what I've done for her, but I did do a lot of things.

I: Um, sorry, I don't know what to say, yeah, it's really bad, you did a lot but she only said the rice was too dry.

P: Yeah, and then when I told her about it, she asked me if I thought they didn't see what I did, and what she meant was that I wanted to be the centre of the group, like I wanted everyone's attention something like that. And I thought it was outrageous, so I stopped hanging out with them.

I: Yeah, I'm so sorry to hear that, she just didn't see what you had done, she didn't understand. Anyway. The next question is, have you ever been treated differently because of your English accent when you talk to British people or people from other countries?

P: Yes, quite a few. But none of them are special, like I just get used to them. One time, I was with a friend, and she was wearing a hat that said Captain something, and an old man thought her hat looked pretty, so he asked her something, and she said she got it from Plymouth. And then the old woman next to him, his wife, asked him, 'do they speak English', and the old man said, 'no, they don't'.

I: Oh no that's sad, but also a little bit funny you know.

P: Yeah, it's funny when we think about it now, but we were quite shocking at that time. And another time we were on a train, and somehow we had to change to another train suddenly, like the broadcast was saying that we had to get off and change s train, but we couldn't understand so we asked a boy sitting in front of us. He was patient and told us what to do, but a British lady sitting next to him was very impatient, she threw her glasses on the table and asked the boy why he always talked to us, and said we were too noisy.

I: This old lady didn't even talk to you?

P: No, she just said to the British guy, "Why do you keep talking to them?" and she said something like if he didn't answer us, we wouldn't have anyone to ask, we wouldn't continue asking.

I: That's horrible! How did you feel at that moment? What were you thinking?

P: Well we didn't really understand at that time, at the beginning we thought this old

lady was saying that the boy wasn't explaining it well to us, but then we realized, just thought about it, that she was saying, ‘why are you keeping talking to them, they don't understand you anyway’.

I: It's so unfriendly, I’m sorry to hear. How did this experience affect your life later on?

P: I kinda just let it go, it doesn't matter, like I don't mind much anymore. That is, even I can’t speak well I have accent, only they will feel uncomfortable, there’s no influence on me. And I still have to use English, I still have to communicate with them, I still have to go to dinner and order food and stuff, so I don't feel anything.

I: That's great.